

INTRODUCTION TO THE TESTIMONY OF Moshe Shutan (1924–2006)

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Introduction

On May 2, 1993, Moshe Shutan gave his testimony in Tel Aviv for the Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies.¹ His Hebrew-language narrative encompasses several central themes pertinent to the Jewish experience during the Holocaust, including resistance efforts, clandestine activities within ghettos, the decision-making processes behind ghetto escapes to forest hideouts, and the complexities of partisan warfare.

Shutan's role as a liaison between the Narocz forest in western Belarus and the Vilna Ghetto was pivotal. He facilitated the movement of individuals from the confines of the ghetto to forest-based partisan units, a function that has been historically underrepresented in scholarship. This topic of Jewish partisan liaisons remains a relatively unexplored aspect of Holocaust studies, often relegated to the periphery of broader narratives concerning underground resistance and partisan activities. Thus, Shutan's extensive and detailed testimony, comprising twelve tapes, provides a valuable opportunity to shed light on this critical yet often overlooked facet of Jewish resistance.

Of particular significance in Shutan's account are his interactions with key figures from opposing spheres of the Jewish response to Nazi persecution. For example, his encounters with Yitzhak Wittenberg, commander of the Vilna Ghetto underground, juxtaposed against his meetings with Jacob Gens, head of the Judenrat (Jewish Council), offer unique insights into the tensions and complexities that characterized Jewish leadership and resistance strategies during this period.²

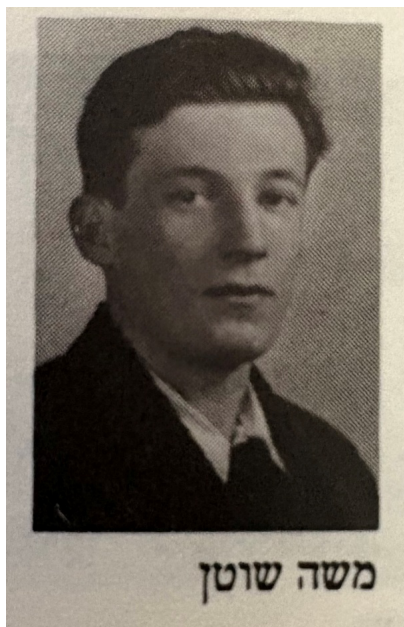
This critical edition will examine, inter alia, three fundamental aspects emerging from Shutan's testimony, which provide significant insights into the broader context of Jewish resistance during the Holocaust: Shutan's role as a liaison between ghettos and

¹ Moshe Shutan, testimony, May 2, 1993, Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies, mssa.hvt.3384. He was interviewed by Anita Tarsi and Nathan Beyrak.

² On those issues, see Yitzhak Arad, *Under the Red Banner: USSR Jews Fighting against Nazi Germany* (Tel-Aviv: Ministry of Security Publishing, 2008), 252–264.

forest-based partisan units, his perspective on the tensions between the Judenrat and ghetto underground movements, and his daily experiences as a Jewish partisan operating within predominantly non-Jewish partisan units.

These aspects are particularly salient as they illuminate the complex dynamics of Jewish resistance, the challenges faced by those attempting to navigate between different spheres of action, and the intricate relationships between various Jewish response strategies to the Nazi horrors. By examining Shutan's testimony through these lenses, we can gain a more nuanced understanding of the multifaceted nature of Jewish resistance during this period, as well as the personal and collective dilemmas faced by individuals caught between different modes of survival and resistance.



Moshe Shotten as a young man, from his book *Ghetto and Woods*

Historical Background

The town of Święciany (Lithuanian: Švenčionys) is situated approximately eighty kilometers northeast of Vilna (Vilnius). On the eve of World War II, the town had a population of about nine thousand residents, with Jews constituting roughly one-third of the total. The Jewish community was predominantly concentrated in the town center, clustered around the market square and the *shul hoyf* (synagogue courtyard).³

³ Shmuel Spector, "Święciany," in *The Encyclopedia of Jewish Communities in Poland*, Vol. 8: Vilna, Białystok, and Nowogródek Districts (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 2005), 600–608; "Święciany," in *The*

Following the Ribbentrop-Molotov Pact, Soviet forces occupied Świąciany in the latter half of September 1939. The Soviet regime systematically dismantled Jewish communal institutions. On June 28, 1941, in the wake of Operation Barbarossa, German forces reached Świąciany. The arrival of the German army, accompanied by Lithuanian collaborators, heralded a period of intense persecution of the Jewish population. Under the pretext of forced labor conscription, many Jews were abducted and subsequently murdered. The remaining Jewish population was subjected to a series of discriminatory measures, including mandatory registration, the compulsory wearing of white armbands, and forced labor for all men aged sixteen to fifty.⁴

A pivotal event occurred on September 27, 1941, when several thousand Jews from Świąciany were forcibly relocated to the Poligon camp near Nowe Świąciany.⁵ This group was destined for execution as part of the “Holocaust by bullets,”⁶ a process that continued in this camp until October 8. In Świąciany proper, a small ghetto was established, housing approximately five hundred individuals. The ghetto inhabitants, devastated by the loss of relatives and friends, were acutely aware of the mass executions at Poligon.

The ghetto was encircled by barbed wire fencing and guarded by both Lithuanian and Jewish police forces. A Judenrat (Jewish Council) administered the ghetto’s internal affairs. In his testimony, Shutan refers to the head of the Judenrat, Moshe Gordon, who was appointed to this position due to his connections with the local Lithuanian authorities. Shutan characterizes Gordon as a principled individual who endeavored to assist the ghetto inmates and was generally respected by the Jewish prisoners.⁷

Underground in Świąciany

Upon the outbreak of the war, a cohort of young Jews from Świąciany convened to deliberate on their course of action under the Nazi duress. Constrained by familial responsibilities, fleeing was not a viable option. Consequently, they resolved to resist the German occupation, as Shutan recounts: “And our decision was made that if we

United States Holocaust Memorial Museum Encyclopedia of Camps and Ghettos, 1933–1945, Vol. II, Part A, Lithuania Region (Generalkommissariat Litauen), ed. Martin Dean (Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press 2012), 1127–1129.

⁴ On the Holocaust in Lithuania, see Christoph Dieckmann, *Deutsche Besatzungspolitik in Litauen 1941–1944*, 2 vols. (Göttingen: Wallstein, 2011); Yitzhak Arad, *The Holocaust in the Soviet Union* (Lincoln and Jerusalem: University of Nebraska Press and Yad Vashem, 2009).

⁵ In late September 1941, Jews from towns in the Vilna district, including Świąciany, were deported to an abandoned military camp known as Poligon, near the town of Nowe Świąciany (New Švenčionys). Approximately eight thousand Jews were concentrated there. Except for a small group of skilled workers, in October of 1941, the inmates were led in groups outside the camp, shot into large pits, and buried there, some while still alive.

⁶ On the Holocaust by bullets during World War II, see, for example, the interesting work of Yahad-In Unum, an organization whose mission is to investigate Nazi shooting execution sites in Eastern Europe and also videotape testimonies of non-Jewish local witnesses to those murders. See <https://www.yiu.ngo/en>.

⁷ Shutan, testimony, tape 2.

stay and don't go [to the forests], don't escape, we decided that we would fight the Germans from behind the lines."⁸

This resolution catalyzed the formation of a clandestine organization within the Świąciany Ghetto. Comprised of young inmates, the group's initial objective was to mount resistance from within the ghetto, with the long-term aim of escaping to nearby forests to join partisan units. Moshe Shutan was among the founding members of this underground movement.⁹

The group's primary imperative was the acquisition of weaponry. Shutan and several of his compatriots, who were assigned to labor in a camp housing a weapons depot, formulated a plan to surreptitiously appropriate arms and smuggle them into the ghetto. This initiative was undertaken despite the fact that most of the group members lacked any prior experience in handling firearms or other weaponry.

This audacious act of weapon procurement marked the inception of their armed resistance against the German occupiers. It exemplifies the resourcefulness and determination of young ghetto inmates in their efforts to combat Nazi oppression, even in the face of severe limitations and personal risk.

However, those young underground members were soon overshadowed by a catastrophic incident involving two of them. This event would test the resolve of the underground movement and bring to the fore the profound moral dilemmas faced by young Jewish resisters in the ghetto. The incident unfolded as follows.

Gershka Bak, Reuvka Miadziolski, and David Yochai climbed to an attic in one of the ghetto houses to sew leather holsters for the pistols they had smuggled. Excited about the possibility of using a pistol against the Germans, Reuvka accidentally discharged a bullet, hitting Gershka in the mouth. The shot was heard in the ghetto streets, and due to the severe injury, they were forced to summon the doctor, Dr. Tarshinski, who was also a member of the Judenrat. Following Nazi orders, the Judenrat members handed over the two young men to the Germans. News of the incident spread throughout the ghetto, and everyone became aware of the existence of an organized group. The members decided to leave the ghetto immediately and escape to the forest, fearing that the two who were certainly being tortured by the Germans would inform on them. Shutan recounts in his testimony how the underground members had already gathered near the ghetto fence to escape when a sister of one of the members arrived and appealed to their conscience, saying that if they left, family members might pay the price. So, they decided to stay in the ghetto. This story represents, in my opinion, one of the most profound dilemmas that young Jews had to confront: whether to try to save their own

⁸ Shutan, testimony, tape 1.

⁹ Another member of this underground was Yitzhak Arad (Rudnitzki), who survived as a partisan and, after the war, was appointed as the chief education officer in the IDF in the late 1960s and served as the chairman of the Yad Vashem Directorate from 1972 to 1993. He was a leading Holocaust researcher and wrote his doctoral dissertation at Tel Aviv University on "The Holocaust of Vilna Jews and Their Struggle in the Face of Annihilation."

lives or to remain responsible for other Jews – family members, friends, and community. In this case, as Shutan presents it, they decided to risk themselves for the sake of others and stayed in the ghetto for the time being. Later, on March 5–6, 1943, a group of twenty-two underground members, including Moshe Shutan, executed a coordinated escape from the ghetto to the nearby forests.¹⁰

Interestingly, throughout his testimony, Shutan frequently mentions his fellow underground fighters by name. This goes beyond mere personal reminiscence; I believe it's his way of creating a lasting record of those who fought alongside him. By weaving their names into his story, Shutan transforms his account into a living memorial, ensuring that his comrades' efforts in the resistance aren't forgotten.¹¹

Shutan's account of his wartime experiences is notably collective in nature. It transcends the boundaries of individual perspective, encompassing instead the shared decision-making processes and collective actions of a cohort of young men and women who chose to resist in the face of overwhelming adversity. This collective narrative underscores one of the key significances of Shutan's testimony: it provides insight into the group dynamics of youth resistance during the Holocaust. And so, the emphasis on collective action in Shutan's testimony offers a valuable counterpoint to individual-centric narratives of survival and resistance. It illuminates the complex web of relationships, mutual support, and shared risks that characterized underground movements in ghettos and forests. Moreover, it highlights the importance of social bonds and group solidarity in sustaining resistance efforts under extreme conditions.

¹⁰ On the resistance efforts in Świeciany, see Shalom Cholawsky, *Resistance and Partisan Struggle* (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem and Moreshet, 2001), 107–114; Dov Levin, *They Fought Back: Lithuanian Jewry's Armed Resistance to the Nazis 1941–1945* (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem and the Hebrew University, 1974), 143–144.

¹¹ Among the friends Shutan had in the Świeciany ghetto underground and later in the forests were Alexander Bogen, whose testimony is in the Fortunoff Archive, HVT-3374, Moshe Rudnitzki, HVT-3566, and Yitzhak Rudnitzki (later Arad), who interestingly was interviewed by Lawrence Langer and Dori Laub in 2001, HVT-4103.



Memorial in memory of the Martyrs of the Świąciany Ghetto, Świąciany (photographed by Daniela Ozacky Stern)

Contacts with the Underground in the Vilna Ghetto

The young underground members from the Świąciany Ghetto arrived in the Narocz forests and joined the partisan unit commanded by Fiodor Markov. As Shutan recounts, Markov was already known to them, having been a teacher to most of the group before the war, instructing them in Polish language and history. This pre-existing relationship fostered a sense of trust upon their encounter in the forest, facilitating their decision to join his ranks and form a Jewish partisan unit called Revenge (*Neqama* in Hebrew).¹²

Following the request of Markov to bring more fighters to his unit, Shutan took the initiative to return to the Vilna Ghetto with the aim of assisting more Jews in escaping to the forests. Through these actions, he effectively became a partisan liaison. And so, he arrived at the Vilna Ghetto on July 15, 1943. He stayed in the ghetto for about a month, until mid-August; during this time, he experienced some dramatic events. On the night of his arrival, he went to sleep in Chaim Lazar's room. Lazar was a member

¹² For more on the "Revenge" unit, see Sara Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial: The Short Life of the Neqama Battalion, an Independent Jewish Partisan Unit Operating during the Second World War in the Narocz Forest, Belarus," *East European Jewish Affairs* 42, no. 1 (April 2012): 1–24; M. Gefen, C. Grossman, Y. Segal, A. Kovner, and R. Korczak, eds., *The Book of the Jewish Partisans* (Merchavia: Sifriat Poalim, 1958), 79–83.

of the FPO, the Vilna Ghetto underground.¹³ A commotion started in the middle of the night, with people screaming, “Liza Ruft!”¹⁴ Shutan thought to himself, “it’s a shame I got into this turmoil.” Everyone crowded the streets of the ghetto, and it turned out that the FPO commander, Yitzhak Wittenberg, was hiding and was wanted by the Judenrat to be turned over to the Germans. This affair, known in historiography as “the Day of Wittenberg,” left a huge mark on Vilna Ghetto survivors.



Yitzhak Wittenberg (Yad Vashem Photo Archive, 4216_31)

Here is the background of the story: in mid-July 1943, the Germans captured two communists in the city of Vilnius, and following a denunciation of one of them, the Germans demanded that the head of the Judenrat, Jacob Gens, extradite Wittenberg. Wittenberg was indeed captured, but underground members who saw him being dragged in chains towards the ghetto gate freed him and hid him in the ghetto. During that evening, Gens did everything he could to find Wittenberg and hand him over to the

¹³ On January 21, 1942, after preliminary talks, an underground was established: the FPO (United Partisan Organization). The underground was under the leadership of Yitzhak (Itzik) Wittenberg, a member of the communist party, and was under the command of four other representatives. They prepared themselves for an armed resistance in the event that the ghetto was annihilated.

¹⁴ “Liza Ruft” (Yiddish for “Liza is calling”) was the secret password of the FPO underground to initiate armed resistance in the Vilna ghetto if it were to face imminent danger of liquidation. It was named after Liza Magon, an underground member who was captured by the Gestapo and executed in Ponary on February 17, 1943.

German authorities as they demanded. The Germans had threatened they would liquidate the entire ghetto if he was not delivered. In this radical choice between one person's destiny and the fate of the entire ghetto, Gens was convinced that Wittenberg must be handed over. The ghetto was on the edge of a fraternal war between the general public, who wanted to extradite Wittenberg and save the ghetto, and the underground members, who wanted to protect him. Shutan tells of this critical event: Suddenly he heard screams, and the underground members started to run away. "I see a girl standing with her hands up and shouting – 'Where? Go back!' In front of her were fifty or sixty Jewish policemen from the ghetto with batons, and they went out towards the camp that was going in the direction. . . . I learned they were going to Strashoon Street, and the police did not want to let them pass." The girl stood and shouted – "Where? Go back," and the members stood, ashamed of themselves in front of this fearless girl. It was Sonia Madejsker. She started running against the police, so the policemen ran away.¹⁵



סאניע מאדזשקער. איינע פון די העלדישסטע יידישע
פארטיזאנקעס. זי איז פארפייניקט געווארן אין דעם
וויזשניץ געטא. זי איז נאך לעבן אין ירושלים.

Sonia Madejsker (Yad Vashem Photo Archive, 2921_221)

Shutan recounts a pivotal meeting with key figures of the FPO while in the Vilna Ghetto. Present were notable resistance leaders, including Abba Kovner, Joseph Glazman, Sonia Madejsker, Chiena Borovska, and Avraham Chvojnik. The central

¹⁵ Shutan, testimony, tape 6.

point of discussion was a strategic reassessment of the underground's approach. Initially, the FPO had planned for an armed uprising within the ghetto confines. However, faced with evolving circumstances, they now considered gradually sending their members to the forests to join partisan units. Shutan proposed approaching Jacob Gens. He intended to persuade Gens to facilitate the departure of a designated group to the forests. This suggestion highlights the complex relationships and negotiations that often occurred between different Jewish factions within the ghetto – in this case, the underground resistance and the Jewish administrative leadership.¹⁶

Indeed, the FPO leadership's response to Shutan's proposal was one of grave concern. They equated approaching Gens with going directly to the Gestapo. Despite the warnings and apparent risks, Shutan proceeded with his plan to approach Gens. This decision demonstrates the initiative and individual agency that sometimes operated within the broader framework of organized resistance, as well as the difficult choices faced by individuals in navigating between different power structures within the ghetto.

Meetings with the Judenrat of Vilna

Shutan met with Gens and the commander of the Jewish police, David (Salek) Dessler. Gens and Dessler implemented in the Vilna Ghetto the strategy of "rescue through work": as long as the Jews worked and produced, the Germans would have an interest in keeping them alive. Thus, any acts of resistance within the ghetto would jeopardize the safety and security of the ghetto's existence. Gens told Shutan: "I will not let you destroy the ghetto. You want to take those thanks to whom the ghetto exists" – the young who can work. The Germans will not leave the women, children, and elderly, Gens said. He continued: "You came from the FPO, and they think I'm a traitor. But ... I didn't hand over Wittenberg. I never listened to foreign dictates. I did my calculations [according to my conscience]. ... When you go to fight you have to be ready for sacrifices, and he fell victim." He said that the FPO members conducted consultations instead of getting ready to fight. "I understood," Gens said, "that we are dealing here with people looking for fame. ... But when Wittenberg was facing the choice of being extradited to the Germans and he was in their hands ... they didn't have to hand him over. If they handed him over, they did the same thing as I did to save themselves and the ghetto."¹⁷

According to Shutan, there were three central elements operating in the ghetto: the first was Gens and the Judenrat, the second was the FPO underground, and the third were the partisans' liaisons, who arrived in the ghetto from the forest, and among whom he worked. Everyone had their own views, and everyone thought they were correct.

But if you take the situation as it was and look at it today, I see that the heroes of the ghetto were not the partisans and not the FPO. But the real hero of the

¹⁶ Cholawsky, *Resistance and Partisan Struggle*, 144–145.

¹⁷ Shutan, testimony, tape 7.

ghetto was Jacob Gens. Why? The partisans did not have a solution to the ghetto but could have taken out five hundred people, maybe a hundred more ... the only one who gave some hope for the Vilna Ghetto, for the people of the ghetto, was Gens.¹⁸

According to Shutan, Gens gave the ghetto inmates the hope that a miracle might happen. When people are in a dead-end situation, they hear what someone promises them, something that gives some kind of solution and hope for their problems. And the one who gave it to them was Gens. When Gens would leave the ghetto, people would say, who knows why he went? When he came back with clouds and depression on his face, then the entire ghetto was in a bad mood. When Gens would come back from the Gestapo with a smile on his face, the whole ghetto smiled.¹⁹



Jacob Gens (Yad Vashem Photo Archive, 1592_50)

Shutan continues his testimony by telling a story about a revolutionary from nineteenth-century Hungary who was caught and sentenced to death. His mother came and said, "Be sure to write for a pardon, and I will go to Caesar." He wrote, and the mother said, "If they lead you to death on the gallows, then I will go. And if you see that I am in a depressed mood, you will know that you have not been spared, but if you see that I am smiling, you will know that you will stay alive." And the day he was executed, he looked and saw his mother was there. And she smiled. And so, with the hope that they were going to spare him, he was brought to the gallows and hanged. "This road from

¹⁸ Shutan, testimony, tape 7.

¹⁹ Shutan, testimony, tape 7.

the prison to the gallows, the two years of stability in the ghetto, this smile, this hope, the one who gave this to the ghetto was Gens,” says Shutan. “And that was his gain. With the existing situation, there was nothing to help the Jews.”²⁰

The Story of Shike Gertman

One of the figures prominently featured in Shutan’s testimony is Shike Gertman, a close friend from Święciany. Shutan portrays Gertman as a restless and proactive young man eager to take initiative in resistance efforts. His story is particularly significant due to his involvement in a complex and controversial incident that sheds light on the challenges and moral dilemmas faced by partisan liaisons. His actions led to anger and resentment among the survivors towards Gertman, with several subsequent testimonies referring to his abandonment of the group.²¹ Here is what happened:

One morning, while still in the Vilna Ghetto, Shutan arrived at the house where Shike Gertman and his girlfriend, Haika, were staying. The house owner surprised him with unexpected news, asking, “Don’t you know? Shike left with a group of FPO members for the forest at five o’clock this morning.” Shutan was astonished. He and Shike had been like brothers, in touch since childhood. They were neighbors with good relations and had even come to Vilna together from the forest. He couldn’t understand how Shike had left the ghetto without informing him. Seeking answers, he went to meet with Sonia Medejsker from the FPO. He questioned her about the group’s departure, expressing his confusion at being left in the dark. Sonia responded curtly: “It’s better that you didn’t know. You don’t have to know everything.” For the rest of that day, he felt abandoned and betrayed. His close friend’s sudden departure without any communication left him feeling hurt and confused.

The next morning, panic swept through the ghetto. News had spread of a tragedy. The group that had left with Shike had fallen into an ambush near the Lavoriškė bridge by the river. Many had been killed, with only a small number surviving. Vilna Ghetto certificates were found on some of the bodies of those who had fallen. Shutan later learned that Shike had gone with the group as a liaison. The commander of the group was Joseph Glazman. Word circulated in the ghetto that the Germans had rounded up the families of those whose certificates had been found, leading them to execution at the Ponary death site.²² They were murdered. The shock and grief of this event rippled

²⁰ Shutan, testimony, tape 7.

²¹ For example, in Chaim Lazar, *Destruction and Resistance* (New York: Shengold, 1985), 77–78; Shlomo Kanterovich, “With the Partisans in the Narocz Forests,” *Edut* 1 (1987), 95–96.

²² Ponary (Paneriai) was the main mass murder site of the Vilna Jews. It is located about eleven kilometers southeast of Vilna. The Nazis used the pits that were dug there as a site for the extermination of around seventy thousand people, mostly Jews but also Poles who were anti-Nazis, Soviet prisoners of war,

through the ghetto inmates, deepening the sense of fear and loss that already permeated their lives.

Shutan recalled: “I went to Gens and said what was happening in the ghetto, how is the situation? He was boiling.” Gens said: ““You sat and listened to how I told them to go without certificates. Not to them, the Gestapo man Neugebauer came and knocked on the table – “In your ghetto, there are bandits.” But he came to me.”” He threw the certificates on Gens’ table, and Gens did not have an answer. ““I don’t want to talk about them, I don’t want to know them. There is no one to talk to.’ I went out and said look, I’m organizing a group, and I’ll need your help to get out of the ghetto. He said no problem, tell me when and the gate will be open. I had to organize everything by myself and go to the forest.” Shutan met with Sonia Madejsker again. He asked her when the FPO would give him the people they want to send to the forest. She told him, ““We’re not going to the forest anymore.’ I said why? Because of one case, which didn’t succeed, you give up on the idea?” She said that the FPO decided to return to the idea of a rebellion in the ghetto. “I wasn’t looking to convince her. ... And with that I ended the relationship with them, I didn’t go to them anymore and they didn’t contact me.”²³

Shutan, given his close friendship with Shike Gertman, attempts to provide a more nuanced perspective in his testimony, essentially advocating for a more sympathetic understanding of Gertman’s actions. This advocacy is particularly poignant given Gertman’s ultimate fate: he was killed during a partisan action, with some suggestions that he may have been deliberately sent on a dangerous mission by the partisan commander as retribution for abandoning the group he was meant to lead.²⁴

Taking People from the Ghetto to the Forest

As a partisan liaison, Shutan’s mission was to organize ghetto inmates for their escape to the forest. During this process, he encountered various individuals facing difficult decisions, and he describes their characters and dilemmas in his testimony: Mirka Ligomski, a beautiful girl from the Vilna Ghetto, struggled with the decision to join the partisans due to her past experiences and depression. Despite her challenging circumstances, she had prioritized bringing books to the ghetto, reflecting her intellectual values even in dire times.

Shutan also met Shmulik, an eleven-year-old boy from Świąciany, who declined to leave because of his responsibilities to his large family. The boy’s decision highlighted the difficult choices even children had to make during this period.

Lithuanian priests, and Roma. Executions by shooting took place there for three years between July 1941 and July 1944.

²³ Shutan, testimony, tape 7.

²⁴ An abstract of Gertman’s story can be found in Yechiel Gernstein and Moshe Kahanovitz (eds.), *The Lexicon of Bravery*, vol. 1 (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 1965), 123–130.

Another woman, a former communist whose boyfriend had been sent to Siberia, sought Shutan's help to escape to the forest. She had made arrangements for her young children, but due to personal conflicts that he did not want to share in his testimony, Shutan refused to assist her. However, she managed to reach the forest independently.

Shutan also met his former teacher, Motel Lewinsky, who chose to remain in the ghetto with his wife despite the dangers, demonstrating a profound commitment to his life partner. Similarly, teacher Deborah Fisher, when offered a chance to escape, opted to stay with the community, allowing younger people to leave and be saved instead.

These experiences deeply affected Shutan, showcasing the diverse and often heart-wrenching decisions individuals faced during the Holocaust. While he found it challenging to judge their choices, Shutan gained a deep respect for the moral strength and sacrifices made by many in these impossible situations. Reflecting on the challenges of convincing ghetto inmates to join the partisans, Shutan provides insight into the psychological barriers many faced:

I think that the transition from the ghetto to the partisans is a transition from a situation where you, as long as you are in the ghetto, you live in peace, sleep like a human being as long as it is quiet, so you pass these days in peace as well, but from the moment you go out into the forest you are in constant danger and with this constant danger you have to fight. One needs courage for this, and strength to hold on because every second, every minute there can be some kind of surprise, for worse or for better, and that's the only reason I think people were reluctant to go, because they didn't want to get into a situation that put their lives at risk every moment.²⁵

With the Partisans

While in the Narocz forest, Shutan witnessed a deeply troubling incident that profoundly impacted his worldview and beliefs. It happened during the dissolution of the "Revenge" Jewish partisan unit, orchestrated by commanders Markov and Ivan Klimov, the representative of the Communist Party in the partisan movement. The disbanding devolved into a humiliating spectacle of antisemitic behavior.²⁶ He relates:

What else did I see? One came out, then a partisan who was standing by the tent said to him, 'Give me your boots.' He was startled, said, 'Don't talk much, give me your boots.' And he took off his shoes, threw torn shoes at him, and this Jewish man from the Vilna ghetto, by chance he was at the headquarters of the FPO, I do not want to say his name, he took off the good boots and gave them to the partisan, and took the torn shoes. I felt as if I had been stabbed in the

²⁵ Shutan, testimony, tape 8.

²⁶ Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial," 11–12; Cholawsky, *Resistance and Partisan Struggle*, 147–148.

heart. We knew there were antisemites, we knew there was an attitude, sometimes good, sometimes bad, but I have never seen such brutal behavior. Then, it entered my mind that the Jew is poor, those poor in the ghetto, poor those in the partisans, and I thought about the brotherhood of the peoples, about freedom and . . . and from the moment I saw how they took his boots off, the Zionist idea that Jews need their own country entered my mind.”²⁷

Shutan recounts the event with palpable anguish: “We Jews still stood as if abandoned, but we could not do anything.” This harrowing experience marked a turning point in Shutan’s ideological journey. The stark reality of antisemitism, even within the partisan ranks where unity against a common enemy might have been expected, shattered his illusions about universal brotherhood. The incident of the forcibly exchanged boots became a powerful symbol for Shutan, crystallizing the vulnerability of Jews in a world where they lacked a nation of their own. This moment of disillusionment and realization underscores the complex interplay between resistance, identity, and political awakening in the crucible of wartime experience.



The Narocz Forest in Belarus (photographed by Daniela Ozacky Stern)

²⁷ Shutan, testimony, tape 8.

Shutan's testimony highlights two more significant incidents from his time as a partisan in the forest. These additional events further illuminate the challenges and experiences of Jewish resistance fighters during this period.

The first incident involved Shutan's being charged with falling asleep while on guard duty. In the partisan forest, the punishment for such an offense was typically death. Shutan recounts that during a guard duty with non-Jewish partisans, they brought potatoes to cook. They offered him a hot potato, but he initially refused, adhering to his guard duty. They began mocking him for not eating, using anti-Semitic taunts. Shutan recalls:

He said, "You're afraid to sit ... you're a coward, all Jews are cowards." Oh, how he said to me, "All Jews are cowards." So, I immediately sat down. I sat down, took one potato after another, he gave them to me, it was warm, it was good, it was tasty too, and I fell asleep. I fell asleep, and when I woke up, I heard shouting at me and someone hitting me on the head. One hand, second hand. The rifle was between my legs. I grabbed the rifle and shouted, "Stop or I'll shoot." Then he immediately took the rifle from me.²⁸

The brigade commissar subsequently interrogated Shutan. After deliberation and understanding Shutan's unique situation of being left almost completely alone in the world, with no family members surviving and no home to return to, the partisan commander decided to spare his life.

Nonetheless, this incident highlights the precarious position of Jewish partisans within mixed units, the prevalence of antisemitism even among allied fighters, and the complex decision-making processes within partisan groups regarding discipline and punishment.²⁹

The second incident occurred as Shutan walked the forests with his partisan comrade Piecka. He recounts:

We walked on for about a kilometer. Suddenly I see a child under a tree, his head towards the ground. I thought he was dead. I approached him, turned his head, and he opened his eyes. I see he's alive. "What are you doing here?" I asked. He says, "Mom left me here and said I shouldn't move, she'll come to get me." I said, "Come with us." "No, no, I won't go," he says. A five-year-old child. And he wouldn't go. I couldn't carry him because I had Piecka with me, so I said, "We can't do anything, let's go." And we left the child.³⁰

In the following tape (number 11), the interviewer asks Shutan why he didn't do more to help the child and mother reunite. Shutan tries to justify his actions:

²⁸ Shutan, testimony, tape 9.

²⁹ For further information on executions in partisan units, see Daniela Ozacky Stern, "Executions of Jewish Partisans in the Lithuanian Forests – The Case of Natan Ring," *International Journal of Military History and Historiography* 40 (2021): 219–244.

³⁰ Shutan, testimony, tape 10.

It's like being in a jungle. It's like trying to find a needle in a haystack, it was impossible. . . . What option did we have? Piecka could barely move, he could hardly walk and I was carrying him. Leaving him wasn't even a thought in my head. It's a very sad case and this is what can happen in war. If it happened today, I would forcibly carry him, but then I didn't do it. I think about it more than once. A person doesn't always do what needs to be done. There are moments when his thoughts are with himself, with those closest to him, and sometimes, in such situations, you don't see further. Today, I see it more clearly and understand it better; that's why I told this sad story.³¹

This incident illuminates several crucial aspects of wartime experience and its lasting impact. It vividly illustrates the complex moral dilemmas individuals faced during the war, forcing Shutan to choose between helping a lost child and continuing with his injured comrade. His retrospective analysis suggests a form of survivor's guilt, acknowledging that he would act differently now, indicating ongoing reflection on his wartime actions. The story of a child waiting for a mother who will not return movingly demonstrates the severe psychological toll of war on civilians. Shutan's explanation reveals how extreme circumstances can narrow one's focus to immediate survival, sometimes at the cost of broader moral considerations. By sharing this difficult story, Shutan contributes to a more nuanced understanding of wartime experiences, including morally ambiguous situations that don't fit neatly into heroic narratives. His admission that he sees the situation more clearly now demonstrates how moral understanding can evolve over time, shaped by reflection on past experiences. This testimony underscores the value of such accounts in providing a more complete and complex picture of human behavior under extreme duress.

Challenging Established Narratives

Moshe Shutan's testimony presents a narrative that diverges significantly from the commonly accepted understanding of the tensions between the Vilna Ghetto underground and Jacob Gens, the head of the Judenrat. This alternative perspective has provoked considerable controversy and resistance among survivors and the scholarly community.³²

When Shutan submitted a partial testimony for publication in the journal of the Museum of Combatants and Partisans,³³ editor Chaim Lazar grappled with the decision to publish it. In his diary, Lazar wrote:

³¹ Shutan, testimony, tape 11.

³² Several such testimonies are of Nissan Reznik (1990) in The Fortunoff Video Archive for Holocaust Testimonies, HVT-3193, and Chaim Lazar (1997), USC Shoah Foundation Visual Archive, 30235 and the scholarly book of Aron Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto* (Haifa: Moreshet Publishing, 2013).

³³ The journal of the Museum of Combatants and Partisans was a private initiative of Chaim Lazar, a Holocaust survivor of the Vilna Ghetto and the partisans. Between 1967 and 1997, he published over 100

I considered whether to publish this section because it is unusual, contrary to everything that is said and accepted today on this subject and because the story and description lowers or may lower the aura of heroism from the leaders of the FPO. I decided to publish the things despite the bitterness it may cause in various circles, because in my opinion the description is faithful to the truth and the assessment corresponds to the reality of those days.³⁴

This editorial decision highlights the tension between preserving established narratives and presenting potentially disruptive but truthful accounts.

Shutan's efforts to publish his complete account faced further obstacles. When he sought funding from the Association of Święciany's Jews to publish his book, he encountered resistance. The Ghetto Fighters House offered to publish the book on the condition that Shutan incorporate certain "corrections," a compromise he was unwilling to make. Lazar's diary provides insight into Shutan's character and the reasons behind his steadfast position: "Moshe is a simple guy, he didn't have time to study much, but he is an interesting type, with a strong character who knows how to stand by his principles and faith and is not ready to accept dictates and corrections contrary to the dictates of his conscience and his 'truth.'"³⁵

This characterization of Shutan underscores the challenges faced by survivors whose memories and interpretations diverge from the dominant narrative, particularly when they lack formal education or established credentials. Despite these obstacles, Shutan's account was eventually published. The Yiddish version, titled *Geto un vald*, was released in 1971 without mention of a publishing house. The Hebrew version, *Geto ve Yaar* ("Ghetto and Woods"), was published in 1985 by the Committee for the Commemoration of Jewish Combat in World War II in Tel Aviv.

The journey of Shutan's narrative, from a controversial written account to a published book and finally to a recorded testimony for the Fortunoff Video Archive in 1993, illustrates the complex dynamics involved in constructing and challenging historical narratives of the Holocaust. This progression – from written controversy to oral history – highlights the evolving nature of Holocaust testimony and memory. It raises important questions about the role of individual memories in shaping collective understanding, the tension between heroic narratives and nuanced historical realities, and the challenges of integrating diverse perspectives into the historical record. Furthermore, the fact that Shutan gave his testimony to the Fortunoff Archive after his book was published suggests a continued desire to share his experiences and perspectives, perhaps reaching a broader audience through the medium of video testimony. This multistage process of sharing his story underscores the persistence of memory and the ongoing nature of Holocaust remembrance and documentation.

issues featuring scholarly works and testimonies on the Holocaust, with a special focus on Jewish resistance. Lazar was my grandfather.

³⁴ Chaim Lazar's diary, July 20, 1968.

³⁵ Chaim Lazar's diary, April 21, 1970.



Cover of the Hebrew edition of Moshe Shutan's book, Ghetto and Woods (1985)

In reflecting on his wartime experiences, Moshe Shutan offers a poignant and self-critical assessment of the rescue efforts he was involved in. His words provide insight into the challenging decisions and limitations faced by those attempting to save lives during the Holocaust. Shutan's testimony reveals the weight of responsibility he felt and the enduring impact of those times on his perspective regarding the rescue of Jews from the ghetto:

I realized I shouldn't have been deterred by the FPO's refusal to go to the forest. I should have organized more people and involved them in the operation to expand these activities. I only did what I could manage on my own. There were some results, but much more could have been done. It was an abnormal and cruel time. Although we fought against the Germans, we Jews ultimately lost the war. The Jewish people paid too high a price in terms of casualties during World War II, which we call the Holocaust. For us, it wasn't a victory. I hope the world will change and become a better place. That's all.³⁶

³⁶ Shutan, testimony, tape 11.

Summary

This critical edition examines the testimony of Moshe Shutan, a Holocaust survivor who played a crucial role as a liaison between the Vilna Ghetto and partisan units in the Narocz forest in Belarus during World War II. Recorded in 1993 for the Fortunoff Video Archive, Shutan's account offers valuable insights into the often-overlooked aspects of Jewish resistance during the Holocaust, particularly the function of liaisons between ghettos and forest-based partisan groups. His testimony provides a unique perspective on the complexities of the Jewish response to Nazi persecution, including underground resistance within ghettos, escape strategies, and partisan warfare.

Shutan's detailed account contributes to the broader understanding of Jewish resistance during the Holocaust. It highlights the multifaceted nature of resistance efforts and the challenges faced by those who sought to survive and fight back against Nazi oppression. His testimony underscores the importance of individual voices in shaping our understanding of historical events. It reminds us that the Holocaust was not just a monolithic tragedy but a multitude of personal stories, each contributing to our collective memory and understanding.

He finishes his testimony with the story of David Luzak, a thirteen-year-old Jewish boy whom he knew in Świeżycy. This boy was a true genius who knew nine languages and read Goethe in German. He was an excellent student. How did he become so smart? The non-Jewish kids used to bother him, calling him "Żyd" (Jew). So, he stayed in the house and learned instead of playing outside with other children. "He was a rare pearl among humanity and among the Jews," Shutan recounts. "The Lithuanian kids took his childhood, and the Germans took his life." Such victims represent an immeasurable loss.³⁷

Shutan's testimony serves as a valuable contribution to Holocaust historiography, offering insights that both complement and challenge existing narratives. It invites us to approach the study of this period with greater nuance, empathy, and openness to the complex realities faced by individuals and communities under extreme duress.

Moshe Shutan immigrated to Israel in January 1949, following a two-year period of internment in British-run detention camps in Cyprus. These camps were established to prevent Jewish Holocaust survivors from entering Mandatory Palestine, a policy that remained in effect until the establishment of the State of Israel in May 1948.

Upon his arrival in the newly formed state, Shutan found employment in the construction industry. He married Batya, and the couple had one child, a daughter named Nechama. Tragically, Nechama passed away at the relatively young age of 48 due to illness. Shutan himself passed away in 2006.

³⁷ Shutan, testimony, tape 12.

As one of the few survivors of his family and having lost his only daughter, Shutan has shared a compelling testimony that serves not only as a crucial historical record but also as a living memorial – a testament to his experiences and to the loved ones he lost.

TRANSCRIPT

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 1 – transcript

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Moshe Shutan [00:00:54]:

Should I begin?

Interviewer [00:00:54]:

Just a moment please

Moshe Shutan [00:00:54]:

My name is Moshe Shutan. I was born in the town of Świąciany³⁸ in Wollach. Vilna. I grew up in a family with six children. My father worked all sorts of jobs and the mother was a writer, we all learned, all the family members, the children learned in a Yiddish school. I started working with Father when I was young, age nine, I started helping him at work and learning in school. Now I will pass on to the period when the Second World War started. A few days ahead even, a week before, they spoke of something brewing. People said that there will be, that a war will break out.

³⁸ Świąciany is a town about 90 kilometers northeast of Vilna. In the Interwar Years, it was part of Poland. About 8,000 residents lived there, about 3,500 of them Jews, the rest being Poles, Russians, Belarusians, Lithuanians, and a few Tatar families. Following the Ribbentrop-Molotov Pact, the Red Army invaded eastern Poland, including Świąciany, on September 17, 1939. The town was annexed to the Belarusian Soviet Republic. In the summer of 1940, with Lithuania becoming a Soviet republic, Świąciany was assigned to Lithuania. On June 26, 1941, the German army entered Świąciany, and the kidnapping and murder of Jews in the town began. In late September 1941, the Jews of the town, along with Jews from neighboring towns, were taken to a ghetto in an abandoned military camp called Poligon, near the town of Nowe Świąciany. About 8,000 Jews were concentrated there, and in the first days of October 1941, all the Jews in Poligon were shot. A small ghetto with about 500 people remained in Świąciany.

Interviewer [00:02:03]:

What date are you talking about now?

Moshe Shutan [00:02:06]:

Before the Second World War began between Russia and Germany.

Interviewer [00:02:14]:

'41.

Moshe Shutan [00:02:21]:

'41. I had a friend who's my neighbor, Shike Gertman, and he returned from Vilna to Świąciany a few days before the war broke out, and he said that on the road, when he was travelling, he saw *shalonim*, trains with tanks with cannons going to the border. The Russians started fortifying the border with stones, they drove with many wagons with stones and also machines, travel machines, travel cars, and it was evident that something will occur. And indeed, on June 22 the war broke out. We children were on vacation from school. A panic arose, and we didn't know what to do because the German blow was so strong that the authorities did not say anything, and it was evident that from the local authorities, people started escaping, and also the Jewish community started panicking. The fear was that the Germans are coming. Who were the Germans? In general, people knew.

Interviewer [00:04:04]:

What did they know?

Moshe Shutan [00:04:06]:

Of their persecutions against the Jews and the decrees.

Interviewer [00:04:13]:

You mean the persecutions and decrees in Poland?

Moshe Shutan [00:04:17]:

No, no. That was in Germany, in Fascist Germany, against the Jews. Also, in Poland, there was great antisemitism before the outbreak of the war.

Interviewer [00:04:30]:

But did you receive information about what happened in Poland during the German occupation after September 39?

Moshe Shutan [00:04:49]:

We knew, generally speaking. What was done in Poland, that they made ghettos there, and in Warsaw they made a big ghetto for the Jews, not just from the Jews of Warsaw but from the surrounding towns, and that life there is very difficult. But I don't want to dwell on it now, I want to tell how it happened that the war began.³⁹ People wanted to know what to do, and they did not have an answer. So, they decided to run away, half the town, on wagons, bicycles, on foot – they left the town towards Russia, to the east. On the way, they were shot at by Lithuanians who defected from the Red Army and were in the resistance, probably the Lithuanian resistance, and they were against the Soviets and you could not pass and people turned back. They shot not just with guns but also with machine guns. There was a case when a Russian military unit went and returned, and driving ahead of them is the Secretary of the Communist Party of our town, and he asks them, where are you coming back to, and they said, you can't pass through there because they're shooting at us, so he says, So that's the kind of army you are? Follow me. Among those who went with everyone, he said, anyone who has a weapon, come with me. There was also, a Jew named Shein also volunteered. They went, they surrounded the Lithuanians and took them out, and the road was clear.

Interviewer: [00:07:07]:

What did your family do? What did your family do in those days, with the outbreak of the war?

Moshe Shutan [00:07:14]:

My family? I'll tell you. Since some came back, the larger part came back, but ... few... continued on the road and got to Russia. I also met up with friends and we asked, what should we do. So, me and the friends decided that we will run away. I came home and

On the Holocaust in Lithuania, see the monumental work of Christoph Dieckmann, *Deutsche* ³⁹ *Besatzungspolitik in Litauen 1941-1944* (Göttingen: Wallstein, 2011).

said that I want to run away, but then they said, if you leave then we leave also. We had in the house a grandmother, 86, bless her, she was healthy, may her memory be a blessing. But to walk in a time of war hundreds of kilometers, and the Germans advanced very fast – I didn't see this as a solution. I said, what should we do, and we decided to stay. But to stay is also a problem. For instance, there was one Jew whose house was nationalized by the Russians, and other people lived there. He got up in front of the residents, "Jews, why are you running, what are you thinking? We'll get by with the Germans." Later he lost his wife and his girl, he stayed alive. So the war was on our doorstep and we had to decide what to do, so one thing was clear, if you can't run, so we gathered with the guys, me, Shike Gertman, Yoske Rodnitzky, Davidka Yohai, Itzke Rodnitzky, and Shike Gertman – I said already – and we talked about what to do. There were no orders from the government, no orders from the local authorities, we had to make our own decisions. And our decision was that if we stay and we don't go, we don't run, we decided that we will fight the Germans from the rear. And the guys agreed to that.

Interviewer [00:10:19]:

These were friends from school?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:2]:

From school. Not all of them, some of them, but we knew each other. Now you will start to ask me what was this decision, how it came about, the Germans weren't there yet and you decided to fight them, this decision came from an ideological standpoint. We came to the conclusion to fight the Germans, not as in most cases after the persecutions, after the murder. Then they decided to fight. We decided to fight the Germans because they were the enemies of mankind, and specifically the Jewish people. You could ask how we came to this decision. I grew up in a Jewish house, that was the education I received. My teachers were Bundsmen, and they spoke of human rights, of the freedom of the individual, they spoke of Fascism, they spoke of the situation of the Jews in Poland, that our situation was difficult, and they outlined our direction to search for justice in the world. I was also raised, not in school, I was raised on books. And also on books, my character, this thought of fighting, I got from authors like Victor Hugo, Jules Verne, Beecher Stowe, and we saw that the persecuted – if they do not rise up to fight, they will arrive at nothing and will remain slaves. Also from the Soviet literature, like the Silent Don and all those heroes, I was with them...

Interviewer [00:13:32]:

You sympathized with them?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:33]:

I sympathized with them. When we were tested, and when the time came to decide by ourselves, so we decided on it. Our teacher, Devorah Fisher, who was a Bund woman and was in the first conference of the Bundsmen in Minsk, so while she taught us, she said to us like this: I know that in Poland, the situation of the Jews is very difficult. It will be very difficult for you with jobs, and you don't have the opportunity to continue in your studies, and everything that you have learned you will forget. But we are teaching you to be human beings, that you will think like human beings and behave like human beings, so that you can get by in life. We also had the teacher Motel Gilinsky, he was a great educator, for instance after the lesson during recess he would come out and play with us until the next bell rung, and when someone needed help, someone who didn't know how to do the lesson, so he always said, If you don't know, come to me and I will always help you. You have to remember that the economic situation of the teachers then was very difficult, because our school subsisted thanks to the Jewish community and the help of Jews abroad. Some of the students paid tuition but there were also those who could not pay, but they were accepted and they were taught. They took according to each person's ability. And some also studied without paying. What more can I say about the situation in Poland? Before the outbreak of the war, in '39, when the war broke out between Germany and Poland, or rather, the Germans invaded Poland, they drafted all the Polish population. They drafted then my friend, the friend of my sister, the eldest one, Rachel, and when he went to the drafting place and was about to leave we said goodbye to him. But then I came up to him – today I see it was very naïve – and I said to him, Look, for the Poles we have no reason to fight, but you should know that you are fighting against the Fascists. And when the time came to decide what to do, and we decided to fight in the rear, the first obstacle that stood in our way was getting weapons.

Interviewer [00:17:43]:

All this before the Germans entered Świąciany?

Moshe Shutan [00:17:45]:

Before. Later, the German army came. When the German army came I went out and saw how they are going through the town with tanks, with transport vehicles, with cars, with soldiers, and there was one case where three Russian soldiers – they threw their weapons down and went as captives, but because there was no one to receive them they stood among all the people and waited. In the meantime, there was a store there, and they distributed buns, so they also stood in line to receive buns. It happened that from an alley a German entered on a motorcycle, on three – a tricycle, and after him a Russian

soldier with a gun. The Russian soldiers, two Russian soldiers caught the German on the way, he was driving by himself, and they forced him to drive east. They didn't know that in our towns the Germans were already there. So, when the German saw Germans driving in convoy he stopped the motorcycle, rolled over, and he fell between the wheels of the machines. He was wounded, but then the Russians shot him and ran away. The Germans started to run after them. After about half an hour they came back. They came back, they did not catch them. So, the three soldiers who were standing in line in the store to get a bun, so people started when all this commotion started, with the German that they shot and ran away then everyone ran away. Before, why did they run away? The Germans stopped the cars and one with a machine gun, he aimed the machine gun at the queue of people. So they started to run away and only the three soldiers were left. After they didn't find the Russians who shot at their soldier, they took the soldiers and killed them on the spot, unarmed. I already mentioned the name, Shike Gertman. His dad went – he had a curious nature, he went to see. He came and he saw the soldiers killing, he came back home, and said "the end of the world". If they can kill people, soldiers going into captivity and unarmed, then he says, something like this is yet unheard-of in all the wars. The situation was very difficult. They could see it would not be good. In the first days they captured Jews for work. They took them to work, and the first case when they took six or seven guys, they said 'for work' and they executed them. All the time, it's forbidden for Jews to walk on the sidewalk, there was regulation that we need to wear the cross, the yellow Star of David. People were afraid to walk outside. The Lithuanian police was then ruling the city, and a Lithuanian officer, he was from the Lithuanian police, and also a few Germans, as far as I know they were five, six, then there were nine Germans in town, but they control was held by the Lithuanians. They went from house to house, the Lithuanians, and searched and found things, found gold, they took everything and every house was in panic and after they already shot the six, the guys really did not know what will happen and how we will come out of it. Avraham, Shike's father, he was a Jew whose whole life he was only interested in politics. He was a cobbler by profession, but politics was paramount for him, it was his nourishment. He would get up with this and go to sleep with this. Now when there was a period like this, there were no newspapers. There was a Polish newspaper published, we had, but Jews could not buy it. Once there was a case that a newspaper fell into our hands, And once he brought – I don't know where he got it from – he brought a Polish newspaper published in Vilna and in the newspaper it was written that if you see a Jew falling on the road and he needs help and his situation is bad and he is going to die, you shouldn't help him, but the opposite, finish him off. Nu, we, when we read these things, our hairs stood on end. Anyway, Avraham did not give up, he wanted to know what's happening because we didn't know what's going on in the front, we didn't know, we had no information apart from the newspaper that would fall into our hands. Radio, there was an order to hand in all receivers, all radio receivers. And we weren't left without anything. He managed to get hold of a radio, and if they find a radio in a house they would shoot the whole family. So he went to his son, he was already old and he didn't have the strength to carry a radio, so he went to his son

and said to him, Listen, one of the Jews has a radio. Who is this Jew? He was a bachelor, in HeChalutz,⁴⁰ he was a Zionist, and he didn't want to give away the radio. He was poor, but all the wealth he had was the radio. But after the restrictions, he was afraid to hold on to it. So, Avraham comes and says, listen, you have a radio, give it to me. So, he said, OK, take it. The main thing is that I get rid of it. So, his son went and in a bag brought the radio. He had to go through some streets in the city and he was not afraid. Now, in order to fix up the radio, to get it going, you had to transfer electricity. We decided that – I was involved in things because I was a neighbor, wall to wall. Our attic was by their attic, only wood planks separate these two roofs. And we needed to install electricity. We said, we will put the radio in the attic and another attic, it becomes small like this, so that, if they go up on the roof, they wouldn't immediately see the radio, but it would be hidden up there. So we needed to install electricity. The electrician was me. Where did I know about electricity? I learned physics in high school so we also learned about electricity, so I knew about electricity. I transferred the electricity, and then – it wasn't a sophisticated radio like today, there was need for an antenna. We can't set up an antenna because they would see it, so we have to set up an *erdung*, a ground connection. So, we said we will make a ground connection. There's a fence, and the fence has poles. We will take out one pole, under this pole put the wires, dig them in the earth through the yard, and pass the wires to the cellar. So just as we're digging to remove the pole, a neighbor comes along, what are you doing? We're fixing the fence. Are you insane? He says, At a time like this you've got it into your head to fix the fence?! We said, You'll see, a few weeks and the Soviets will come back. You're out of your minds, he says, and goes off. We fixed everything up, and in the first evening we go up to the roof, me with Shike because Avrum himself could not go up, it was that difficult for him. And we heard, we received Russia, Moscow. And what did they say? They said that they, the Red Army, is holding on, that they are managing to stop them, and they turned to the population left in the rear, to the young people, that they should go to the partisans. They even spoke of the Germans killing Jews in a town, they said, I can't remember exactly right now, but they said that 70 Jews were put in a house and they were all killed.

Please note that I have fixed an issue :Commented [sjc1] in the main text as well as footnote. There was a mix up between English and Hebrew definite articles and the name itself. I consulted with the translator before making these changes. (I myself would put Ha not He, so HaChalutz, but this is down to style and I left as was.)

Interviewer [00:30:06]:

Do you remember the approximate date of...

Moshe Shutan [00:30:09]:

It was in the month of August. August... yes, approximately August it was

HeChalutz ("The Pioneer") was a Jewish youth movement founded in the early 20th century that⁴⁰ trained young Jews in agriculture and other practical skills to prepare them for settlement in Palestine/Israel, playing a crucial role in establishing kibbutzim and contributing significantly to the Zionist movement before, during, and after the Holocaust.

Interviewer [00:30:18]

'41

Moshe Shutan [00:30:19]:

Yes, '41. The fact that they spoke of going to the partisans was for us, how shall I put it, it held us up, it gave us hope in the road we chose, that it's the right road. This Avurm would tell the Jews, he would tell them the news, there was another Jew with a radio, Peretz Hochman, so they would.... They would talk amongst them about the news they heard. Now, we managed to hear also London, we heard London, and what was interesting in the message from London? They turned to the Polish people to keep weapons, to arm themselves with weapons but fighting – they should not go out fighting, that they will yet give the order when to go out. And in the meantime, to sit quietly.

Interviewer [00:32:02]:

You were in the town and you said about the other man who had a radio. I wanted to ask you what is happening in the meantime among the Jews of the town, in terms of the community organization and so on.

Moshe Shutan [00:32:18]:

Just a moment.

Interviewer [00:32:29]:

Danny, do a round of 'quiet' please.

Moshe Shutan [00:32:30]:

Once we managed to hear Jerusalem. And they spoke in Hebrew. We didn't know Hebrew, we grew up in a Yiddish school, but in our town there were Zionist parties, among them was the Hechalutz HaTzair, the leader of the Hechalutz HaTzair was named Yudke Shapiro. This Yudke Shapiro was an intelligent guy, he had rhetorical powers, and those who belonged to the movement were very appreciative of him. Also us, I mean we were Yiddishists, but we appreciated him as a person. We went to him and said, Yudke, we have something to tell you. So he said, What? We have a radio, and we want to hear from Jerusalem, they're talking in Hebrew, we don't know what they're

saying there, so we want you to come. At first he could not believe that we have a radio; later he saw that we are serious, so he came. He came one evening, we would put three or four blankets on us and on the radio, so that it's not audible outside. Because once my brother-in-law was living with us in the house and he.... So we would do like this, Shike would go hear the radio while I, while he was with us, my brother-in-law, he would go out with us and we would sit on the attic. So to make sure that he doesn't hear, I would start shouting and singing and dancing, so he would say, so they said in the house, your son has gone mad. Once he says to me, Mishka, I hear radio. I say to him, This radio is for sure from the city, there was a kind of café there, casino; I said it's coming from there. Maybe, he says, but I hear radio. Anyway, he didn't know. He didn't know. When Yudke came in the evening and started listening to Jerusalem, then we asked him, Nu, what did they say? So he gave us the news, exactly what we heard from London, word for word, translated. We thought there would be some appeal of the Jews from here, our Jews, there was nothing. And I can tell you that he came down and he also was despairing, that he didn't hear anything from Jerusalem. Let's say from Russia, from Moscow, they would say Fight! Take Action! Here – nothing. They passed on the information that the war is going like this and like this, they bombed here, they bombed there, there were battles here – that's the information they gave. Me and Yudke did not share with him the secret that we are a group with this idea, to fight, because we were afraid, we didn't want to talk about it yet, and if Yudke did not decide to fight – because he didn't come to this idea, to fight the Germans, and there were already persecutions that killed 40 people in our town, and then they killed 100 people – and if Yudke was not going to fight, not going to hide, was indifferent, maybe not indifferent but he couldn't do anything, but in general I think Zionism then had a problem. What was the problem? With the Russians we got along. The Bund,⁴¹ Communism, it's actually the same ideology. Only their approach is different. We learned at school and we had no problems with the Soviet rule – quite the opposite, under the Poles we couldn't study, and once the Russians came everyone went to study. When the Russians came they closed down all the Jewish institutions but the Yiddish school stayed. And we carried on working in the Yiddish school. Some friends went to a Russian school, they opened also a Russian school. I wanted to continue in the tradition of the Jews. For me, Judaism – Sholom Aleichem, Mendely, Shalom Asch, Peretz, I didn't see them as any lesser authors than the global authors, and they spoke to my heart. And if Judaism subsisted on the Torah, but then the Haskalah began and Jews started learning other languages and math and history, from the beginning the beginning of Haskalah,⁴² this tradition – I didn't want to leave. Because of this I stayed at a Yiddish school, and not

The Bund (General Jewish Labour Union) was a secular Jewish socialist political movement founded ⁴¹ in 1897 that advocated for Jewish workers' rights, cultural autonomy, and Yiddish language preservation in Eastern Europe, while opposing both Zionism and assimilation, playing a significant role in Jewish political life until World War II.

The Haskala (Jewish Enlightenment) was an intellectual movement that emerged in 18th-century ⁴² Europe, particularly among German and Eastern European Jews, promoting secular education, integration into broader society, and modernization of Jewish life while encouraging the study of European languages and modern science alongside traditional Jewish learning.

Just wondering if 'German and :Commented [sjc2] Central European' rather than 'East European' might be better in the footnote? I am not certain.

just me, there were others. Since the Soviets closed down the school and the Hebrew culture, then Yudke remained outside, so to speak. The Communists were enemies of the Zionists, that's why they didn't have a common language. And now when the situation came that we had to fight the Germans, so it had to be done with yesterday's enemy, and he didn't overcome this. If he had overcome this wall and said, now the war is against the Germans, and no matter with whom I am going to fight, then that would have been a correct thought, but he didn't get there. And when the Jews of our city were liquidated, he went with everyone. It's possible that if we had said to him, Yudke, look, we have a resistance network, he would have joined them. We didn't do it. And obviously, today I know it was a mistake. After about a month.

Interviewer [00:41:01]:

A month from when?

Moshe Shutan [00:41:02]:

Or less, from the start of the war, the Germans decided to expel all the Jews from the city and said they would do a ghetto, and some of the population would remain in the ghetto. We had one, Moyshe Gordon. Who was Moyshe Gordon? When the Germans and the Lithuanians took control and they caught guys for work, they didn't know if they caught them to kill them or if they would come back, people would run to this Moyshe Gordon who knew the commander of the Lithuanian police, and he could also speak Lithuanian. So they would run to him, Moyshe, go see what's going on with our kids. So he would go and ask what's the situation, what's up with these guys. And he would tell them families, don't worry, it's just work, they will come back. Now when the order came to expel the Jews of the town, so he saw... he saw it as his duty to say to the Jews that they want to expel. They gathered in the synagogue, and he stood before the crowd and said, Look, the Germans have decided to expel us from the town to a place by the town of Nowe [New] Święciany, named Poligon,⁴³ the name of a camp called Poligon, and they would only expel there And anyone who can save himself should do so because why they're sending there, and how, I do not know. Then after that night many people escaped, also young people. Where did they escape to? They escaped to White Russia, it was quiet there, there were still no persecution against the Jews. When they gathered all the Jews in order to send them the next day and it was Saturday, they said that they gathered in the market of the town, they all gathered, and I said, my guys said, if the Germans say one thing, we will do the exact opposite. So me and Shike decided we would hide. We hid in a room, closed the door and put a wardrobe, his father put the wardrobe by the door, and the Lithuanian police went door to door to see if any Jews were left. They went with a list, and whomever was not on

In an abandoned military camp called Poligon near the town of Nowe Święciany, thousands of Jews ⁴³ were murdered by Nazi forces during the first months of the war. See note 1 above.

the list, they took him. My brother in law – he married my sister during the Soviet time, he was in printing by trade so he worked, so they left him. They left 80 families. So they left him and with him they left all the family, so also my family, part of my family was left, but the grandmother and one of my sisters they took. When they took everyone we were inside and we heard the shouts of the Lithuanian police, and then there was quiet and we waited until the evening. We waited until the evening, one of my sisters named Nechama, she went to see what's going on, because she was left. They left her. And she came to the window where we were and said, you can come out, everyone is already out of the city, and go in the house. Then we came in the house and I was surprised that she's not afraid to walk down the street. With her it was like this: She had a boyfriend, and the boyfriend heard that Moyshe Gordon said to run away, so he ran away, he ran to the city of Glubokie, so she decided that she would also go to Glubokie, that it's more quiet there, and she will find him. On the road they stopped her, her and some other Jews, and killed her. She was five months pregnant. After they led all the Jews to Poligon, then they said that they need, it was a Sunday, on Sunday all Jews must enter the ghetto. My father went out and took a broom. He wanted to see what was going on in the street, so he took a broom as if he's sweeping the street, working, so that he would not be arrested. And he said, It's quiet, we can go past. OK, Shike's whole family with his father Avraham was taken, and the radio stayed: what to do with the radio? So he put it in a bag and we said we would move to the Ghetto and bring the radio to the Ghetto. Now we were in one house, he came with us, he was by himself, so he was already with our family and sat down. My mother asks, what is this you're sitting on? What is this? In the bag. So he says to her, a radio. She hears radio and she pales. She says, Quick, take out the radio so I don't see it. He takes the radio, don't know where he puts it, and then he returns. This was the next day. Sunday, after they removed the Jews. In the meantime, my mother had heart trouble. So my father goes to a pharmacy in the town to get medication. He returns from the pharmacy, pale as whitewash. What happened? He says, I saw three cars with Lithuanians, drunkards, and behind them – this was a few days after the Ghetto was [emptied] – after them drove a car with lime, and he says they were driving in the direction of Poligon, where they removed the Jews. In the meantime, an order was issued that all the heads of families should gather in the central square of the Ghetto on the main street, that the Germans want to convey something. So Father says, I will go look at what they say there, so Mother says, why, look at how you are, don't go. No, no, he says: I want to know.

Interviewer [00:49:42]:

What does it mean, look at how you are?

Moshe Shutan [00:49:55]:

They said they would convey a message to the Jews.

Interviewer [00:49:58]

Yes, yes, but Mother said to Father, look at how you are - what did she mean?

Moshe Shutan [00:50:02]:

Yes, he still was, from having seen the Lithuanian cars that drove, it was then. He came and said that the Jews are going there to gather, to meet there, I will also go. Then she says, Look at how you are. No, no, he says, I want to hear what they will say there, and he went there. The Lithuanian officer was there with about ten Lithuanian policemen. If there was a German there, I don't know, I can't remember. And the officer pulls out the list and starts reading; he starts reading the list and says, whoever is in the list, move forward. My father was not on the list and so he stayed. Someone felt that something is wrong, and he also was not on the list, one Pinksu Gefer. So he, they called up one person and he wasn't there, so he came up in his place, and my father did not have time to do that. And when the list was done, whoever was left, about 15 people, they surrounded them and took them to prison. Took them to prison, and the next day they brought them all back to the Ghetto, under a Lithuanian guard. They asked the people they arrested, Where is your family. So one said, I live here, I live here, I live here, and they took also the families. When they asked my father, Where is your family, so he brought them, there was an empty house, he said, Here is when they were. And no one was there so they went. That's how we were saved. After ten days we heard in the Ghetto that they murdered all the Jews in Poligon, among them my father and the grandmother. Because those they caught, the fifteen men, they were with families, and they took them also to Poligon, to the camp. We were in shock, we didn't know how we would live, what will happen, everyone was at a loss. They no longer spoke of food, they did not speak of how you sleep, of the difficult situation. Everyone was afraid for his life, for his life. But in the meantime life went on. They started taking workers for labour and sent people to work and continued to hide in the Ghetto. On the list was my brother in law with his wife, my family wasn't, my mother and three other sisters weren't.

Interviewer [00:54:14]:

The list of labourers?

Moshe Shutan [00:54:16]:

The list of 'legals' in the Ghetto.

Interviewer [00:54:20]

That they were taken to work? From which they were taken to work?

Moshe Shutan [00:54:23]:

I will explain to you.... Of those left, the Ghetto did a list of the necessary Jews, how shall I say? The "nociker Jude."⁴⁴ So my brother in law was with my sister, and they had a daughter less than two years old. But the Lithuanians, she said then, This is my father and this is my mother, so they left the family, but they were not written on the list. They weren't among those who were legally written as existing, so they were afraid to work, because they could be caught. So we were in the Ghetto and we didn't work, but there was a problem where to get food. Anyone who was allowed to be in the Ghetto received a portion, his food portion. We didn't get anything. So then each person was looking to become legally registered. There was one girl called Ruchke Zarsier. Zarsier was a town in Lithuania. So they called her Ruchke Zarsier. She worked for the Lithuanians, she knew Lithuanian well, and there was another girl, Ruchke Rodnitzky. And she worked for the Germans. So they spoke there, they bribed them. Gave them money, presents, and they agreed to register the Jews who remained as legal. So we started going to work and receiving food as well.

Interviewer [00:56:25]:

Did you receive a certificate as to the registration?

Moshe Shutan [00:56:28]:

I don't remember. They said, You're already registered. In Ghetto Vilna they would give numbers, with us this wasn't so, and so we started working. In the meant time, what happened to us, what happened in the world at that time, because we wanted to know every day what was happening so we would get the *Völkischer Beobachter*,⁴⁵ it was a German paper, they would bring, we would work for them, we would find a newspaper, we would take and bring to the Ghetto. So reading between the lines, we kind of knew what was happening, and we came to a period where they stopped them, the Germans, by Moscow, and we said, we need to wait for the situation to improve. We passed the winter, and in February, end of February, a German came once to the Ghetto, and he says he needs 15 people for work. People were afraid to go. How come a German is looking for 15 Jews? Do we not know him? Who are the authorities? We already knew

The German concept of "useful Jews", who were designated as "needed" or "necessary" for forced ⁴⁴ labor.

The *Völkischer Beobachter* ("People's Observer") was the official newspaper of the Nazi Party from ⁴⁵ 1920 to 1945, serving as the primary propaganda publication that disseminated Nazi ideology, antisemitism, and ultranationalist views throughout Germany.

people then. Him – we did not know, suddenly some German comes, a sergeant, and says give me 15 people.

Interviewer [00:58:11]:

To whom did he come?

Moshe Shutan [00:58:12]:

To the Judenrat, they made a Judenrat, so it was the head of the Judenrat, Moyshe Grodon, this Moyshe Gordon. There was another one called Shuchman, and later there was Moyshe Gordon. So they said, so people didn't know what was going on. So the Judenrat made a list, and there was Jewish police, they made a Jewish police within the Ghetto. Within the Ghetto there like this, Arbeitsamt, it's a work agency, there was the Judenrat in itself, there was a division to help people settle in apartments or help with clothes, and there was the Jewish police.

Interviewer [00:59:05]:

Who were the people chosen for the Judenrat, the police?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:11]:

Some were volunteers, who said, I will be in the Judenrat. This Moyshe Gordon entered it naturally because he knew the Lithuanians, of course it required someone who knows them.

Interviewer [00:59:29]:

Which party did he belong to?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:30]:

He was not in the parties. And before him there was someone – did I say? There was one Shuchman who also knew the Lithuanians who were in power.

Interviewer [00:59:41]:

Why did this Shuchman stop his work at the Judenrat?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:46]:

Maybe they found that Gordon is better at managing the business.

Interviewer [00:59:50]:

Who found out?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:50]:

He has more, better connection with the....

Interviewer [00:59:55]:

Are you assuming or do you remember?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:58]:

I am assuming.

Interviewer [01:00:00]

You are assuming.

Moshe Shutan [01:00:00]:

That he had better ties with the Lithuanians.

Interviewer [01:00:03]

Meaning that you think it was a decision taken by the Jews?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:07]:

For the sake of the

Interviewer [01:00:08]:

To replace Shuchman with Gordon.

Moshe Shutan [01:00:12]:

I don't know. I don't know.

Interviewer [01:00:13]:

Shuchman stayed in the Judenrat?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:16]:

He stayed alive after the war, now I don't know where but he stayed alive. Now like this

Interviewer [01:00:25]:

The tape is done, it's been an hour and we need to stop

Interviewer [01:00:28]:

We're going to break a minute until we replace the tape.

Moshe Shutan [01:00:31]:

We haven't started yet

Interviewer [01:00:31]:

I know.

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 2 – Transcript

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Interviewer [00:00:2]:

Regarding the Judenrat, how did the Judenrat work? How did it treat the population? Was it accepted or not accepted?

Moshe Shutan [00:00:45]:

I will tell more about the Judenrat, I will get to it. Can I carry on?

Interviewer [00:00:53]:

Go ahead.

Moshe Shutan [00:00:57]:

The Judenrat made a list of 15 people, usually young, and sent them, and there was one messenger for the Judenrat, a young lad of 14-15, and he went to give to each person the note saying he should report at 08:00 tomorrow for work, and nobody reported. Ask me what happened – it's not just a few who don't turn up. A few weeks before, there was such a case in the town of Svir,⁴⁶ that a German came and said that he needs 25 workers and he took them to the town of Nowe Wilejka, they worked there, and after they finished the work, they burned them. How do we know this story? Because one of the 25 was from our town, Shike Kremnik, so they were afraid that maybe it's the same trick here, and no one went. The next morning, when the German came to take the workers and there was no one there, he started screaming. He pulled out his gun, I will kill you all if I come back tomorrow and I don't have the workers. The Judenrat again sent, and no one went, so they decided they would volunteer. So, all of the Judenrat men would volunteer, as well as anyone who also wanted to volunteer from the Ghetto, to go to work. Among those who volunteered to go with the Judenrat was one Godel Gilinsky, the brother of Motl Gilinsky, the teacher I mentioned. And people didn't know what would happen, and around the time that they should have returned from work, they came to the gate of the Ghetto: at the gate stood on one side a Lithuanian policeman and inside a Jewish policeman. People wait and see, perhaps they will come. They came, nu, a weight lifted from everyone's souls, they breathed easier, when they entered the Ghetto they were happy, thank God. This Godel, who volunteered with everyone, he worked together with Shike, with Shike Gertman. There was a workshop there for signs, and he studies – he was a painter, Shike. So, he works and Godel and a few other people worked in the workshop, and there were some work orders by the Germans, road signs or different kinds of signs.

On the town of Svir, see the Yizkor book, Hanoch Svironi (ed.), *Our Shtetl Svir* (Tel Aviv: Organization of Svir Survivors in the State of Israel, 1959). See also Herzl Weiner, *Once Upon a Time in the Town of Svir* (Tel Aviv: The Organization of Svir Survivors in Israel, 1975).

Interviewer [00:04:17]:

Inside the Ghetto

Moshe Shutan [00:04:25]:

Inside the Ghetto they worked. So Godel knew Shike, and Shike loved talking and loved showing himself. So he see that he's a fighter type, Godel does, so he says, Look here Shike, you're always saying that we should fight, it's, it's, do you know where we were working? We were working in Ochronka. That's how I say the name, there's a lightning camp there and there are weapons there. Nu, Shike hears weapons. And he immediately comes to me, Moshe, there's a warehouse with weapons, and we said to all the friends. We went to the Judenrat, so we decided we would go to the Judenrat to say that we are ready to go there and they sent us. That's how we entered the warehouse, there were weapons there, that were left from the Russians when they withdrew, so they threw many guns, machine guns, there were even 120 mm cannons.

Interviewer [00:05:34]:

What did you know about weapons then?

Moshe Shutan [00:05:43]:

I didn't know anything. I had never held a gun in my hands, but it doesn't matter, you can see how. During the Polish period, there were soldiers, there were Russian soldiers, we saw the gun and we saw the three-bolt, we saw how you put the bullet in, we saw. Now they let us work there to clean the weapon, so we took out the bolt, and you had to grease everything. So that's how we worked, we said, Oh, now there's an opportunity to steal weapons. But there were two Germans, one this Feldwebel⁴⁷ and one was called Schimke, and one was an S soldier – a simple soldier. And this soldier did not leave us alone even for one pace, and he was very bad, and we couldn't do anything. And one time he was sick, he was sick and the - Feldwebel stayed alone but he wouldn't sit with us the whole time. He would leave, come and go, so we said today is the day that we can remove weapons. But we had a problem, we weren't the only workers there, there were more people working and there were also girls, and we were afraid they would see us taking weapons, so what shall we do? There was one lad there who wasn't part of the group, called Greshka Nadel, and I went – he was about 15, and I went to him and said, Listen Greshka, you know what's the situation of the Jews, you know what our end will be according to the Germans, and we need - if we can take weapons, what do you think, should we take them or not? He says Yes, without overthinking, without thinking too much, immediately said yes. But I was still afraid, he said yes but it's a

A non-commissioned officer rank in the German military, equivalent to a sergeant or staff sergeant.⁴⁷

different story to take the weapon, he will see, maybe he would talk. So I said to him, are you ready to take? He said Yes. When he said yes, I chose an Atrizenka,⁴⁸ I said put it in the trousers. It was winter, we went with coats, so we closed them they couldn't see, and this way he also we finished work and he's with an Atrizenka in the...

Interviewer [00:08:41]:

What's an atrizenka?

Moshe Shutan [00:08:41]:

It's a rifle with a shortened barrel and butt, shortened barrel and butt, this size. And in the yard, there was a gate, and Lithuanians stood there. Lithuanian policemen guarded, because the whole time there was a guard there because it was a warehouse with weapons, and we would leave together, he would organize us in rows and walk before us and take us out of the yard. We went past and the Lithuanians saw us walking with the German, what do they care, they weren't suspicious. So, he brought the weapon, and I said to him that he should pass it to me in a toilet in the Ghetto. And he gave it to me there and I hid my Atrizenka in my attic under the sand. Abroad, the houses were built against – they were wooden houses, so to guard against fire, you had the roof beams, and they would pour sand on the beams in case of fires, the sand stops the fire. So under this sand I hid the Atrizenka. That's what I knew on that day, but the same day, Itzke Rodnitzky⁴⁹ also brought. He also brought an Atrizenka. He didn't say anything to us, he took. So like this we already had two. And when I look at it now, so me or Itzke or someone else that needed to take weapons - so that was our duty, but this Greshka, he didn't have to. And if he entered this path, then I see him as a hero. In my books he was the first who brought weapons to the Ghetto. He died. I am telling this about him, because with this I want to pay him the last respect; there is someone who claims otherwise. Now that we got the weapons we became from an ideological group to a fighting group. So we saw and we started taking from there more and more weapons, we even brought a few rifles. We would chop off the butt, and then at home we would attach the butt to the barrel and we have rifles. There were short guns and that's what we brought, and we brought lots and lots of ammunition, the bullets. It's interesting to note that there were guys working with us there from the Polish army, some guys who were in the Polish army, and they didn't think to steal weapons. One of them, Peretz Gerzul was his name, he was a gunner in the Polish army, so when he saw us hanging around the bullets, he would say to us, Guys, stop it, the German will come in and kill everyone. But he himself, there were cannons there, so when the German wasn't there he would take a shell, open the bolt of the cannon, put the shell in, and say, Here, now if I pull the rope it will go off. So I was astonished, to do something like that he's not

A rifle with a shortened barrel and butt.⁴⁸

See the testimony of Yitzhak Rudnitzki (later Arad), at the Fortunoff Archive, HVT-4103.⁴⁹

afraid, but when we go to the bullets he's all, Oy oy oy, what are you doing.... We started to receive more guys, to tell and include more guys in the groups, and we already had some 15 people, Rezpul who was a brother of David Yochai, Berl Yochai, now Shleke Michalson, Motke Bushkenitz, Reshka Beck, Shike Ligomsky, Itzke Taitz, I don't remember, I should remember them all but there were more. And among those, Shike Michalson said he has four guns. Where do you have four guns from? His uncle was once in the firefighters and he had a gun, and he must have loved guns, so he had a collection, and he hid them outside the ghetto and there was a problem taking them out, because a Lithuanian officer lived there. We didn't know what to do, when we were already a bigger group we said like this, so we decided to have a meeting and elect who would be at the head of the group and some lieutenants, and to coordinate actions, not each person separately, but in an organized manner. The first meeting was at the home of Davidke Yochai, he belonged to the group. He had a dad, he was a tanner, and his mother and the brother, Berk Yochai, and another sister, Peska. They were sent to Poligon, but they said later to the Germans that there is in Poligon one excellent tanner and they should take him out, it would be a waste of his work, so they came and took him out of Poligon, otherwise he would have been killed with everyone. So he didn't exit alone from the extermination camp, he took another ten out, he said, These are also my relatives, and so he saved more people. He himself was a soldier in the Russian army in the First World War and was also a gunner. One of his sons, Leibke, ran away to Russia and he with the family that stayed, he worked at his job so he took his two sons with him and they also worked, Dovidke and Berke also worked. He was a type, you might say, a war veteran. He didn't forget these years that he fought, and when he heard that we organized into a fighting group and want to go to the Partisans, he said it's a good idea and that's what should be done.

Interviewer [00:17:34]:

What do you mean he heard? You must have kept it hidden closely.

Moshe Shutan [00:17:37]:

From his sons, there already, with him, not us, they didn't tell, we said they could tell. There was in the group also one girl called Haike Porush, they also brought her in, they put the weapons in her place for hiding. So we chose like this, that the leader of the group be Berl Yochai, and me and one more, I can't remember his name, will be his lieutenants. And we decided to take out the four pistols, and there were guys volunteering and three guys went at night, it was winter, and they took it out, and brought the pistols. And we all the time continued to work there in the weapons warehouse. Once I come from work, and I brought bullets, and go up to the attic and I see someone walking on the attic. I look at Dovidke, Dovidke Yochai from the group, and he's white as paint. I said, what happened? He says, Midzialesky killed Greshka.

They were both in the group. How did it happen? He says, from the pistols we brought. One of them didn't have this, nu, where you put it, a holster, so I went – he says – I brought leather, leathers, and started to sew a holster for his pistol that was without a holster. In the meantime, Greshka and Miadzialesky were there, and Miadzialesky started playing with the pistol and he said, Ah, if there was a German before me I would kill him and he shot with the pistol and hit Greshka here in the throat. The minute I heard this I jumped up and ran there, I ran there. He was lying wounded, and they told us they would bring a doctor. This doctor was in the Judenrat, there was a period he was – Tarsiesky, the name was. Nyuma Tarsiesky. He was in the Judenrat, he was also a doctor. So they brought him, Greshka's family brought him, so that he sees what can be done. So he says an incident like this we have to go to the police, otherwise they will kill everyone, and he went to the Judenrat and said to them and they told the police. Until the Lithuanians come, Greshka didn't know what would happen, so I said to him Run away. He's wounded he can't run, but you run, run, run and we will come wherever. I told him to run to the Jewish cemetery and we will come there, and he didn't do it, the Jewish police came and chased us all out, then the Lithuanian police came but I wasn't there any longer and they took them took them after a few days they killed three people, both of them and one girl. How did they add the girl to this group? She fell in love with a Polish *sheigetz*,⁵⁰ he loved her terribly, so he took her from the Ghetto and hid her in his house. The Lithuanians heard about it, they arrested her and killed her with the guys. When we heard they were killed but before they were killed they were, they were, the police interrogated them, there was an interrogation, so this Ruchi Zresier, she knew they were being arrested, that the interrogation, she said that they tear their nails out from their fingers, they put their hand in the door and close it, so we were afraid they would give us away. We gathered and decided we would leave the Ghetto. That night, at 11:00 at night, we gathered by a Ghetto fence, we waited for all the guys to come and we wanted to leave. We wanted to leave, and suddenly someone walks along, we see Itzke Rodnitzky's sister, Rochke. She was very protective of him, and she saw that he's not as usual, so she followed him and so he's by the fence and more people are gathering and they want to leave. So she says, Are you crazy? You created a problem for the Ghetto and you're going to run away and leave the Ghetto?! Besides, she says, they didn't give anyone up, they held on. If you run away and tomorrow the German will know that you didn't show up for work, so there will be connections made, how come suddenly you didn't come? I suggest to you, she says, that you stay in the Ghetto. the idea of going to the Partisans is a good idea but this is not the time. When the time comes I will also want to go with you. We listened to what she said and returned each person to our home, but we left a guard by the fence, all night we left a guard. If something will happen, they they'll let everyone know and break the.... If they surround the Ghetto we will break out and run away.

In Yiddish, a "sheigetz" refers to a non-Jewish boy or young man.⁵⁰

Interviewer [00:25:06]:

I want to ask you, this doctor you were telling me about, did he go consult with the Judenrat people first?

Moshe Shutan [00:25:20]:

He went to the Judenrat, he told them, he said what's happening and that the bullet is here in his throat, if he were to cut here he would pull it out. So he says, this is something that needs to be done in a hospital, and according to the oath I gave I need to let the police know in such cases, every doctor takes an oath.

Interviewer [00:25:45]:

He meant the Jewish police?

Moshe Shutan [00:25:48]:

No no no, the.... The authorities, the local authorities, they were the Lithuanians. They went to them with presents, they wanted to kill also Greshka's family, so they gave him presents, and he left the family and killed only the son.

Interviewer [00:26:10]:

To whom did they give presents?

Moshe Shutan [00:26:15]:

To the criminal police officer, the Lithuanians. In the meantime...

Interviewer [00:25:24]:

Wait, did the Ghetto have a clinic or a hospital?

Moshe Shutan [00:26:28]

No, there was a doctor, there was a nurse, if someone needed – there was a doctor, this doctor would come and help. There was also a nurse in the Ghetto. But I will tell you the truth, there were no sick people. Apparently, people who live under fear of death are not sick, they want to live. When we saw that all the... a few days passed and it was

quiet. But in the Ghetto it became known that we exist, that there's a fighting group. We did our thing and they did theirs, they didn't touch us, and we didn't.... we did what had to be done. We got hold of weapons, we bought pistols with money. A guy from town helped us, a tanner named Kuba, he worked with Chaim Yochai. We continued working, we continued stealing, stealing weapons. And then there was the last day, that the German said we finish the work. We said, In that case, we won't be able to steal any more. So we prepared 15 guns and we decided we would come at night and take them out and bring them to the Ghetto. So when we came to the Ghetto, we put it up, we gathered, because we already had a commander, we put it to the lads, we gathered and said we must carry out this action. So they voted, some who were against it said that we're risking the Ghetto so they voted - it's interesting, all the first guys from the group, those who decided to go fight the Germans even before they entered, were for taking the weapons; all the rest who joined said no, and they were the majority and that's how it stayed.

Interviewer [00:29:02]

I have a question about the group, you're describing a relatively veteran group, which gets hold of weapons, surely you must have also gathered and talked. Did you plan any concrete plans, did you organize for this or that possibility?

Moshe Shutan [00:29:30]:

No, our goal was to go to the partisans. Until we had weapons it wasn't realistic. Once we had weapons, then we came near to leaving for the forest and we had conversations about it. This was in the winter, so there were guys who said, as long as the Ghetto exists, we should sit in the Ghetto. The more veteran ones said, no, not, we should leave. There was an incident in May '42, we suddenly heard, there was information in the Ghetto that the Germans, that Russian partisans not far, maybe 7, 8 kilometers from our town, killed two officers from our city Świąciany, two German officers. And there was with them a Polish girl who was a translator. They left her. When she came, she said that these partisans, she saw among them one guy called Markov.⁵¹ Who was Markov? Markov during the Poles, he was in the Communist resistance. He sat in Karpos Barza,

Fjodor Gregorovitch Markov was born in 1914 in a village in the Postavy region. Before the war, he ⁵¹ was a teacher of Polish language and literature at the Jewish school in Świąciany. In 1934, influenced by his Jewish communist wife Esther (Etel) Distink, he joined the Communist Party and was imprisoned for his political activities. During Soviet rule, he flourished politically, was elected to the Supreme Soviet of Belarus, and served as deputy head of the district council. With the launch of Operation Barbarossa and the German invasion, Markov was sent to a special school for training partisan commanders. In autumn 1941, he became an officer in the Red Army, and in May 1942 began operating in the forests of western Belarus. Markov gathered officers and soldiers from the Red Army who had escaped captivity and established a partisan battalion, which grew larger each month. In November 1942, Markov's battalion expanded and became the "Voroshilov Brigade of the Belarusian Republic." The first Jewish partisans under Markov's command were young people from surrounding towns who fled to the forests. Among them were Markov's former students from Świąciany, who had known him before the war.

it's a construction Lager, and then he left but it was a period that the Poles did not want to employ him. So he worked as a teacher in our Yiddish school, and he gave instruction in Polish language and Polish history. So we knew him as a good friend. He was honest, handsome, he treated Jews very fairly, for him there was no difference, we even once had a conversation about Israel and he said then, The solution for Israel is the Communist approach, so he said, it should be like this, the Jews now fight with the Arabs, and each one separately fights against the English. You should unite with the Arabs and together throw the English out and found a state for yourselves. It was – how shall I put it, it was very naïve this plan, not so simple, but this was his idea. He was also a physical education teacher, so we knew each other pretty well, and also had a run-in with him, if you can call it that, inside the school, what happened – happened, but we came out of it OK. And he treated us like equals. Now when the Russians came he became mayor, as a veteran Communist, so once they said - I studied in the Yiddish school so a guy came, In Russia the newspapers are writing now that everyone has to acquire a trade, we need potters, so we want the youth to go to trade school. Come on guys, what, shall we sit on the bench and study, study? Let's go out into the world, learn a trade and see the world. So you had to present a request. So I presented to him the request, so he says to us, If you don't want to, you don't have to do what they're asking. Not just to me he said this, also to others. No, no, what is this, we will go, we don't want to study. I came back to school, so I said to my teacher, Motel Gilinsky says, Here, I'm leaving the school, I'm going to study where you can study and gain a trade. So he said, I can accept this one going, I don't mind, that one going, I don't mind, but you? And he influenced me. Why did he insist with me? Because I was a gifted student. I was the most gifted in the class, I got A's for everything. So he convinced me to stay. So I stayed, so everyone stayed, only one left. He came back after half a year, poor guy, they robbed him of everything there, there was no food, he was with guys, how do you say, riffraff. I came back. I came back to school to study. Why am I telling this about Markov? I am telling about this Markov, that he said, you don't have to do what's written, so he must have known about these schools, so since he knew us, well, it's better that you study, sit, study and be at home. Nu, so when we heard that Markov was in the group, then there was a different incentive, there's a known guy we can go to, who is already a Partisan, that there are Partisans in the area.

Interviewer [00:36:00]:

Before this did you have any contact with them?

Moshe Shutan [00:36:02]:

No, but how would you look for it? In the meantime, what did the Germans do? So where they killed the two officers, they gathered 100 Poles from the town and they picked all the intelligenzia, and this whole *akzia* was done by the Polish police, the

Lithuanian. I happened to drive by train to the town where we worked in Ochronka with the weapons, so we would bring the weapons to a train station 12 km from our town, and back, we would return with a little train, there was a short train like this. So once I was taking the train and I saw with my own eyes an officer, a Lithuanian officer, why, I was impressed by him, he was handsome, when you walked... when they gathered all these Poles, we were just returning from work in Ochronka, and we saw them being led with many Lithuanians, Lithuanian police, one on top of the other led the group. And this officer with the gun walked at the head, among the last were three Polish women, not three, two, one that was with them that the Partisans left alive, and another one who worked for the... for these German officers. And they killed all of them there, in the Jewish cemetery when they killed them all. So when they killed Jews, the Poles would say Ziedzki, you're kikes, they take you, they kill you like this, we will not be taken. And in this sad case that they killed them, no one resisted. Who was the one person who resisted? There was in our town one *sheigetz* who was a hooligan. A youth of 17, 18, antisemitic, he would see Jews and attack them, he would attack, hit, curse. He was the only one who attacked a Lithuanian policeman, there when they killed. So they didn't kill him with a bullet but with the rifle butts. They finished him off. Among them were also two Jews, the two Jews from the Ghetto who worked for Germans, they took them too. Not important. Apart from those whom they killed in town, they also killed many from the area, they took from the villages in the area where the Partisans were and other places, and when we went with the weapons from Święciany town to the train station so the next day we saw a big grave, like six meters long, later they told us that they killed there a priest and 25 other Poles. I don't know the exact number that they killed as revenge for the Partisan *akzia*, but according to what I heard it came to thousands. When we found out there were Partisans we decided to go out and look for contact, so there was one, Shimke Levine, he also joined the group, he and his brother Levine. Since he worked, he was a cattle merchant, he would go to the villages, so he knew the roads. So one night I went out with him and we came to a village, we went 30 km and we didn't find. The farmer whom he knew said he doesn't know, and we came back. This was – I'm taking about May '42, when there was the accident with the Partisans, the incident with the Partisans, and we sent through all this period, all the summer, but in the Ghetto people started to believe, if before they didn't believe that the Germans would lose the war, after Stalingrad we had Red Army posters fall here, they brought one to the Ghetto, with my own eyes I read it, I don't know how it fell but with the pictures – it was in color, how they're leading the German prisoners, General Marshall Von Paulus and so many, they took a quarter of a million prisoner, and this really lifted our morale. But to go out to the Partisans, since we still had no contact, they didn't want, the older ones didn't want. We reached the year '43, the winter of '43, the Germans brought to our Ghetto more Jews from the towns in the area, from Belarus. They brought them and we had to house them somewhere. So where will they house them? Wherever possible, wherever there were people, there was terrible crowding. And in the end there was a Typhoid epidemic. This was a difficult winter, some people died from the illness and this - actually this doctor, Tersiesky, he worked very hard all the time to

help people. There were almost no medications, and what did the Judenrat do? They went house to house to search for sick people. If there were sick people they immediately put them in a hospital, they made a hospital in one house. By chance once my brother-in-law had a high fever, 40 degrees, and he's burning and he can't go to work like this and we knew that tomorrow they would come again to see if there are any sick people. So we covered him with a blanket, we closed the bed like this so that they can't see him, because we said, if he's there – maybe he's not sick with typhoid fever, but if he's there he will catch the disease anyway. So he stayed. After a few days he got better. But legally this was forbidden, in terms of the regulations in the Ghetto this should not have been done. But we did, people behave according to their own understanding and he got better.

Interviewer [00:46:02]:

There's a pretty long period that you're skipping over, you first talked about May '42.

Moshe Shutan [00:46:10]:

Yes, I said, all the summer we worked in all kinds of places and they brought the people from the surrounding ghettos from white Russia. In the end, in '43, I say in '43 there was an incident, ah yes. We worked in a sawmill, almost all the guys of the group together in our town. They stopped work there and told us that we need to go work somewhere else, in a different town. How was the work there? We worked in winter, it was cold. After that finally came winter and there was water, mud, water and snow and my shoes were torn, so I took my shoes off, I worked without shoes, with the guys. Then came this... the director of the sawmill, so he saw that everyone is working, I am without shoes. So he says, like this you're working? Go home. I said no, I didn't go, I didn't want to leave the guys alone because the work was very difficult and every hand was very helpful. There was there once a story that we worked in the sawmill; we put the, there was a groups of Goys that they sawed the wood and we put them on small trolleys and brought it to a machine where they get cut, it's called a Gatter, we would bring it - wait, no, we would cut and they would bring, and when we started work, so we had enough time also to sit, and it pained them, the Poles, why are we sitting and they're working? They also sat, but they thought we had it better. So one day they come, Let's switch. We had no choice – can we say no? So we switched. We started loading the wood on the trolleys, and they would cut, they would cut. We smashed our fingers and we smashed our toes and we smashed our hands until we started work and the Gatter worked on empty. We didn't bring the wood in time, and they would shout at us and they would sit and laugh at how we're being shouted at. But slowly we started entering into the work with all the energy and we started loading and the work was already easy, and we would bring and still have also time to sit. When they saw that we're already sitting they came, No, no, let's switch back. So we didn't agree. When we

finished working in the sawmill, we came to the Ghetto, then the Judenrat, one German asked for workers for a sawmill in a town called Dukest.⁵² He had a sawmill there and he was the owner of the sawmill, a German civilian. So the Judenrat, where the Germans or the Lithuanians ask for workers, they give, so they sent us.

Interviewer [00:50:41]:

All this time, Gordon is the head of the Judenrat?

Moshe Shutan [00:50:46]:

He was then the head of the Judenrat. There was a time that the doctor was there also, but this period it was Gordon, Moshe Gordon.

Interviewer [00:50:53]:

You were in contact with him? You actually met him?

Moshe Shutan [00:50:55]:

I saw him, sure, but we didn't talk. What have I got to talk, a young lad, he was already older, he had a wife, he had two daughters, one Rivka and one Nuska, he lived in the Ghetto – his situation wasn't bad, with his wife.

Interviewer [00:51:23]:

What do you mean?

Moshe Shutan [00:51:24]:

There wasn't – why, because those who left the Ghetto, they had an easier time getting food. We weren't allowed to leave the Ghetto, so what the Germans gave is what we had. For instance, my mother, I told you, was a seamstress, so sometimes outside the Ghetto they would bring her – they knew her, before the war, they knew her. So village women would come to us and would bring her something to sew, and they would then bring food. Or, while I worked at the mill, so they brought grain. So my food was apart

In a sawmill near the town of Duksztzy in the Święciany district, which was owned by a German named ⁵² Schultz, the Germans established a labor camp where approximately 70-80 Jews from Święciany and other towns worked under harsh conditions. See, Shmuel Spector, *The Encyclopedia of Jewish Communities in Poland*, Vol. 8: Vilna, Białystok, and Nowogródek Districts (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 2005), 251.

form the ration the Germans gave, I would put a handful of grain in a cup of water, boil it, and it was soup and it was good. To tell you the truth, the Director of this... how do you say in Hebrew, the CEO of the mill sent me when I was without shoes, and I'll tell you the truth, I wasn't cold, I was hot, we worked hard. They sent...

Interviewer [00:52:41]:

One second, I want to ask about this Gordon, how was he perceived in the Ghetto?

Moshe Shutan [00:52:51]:

Yes, people appreciated him, respected him, because he was a wise man, with, with an approach beyond the letter of the law, he would hear what people say, he would try to help.

Interviewer [00:53:10]:

Did he know about you guys that you're a resistance?

Moshe Shutan [00:53:14]:

Yes, of course. So the Judenrat decided to send us to camp. So we said among us, like this: If we go the camp then he will exterminate us, so there were guys who said, look, it's not death, it's work, we will come back. I said, No, I'll hide. I hid, so in the end they came from the Judenrat, they said like this, If you don't go we will take your sister, so I went. There was the same case with another friend of mine, Froyke Medielsky, with him also they said, If you don't go we take your sister, he also went. So half the guys from the group went to Dukost. There were people who were a little more rich, we were, my family was living in a very difficult state, and when I went to the camp my mother gave me half a loaf of bread with a little butter, and there were some who were given a whole loaf of bread with butter and also money. I did not have money. When we got there we started working. We arrived at four in the morning, they gave us two hours to rest. The journey took some three hours and they gave us two hours to rest, and at six in the morning we started work. You had to walk by foot, we came to the mill from the camp where they lodged us, we worked there 12 hours, from six until six in the evening. We came at six in the evening, they gave food, they gave a little black soup, like this, with beans. How much beans were there? I don't know. And those who cooked the food were also from our town, a woman called Shenke Kowarsky worked there. So I ate the food quickly, I was hungry, so I finished the bread that mother gave me with the butter. After six hours, it was at six, we came at six and at 12 at night they took us again to work. We worked 12 hours until noon. I came back, the guys were on the ... food apart

from what they gave me and I didn't have any more, so one Itzke Taitz, so he gave me some of his. But I said, This isn't a solution, how long can I carry on like this? So I went to Froyke Medielsky, I said Froyke, Let's run away. Do you agree? Yes. I asked a few more, No, no, don't want to. He agreed, I said, We run away tonight.

Interviewer [00:56:29]:

You already have shoes?

Moshe Shutan [00:56:31]:

Excuse? I had, yes I came, an hour I'm with him, about 10 at night, It was winter, snow, we left. We left there, there was a hole in the fence, we left through the hole. And where do we go? we go to the Dukest train station and we decided we would take the train to a town 12 km from our town: this town is called Nowe Świąciany, our is Alt Świąciany, and there, New, New Świąciany. Nu, so you have to catch a car coming from the front, usually from the front they come empty, So for us it was fine an empty carriage so we came, not exactly where the station is, we were maybe half a km away. We looked for a train, we looked, we didn't find, none. What did we look for? We looked for a train with carriages and an engine in the direction we want, because the rest were northbound, North is Leningrad, to the front, And here we need southbound. Suddenly, a civilian train goes past, with German soldiers, and we're walking by the train and a German sticks his head out looks at us and shouts Wo Hinden? Where are we walking, it's where.... We weren't by the station. So as he shouts, Wo Hinden? I shout to him, Nach Dukest, that we're going to the station. And he left us. We continued walking because we saw on the other side empty carriages, and we will look where the engine is tied. So he got a little scared. So I go to him and I said, If you, if they see that we're walking and we're scared, then they'll catch us immediately. But if you show that you're walking then someone will think, They must know where they're going on from here. And we got past, we got past finally we found an empty carriage, we found an empty carriage and entered. We enter, we sit in the carriage.

Interviewer [00:59:27]

The tape has ended.

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 3 – Transcript

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Interviewer [00:00:35]:

Is it tied here?

Interviewer [00:00:37]:

Ah, where's the microphone? OK, yes, yes, yes.

Moshe Shutan [00:00:53]:

It fell, is it OK now?

Interviewer [00:00:58]:

OK, we can start.

Moshe Shutan [00:01:07]:

We entered the empty carriage. I suggest you take it out. We entered the empty carriage, and we sat. Night, darkness, you can't see a thing, you can only hear passenger carriages. Suddenly, we hear someone come next to the carriage, and the carriage was with an open door, and he sat down, jumped and sat on the carriage with his feet outside, and put a flashlight inside: now there's light, you can see everything. We were quiet, we wanted to see what will happen here. Then he takes the flashlight and does like this. He guided the *maschinisch* of the engine, the engine driver, he guided him backwards and forwards. We stopped, he jumps, we heard knocking from the carriages, and we learned that if the engine beeps once, it drives forwards; if it beeps twice, it drives backwards. We heard one beep, a sign that we're going forward, and we're not moving. This man, he disengaged our carriage, and we remained standing, Oy oy oy, until we found out, we got down, and there was quiet, that guy left, this train was still standing, we sneaked forward, got on another carriage, and with the help of God, as they say, finally we heard one beep and we were moving. Even though it was winter and cold, but we were not cold. I don't know, apparently in such situations a man has a lot, a lot of heat in the body. We got to the town of Nowe Święciany, there we descended and walked to the little train. But the little train is already not a freight train but a passenger train. What did I do? How are we not afraid to travel, they could do a check and we have no documents, nothing. So I had a document. What document did I have? When we decided to run away from Dukest, this Hayim Yochai, he knew I had nothing, so he gave me fifty marks. I had those fifty marks. I heard that there's a guy there with a document, but not for this date. He said, The main thing is to have some sort of document. So I said to him, How can I get that? You had it, do you need it? He said, If you pay me I will give it to you. So I paid him the fifty marks and he gave me the document. With this document we entered.... So I had the document and we weren't afraid to travel by the passenger train. And what can happen in life, we're walking on the platform at the Święciany station, there were warehouses there and it was still dark, it was about 5 AM, when suddenly I see someone step out of the warehouse with a gun,

shouting *Stavoi*,⁵³ stop, stop. We stopped. Later I see he goes back inside. Our heart dropped when he said Stop, then he goes in and comes out with the wheelbarrow. And this wheelbarrow has only one, nu, how you say, and he pulls this stick that holds the barrow, the shaft.

Interviewer [00:05:44]

Yes.

Moshe Shutan [00:05:45]

So we saw that he got stuck there, he couldn't get out, so he shouted out to the person pushing, Stop, stop. We were afraid, we thought about us. Nu, we saw him leaving with the wheelbarrow, it wasn't directed at us, we walked. We arrived with the train, there was an examination, but they only looked at people – Lithuanian policemen – they didn't say anything to us. Now we need to go to the Ghetto. But we can't go to the Ghetto, we ran away from the Ghetto, they sent us. If we ran away, we come to the Ghetto, they will take us, send us back.

Interviewer [00:06:27]:

Wait a second, you're in Nowe Świąciany or in Świąciany?

Moshe Shutan [00:06:30]:

In Nowe Świąciany, we got to Świąciany. So we said, since we came in the morning, early, six in the morning, It was still a little dark, so we went from the train station and we came to an empty house where Jews once lived. We entered the attic and said, Like this we'll wait for dark, and in the dark, when it's dark we will come to the Ghetto so they don't see us. So we lay there all day and in the evening we came there, to the Ghetto, I came home, they saw me, oy. So I said, spread a rumour. I will hide, and you spread a rumour – not today but in a few days – that you heard I ran away from Dukest camp and you don't know where I am, maybe Germans caught me and killed m. And so it was. So it was. And once, eventually, the Judenrat found out that I do exist. They saw that the mother is not so worried that she lost a son and the family not so much, they found out. I heard that the Jewish police is coming to catch me. So I ran away from home, and ran away from a neighboring house, where I ran was the house of this Haike Porush, who was in the underground, in our group. There were many cellars with rooms with all sort of corners, so I hid there, I entered the cellar, but - and there I had with me a weapon, I took a gun, I had a gun. I said, where shall I hide here? Like here, can you hide when someone comes to look for you? So I saw, with us, in winter they would put up more windows, two pairs of windows, so that the cold does not enter; and in summer they would take them down. I see that there are such windows standing by the window, I said, there was coal in a corner. I said like this, I will hide under the glass. Why? Because you can see through glass. And if they see, they will not look. So I hid under the glass, and the officer, the commander of the Jewish police came with two policemen,

Possibly this should be – "stoi" (стой), to stand, in Russian.⁵³

and he's shouting, he says, I saw him enter here in the house, outside they are guarding, he must be here. And he walks past me, by the window, and I press myself against the wall. And the pistol is in my hand, I said like this, if he catches me, I will say to him, get out and shut up. And he didn't see me, it's better. So they thought, in any case they thought I ran away from the.... Afterwards they thought I ran away from the Ghetto. But I was in the Ghetto. Eventually they found out, this Moshe Gordon, from the Judenrat, found out eventually that I am alive and well, he sent a messenger home and said that we need to come to the Judenrat.

Interviewer [00:10:47]:

Who's 'we'?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:41]:

We're two, me and Freike Maidolsky who ran away from there.

Interviewer [00:10:46]:

What was the response of the Germans in the camp?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:50]

Don't know. He said he wouldn't do anything to us, just that we should come, he needs to clarify things. And in the Ghetto it was already known that we had run away and that we are in the Ghetto. So we came to him, so he says to us, like this, Listen, we're a structure, in this structure people are living, you can't have it that everyone does as they please. There must be some discipline. The Germans demand workers, we have no choice, we have to give them. Now you ran away, you must receive a punishment. So that they will think that it's not just lawlessness. Otherwise anyone, if I don't do to you, if you don't go to prison, anyone will do as they like and I will not rule the Ghetto and there will be lawlessness, what will become of the Ghetto? So we agreed and they put us in prison. They set a room there in the old synagogue, they set aside one room and a policeman guarded us day and night. We were three days, the guys from the group would visit us, he would let them enter. We would sing songs, and once we sang the *Internationale*. So he came, What, did you lose your minds, people will be able to hear that you are singing the *Internationale*.

Interviewer [00:12:36]:

The Germans weren't looking for you?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:38]:

No, they would arrange everything through the Judenrat. That's how I see it. Because if, say, two people ran away, they had enough workers there, they would always take more. The reaction of the Germans, what happened there I don't know, but the reaction of the Judenrat was what I told you.

Interviewer [00:13:10]:

But you don't know if the Germans addressed them in regards to you two?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:40]:

Don't know, don't know. But he asked that we go and sit in prison.

Interviewer [00:13:20]:

You entered with the weapon? You had the pistol there?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:25]:

In prison – no, I hid it at home.

Interviewer [00:13:30]:

You weren't afraid...

Moshe Shutan [00:13:31]:

Actually I also had a gun.

Interviewer [00:13:35]:

You weren't afraid of being shut up? Wasn't there....

Moshe Shutan [00:13:40]:

That the Judenrat would turn us in?

Interviewer [00:13:41]:

Yes

Moshe Shutan [00:13:42]:

I can tell you one thing, by nature I am not afraid of Jews. Of some criminal, yes, but usually, of Jews I am not afraid.

Interviewer [00:13:58]:

And the Jewish police?

Moshe Shutan [00:14:00]:

I wasn't afraid of Jews.

Interviewer [00:14:03]:

Wasn't there cause to be afraid of the Jewish police?

Moshe Shutan [00:14:08]:

Look, they gave up those two guys. But I see today that that was an unusual thing. But usually, no, of Jews I wasn't afraid.

Interviewer [00:14:25]:

So who was head of the Judenrat when they were handed over? When those two guys were handed over? Who was it then?

Moshe Shutan [00:14:33]:

It was Nyuma Tarsiesky, that doctor. They... we sat and he came to us and said, Guys, sing whatever you want, just not the *Internationale*. OK, all right. We came, one night they didn't bring wood to heat up the stove so we broke the window bar and ran away in the middle of the night. We were cold, and we ran away home and they didn't do anything to us after that. Then there was a period that... they asked me to come to the Judenrat and he explained everything to us, the guys came with us to see what will happen to us because they didn't want to give us - do what you need to do with them, so they came in and said, they agreed with Gordon's opinion, but they said like this, the officer, the police commander said that you need to hand in your weapons. We said, This - No. We told them that they are gathering money for Germans who need to be bribed, so we ask that they give us also money to buy weapons, and they agreed. As far as I know they gave thirty thousand rubles.

Interviewer [00:16:33]:

What do you mean, as far as you know?

Moshe Shutan [00:16:35]:

As far as I know the Judenrat gave us thirty thousand rubles. Because it wasn't me there when we got the money, but they said that they gave money, and they bought with the money a pistol. So you could say that the Judenrat, they were glad that we're not causing problems. And we were glad that they left us alone. At the end of 1943, Jewish policemen came from Ghetto Vilna, and they said that the Ghetto would be moved from Święciany. We gathered, we held a meeting, and this time everyone agreed that we would leave. We would leave for the forest, regardless of the partisans. We picked a forest, Berke Yochai bought a pair of binoculars. We had a map of the area, and the main thing is that we had Shimke Levine, who knew the area. This is better than a map and better than a compass, better than anything: a human as a guide. I said to my mother, I'm going to the partisans, and the first time that she found out that I have a gun in the attic, then she nearly fainted; this time she said, Go, and may your road be successful. I said goodbye to the family, mother, three sisters, brother-in-law, the little girl - Liebele they called her, she was a baby. And we left for the forest, we gathered by the fence and at night, in groups, five people left and we agreed that we would meet in a spot behind the town. The group was then 22 people, there were three girls.⁵⁴ We added more people. And we said that it all has to be incognito as they say, in quiet, so no one knows, complete secrecy, we don't take other people because we know we can only rely

On the escape of these 22 youngsters to the forests, see Sara Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial: The Short Life of the Neqama Battalion, an Independent Jewish Partisan Unit Operating during the Second World War in the Narocz Forest, Belarus," *East European Jewish Affairs* 42.1 (April 2012): 1-24.

on us. If you just take someone and you don't know who they are, it's a danger for the whole group. When we left, I was the commander of the last group of five, and two guys came along, I knew them. They said, Take us to the forest, and since there was a decision we take no one, I said, No, you cannot go. And they stayed, and this other guy comes along, Peretz Grezul, and he says I'm coming with you. I said, No, you're not coming with us. You can shoot me, he says, I'm coming with you. And he passes through by force. What am I going to do, create a hullabaloo by the fence for the Lithuanians and the Lithuanian police to hear and come? And so he went through. What do I want to say by this? What do I see here? That in life you sometimes need shoulders. You don't always have to be intelligent or quiet or humble. Sometimes you need to be pushy if it's a matter of life and death, and this Peretzke who had the audacity, he passed and then became a good partisan and helped us a lot. Those other two, I will tell about them later.

Interviewer [00:21:30]:

One second, I want to ask you. The group that was with you at Dukest, they came back to the Ghetto in the meantime?

Moshe Shutan [[00:21:35]:

Yes, they came back. They finished working there, then they sent me to work in another place. Then they sent us to Nowe Świąciany, there was a camp there, a camp which wasn't ...pretty big of ... they worked on the train. And also this Proyke worked, he was with me there. They took us, we started work at 7 AM. We worked from 7 AM, and Froyke was on the train, You had to carry these big logs on the carriage, to load the carriage. And an SS guy was watching over us. This Froyke, the SS guy thought that he wasn't walking so fast, because he wanted to run all the time, so he came up behind him and gave him a kick in the back. He jumped and held on and grabbed the log with another one and went. That's it, I said, working with these kind of guys is not for me. The next day, not the next day, that night, I ran away. There was also a Jew in charge, a Jewish policeman from Ghetto Vilna, over the whole camp, there were a few hundred people there. Among the guys there was one called Motke Gavender. He was from Dukest, a well-built, handsome guy, good looking. He was a sergeant in the Polish Army, with lots of energy and fire, and he was from the camp, they would come on Sunday. They didn't work then, so he would come to Świąciany Ghetto. So he would always sit among the guys, They won't kill Motke, I will get past them. So what would Motke do in the camp? He was so good looking that the Germans respected him and allowed him not to work, but when they would go to villages, and would take from the villagers eggs, butter, cream, then since he knew Polish they would take him with them, so he would also bring some for himself, yes, they would let him. So the guys, if say they needed saccharine for the tea, there wasn't ... there was only water, boiling water. So at Motke's you could buy 50 pills of saccharine. He would charge next to nothing and sell to whomever wanted. It was also a business for him. But in general he was a

good guy, and what would he do? He would play card there. Also girls were there. Where was I?

Interviewer [00:25:14]:

That you wanted to run away.

Moshe Shutan [00:25:17]:

Yes, so I ran away from this camp, I ran away, there was another house there with maybe ten Jews with no guard. Here there was a guard of Germans and Lithuanians, and there there was no guard at all. So I ran away there, I hid there because I did not want to go back to the Ghetto by now. I hid there one morning, ten o'clock I hear the policeman in charge from the Jewish police. From Vilna.

Interviewer [00:25:55]:

You remember a name?

Moshe Shutan [00:26:00]:

Maybe we don't say the name. And there were two girls there who cooked the food. So he says, You know, *Moyshke Shutan at usgericht*, that I ran away. He said it in German, and I said to the Germans that if they catch, that they first bring him to me and I will settle the account with him. And I am under the bed and I hear everything. They didn't say anything, he didn't know, and he went. Later, the guys there who were friends, I said to them – they would come back from work, I would lie under the bed from five when they would return until the next morning, six, when they would leave. When they left I would come out to breathe some air - the two girls knew. And when they returned I would once again lie down. After a few days I went to the Ghetto, I returned to the Ghetto. The Judenrat asked me again to work, so I came. So this Moyshe Gordon says to me like this, when I ran away I came by train, so he says, You know what, When we send you, we mustn't send you to a place with trains. It should be a remote place with no trains. But whatever, he says, We're not going to do anything to you. In the meantime, I said that Jewish policemen from Ghetto Vilna came and said that we're leaving for the forest. I told here about the camp because we spoke about how in life sometimes you need shoulders.

Interviewer [00:28:22]:

One second, I want to ask you about the arrival of these policemen from Vilna.

Moshe Shutan [00:28:28]:

Yes.

Interviewer [00:28:29]:

Can you elaborate how it happened, how did you find out that they're here, who did they talk to, what did they say?

Moshe Shutan [00:28:39]:

They came to us like this, that in Ghetto Vilna there was Jacob Gens, the commander of the Ghetto.⁵⁵ The Germans later put him in charge of all the ghettos in the area. Since he's in charge of all the ghettos in the area, he sent his people inside our ghetto. That's how the contact was formed with Vilna Ghetto. And they are also from our Ghetto, one from the Judenrat – my teacher was in the Judenrat, Motl Galinsky, so he went to Vilna. He went to Vilna Ghetto, I don't know what or for what, then he came back, since by nature he was an educator – he himself wrote an operetta for children, and he loved music and songs a lot, he was very talented in these things. So he brought to us in the Ghetto songs of the Vilna Ghetto and taught us. It's the first time we learned songs in Yiddish from Vilna Ghetto, and it lifted our spirits a little.

Interviewer [00:29:56]:

Do you remember the songs?

Moshe Shutan [00:29:58]:

One of the songs was... *Yungils, yider yider yider yider rehn pres Vilno*. I can't exactly right now, but I know the song. If you ask from Vilna Ghetto the words, *Yungs yeder vers vilno, yuron hom kaim betait*, so they will know this song and other songs that he taught us. He told us that the Vilna Ghetto is a big ghetto, twenty thousand people, that people work there, life is hard and there's order in the Ghetto, discipline, hospital, help from the Judenrat for those who need it. The Vilna Ghetto Judenrat, when there was a typhoid epidemic they helped with medicine. Well, we left for the forest. All the groups of five met up, and Schimke Levin led us, we walked maybe thirty kilometers. We came to a place where, he said Sit here, I will go in to the farmer, I know, maybe he has heard of partisans, to talk to him. He goes in, we wait maybe an hour, it was four in the morning, and then he comes back, he says, Come, led us, we walked maybe two more and he brought us to a forest and said, We will make camp here. It was cold, there was still snow under the trees. It was by a river, we could wash, so the face, not The whole body, hands and face. And there was a problem with food, how do you get food. Actually, for us it wasn't a problem, because we had weapons. So this Schimke Levine and Pretzke Gerzul, they knew the area, they knew the farmers, so they would take us, we would knock at night, a group of two or three people would go, knock on the door, the farmer would open up, give food. Armed people, he would have respect for such people, and he would give the food.⁵⁶

Interviewer [00:33:00]:

Jacob Gens (1905-1943), born in a town in the Šiauliai district, was appointed commander of the Jewish police in the Vilna ghetto in early September 1941, and in mid-July 1942 was appointed head of the ghetto, replacing Anatol Fried, who had served as chairman of the Judenrat until then. Gens was shot to death on September 14, 1943.

On the escapes from ghettos to partisan forests, see Daniela Ozacky Stern, "From Victims to Fighters: Jews in the Belarusian Partisan Forests," *S.I.M.O.N.*, 12 (2025): 116-128.

This Perez got weapons from you?

Moshe Shutan [00:33:03]:

He didn't have a weapon, not everyone came out with a weapon. Most, but not everyone. Say the girls for instance did not have weapons. So we went through a difficult period, There was rain later, the winter was ending and it was cold so we built three tents, from twigs and branches. It wasn't bad. And we lived like this. The food, what we had was not cooked. We would get from the farmer pig, which you slice, and eat it with bread. It was so wet, but at any rate the feeling was that we are free, and our main goal was to get in contact with the partisans. So wherever we would go, this Peretzke and Shimke would ask, and still no contact is made. In the mean time we sat like this for ten days and we said, the Ghetto remains, let's go see what's up in the Ghetto. Some six guys – maybe more, maybe eight – we went back to the Ghetto. I came to the family, they were glad I'm alive, that they can see me, and they say they're preparing to leave for Vilna and Kovna, they said the Święciany Ghetto, some will go to Kovna and some to Vilna.⁵⁷

Interviewer [00:35:10]:

This is March '43?

Moshe Shutan [00:35:12]:

March '43. Gens came to the Ghetto, with some of his helpers, and he told the people who gathered in the Schul.

Interviewer [00:35:30]:

This is before you came?

Moshe Shutan [00:35:32]:

Excuse me?

Interviewer [00:35:34]:

This is before you came back for a visit in the Ghetto?

Moshe Shutan [00:35:37]:

That's rights, that's right, before we left he came.

Interviewer [00:35:42]:

On April 5, 1943, the last four ghettos in the Vilna district – Święciany, Michalishki, Soly, and ⁵⁷ Oshmiana – were liquidated. Some of their residents were sent to the Vilna ghetto and labor camps. However, the majority, approximately 3,800 people, were taken to Ponar, where they were murdered by shooting. In fact, this action, which survivors call the "Kovno Action," was carried out through German deception. The Germans told the Jews of the ghettos that they were being taken to Kovno and Vilna. In reality, the main destination was Ponar, the killing valley, where they were shot. See, Daniela Ozacky Stern, "A Revolutionary Jewish Woman during the Holocaust: Hinda Deul and the Holocaust in Oszmiana, Belarus," *Tsaytshrift*, Vol. 8 (2022): 153-167.

Even before you left for the forest?

Moshe Shutan [00:35:44]

Before we left he came and said that they are eliminating Świąciany Ghetto and would take part to Kovna, part to Vilna. And he said, Don't be afraid, with us in Vilna Ghetto the Jews live, work, work, the young people don't have to be depressed, it's the opposite, you need a lot of courage, and you have to hold on in hard times, and we have even theatres in the Ghetto and the art is no less... it's not... how shall I say it?

Interviewer [00:36:31]: No less good?

Moshe Shutan [00:36:32]:

Not that it's no less good. It's not opposed to a hard life. The opposite, he said.

Interviewer [00:36:39]

You were present when he spoke?

Moshe Shutan [00:36:40]:

Yes, yes. I was present. I even took a gun. In case something happens, then there will be a war.

Interviewer [00:36:47]:

What do you mean, if something happens?

Moshe Shutan [00:36:49]:

If Lithuanians come and surround all the people.

Interviewer [00:36:54]:

You mean you didn't trust Gens?

Moshe Shutan [00:6:56]:

No.

Interviewer [00:36:58]:

Did you know then about Ponar?

Moshe Shutan [00:37:01]:

No. we knew, yes.

Interviewer [00:37:03]:

Did you know about Ponar?

Moshe Shutan [00:37:04]:

We knew, we knew. I will get to Ponar.

Interviewer [00:37:08]:

But not, at that meeting...

Moshe Shutan [00:37:10]:

There's one more, there's one more thing. After he was, so he talked. So anyway, one Jew, named Baruch Hermetz, and he says, OK, you say that you take to Vilna Ghetto people from Świeciany, but how do you know that those who are going to Kovna will get there? So he says, I will go with you. I will go with you, with the *shalon* to Kovna. Was there a choice? Could one have done anything different?

Interviewer [00:37:45]:

But why did you not believe him? Believe Gens?

Moshe Shutan [00:37:49]:

Those who went with or were attached to the Germans I did not believe. I didn't trust. And then afterwards was a decision to leave for the forest. When we decided to leave for the forest Haim Yochai said goodbye to us – he had two sons in the group, so he said goodbye to us. Before you go, he says, I want to say to you a few words. I know, he says, that you were never soldiers and didn't fight and don't know how to hold a weapon in your hand and you haven't fired one shot. But I tell you, I hope if you have a chance, if you will get to fight for your lives, then you will fight, and not just put your head in the noose. And I am glad that my boys are together with you and I wish you success and all the best, you should see yourselves as brothers and take care of one another. One should note that besides the fact that the two sons were in the partisans, were in the group, in addition one son ran away and was fighting in the Red Army, the son Leibke. And he himself, Haim, was eventually also a partisan. So these words of his moved us a lot.⁵⁸ Nu, we returned to the Ghetto, What's up? When we were already in the forest, like I said, a group of about eight people returned. So they said that they are preparing to go to Vilna Ghetto. So I thought to myself, I was already a partisan: if I was in the forest then I am a partisan, doesn't matter if I saw or didn't see Germans, my main foundation is living in the forest and getting food with weapon. The weapon is an important thing, that you can survive. My family was being sent to Kovna, so I said to them like this, Listen, if you go with me to the forest, so I thought, I have a gun, if the group agrees to receive us or not, I don't know. If they don't agree, I will be alone with the family and leave the group. And I said to them, You are going with me to the forest. And the main thing, I spoke to my brother-in-law, Avremke was his name. So I said to Mother, Mother, there's nothing to think about, we need to prepare for the road. So she says, You know I have a heart complaint, how can I survive the walking and the harsh conditions, I can't. So the little sister, Sorale, she says, I won't leave Mother. And another sister, younger, says, I won't leave Mother. Hayale. And Avremke says, How

This inspiring speech of Chaim Yochai is cited in Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial," ⁵⁸ 4-5.

can I go with a two year old girl to the forest? And my sister Rochke says, whatever my husband says, we will stay. So it turned out that no one wanted to go. Only one agreed, my sister Ester, she said I will go with you. I said to myself, if it's not the whole family, only she goes with me, then I will not take her to the forest, because the conditions are very harsh. In the meantime we hear that in Vilna Ghetto things are more or less quiet, I knew I had an uncle in Vilna Ghetto, I will take her to the uncle, she will be there, and when the situation becomes bad, I will take her then to the partisans. Another girl called Zletke from Shoschin, she asked me, If you go to Vilna, take me as well. Why did she ask me? I could have gone with the *shalon*, like others did. But like I told you, I don't go with Germans, I said, I will walk on foot, I will walk by night, I will walk by day, I will walk without a path, and I will try to get to Vilna with the sister and this girl. And when everyone left the Ghetto, they put old and sick people on carts, farmers came with carts, they put them on carts. The moment they left... everything was organized by the Jewish police from Vilna Ghetto. When they left the Ghetto, from the gate in the street, suddenly from the sides, from all the courtyards, came people, Lithuanian policemen, and accompanied the cavalcade. Not many, but say one every 50 meters. And the cavalcade was long, maybe a kilometer. I walked after them, Mother sat with my two sisters on the cart, facing backwards, I walked after the cart and finally I said to my sister and the girl, now we will slip away, and that was the last time I saw them. We walked into a courtyard, the Lithuanians didn't see us, we passed through fields, it was a Sunday, we said, On Sunday the farmers come to Świąciany for church. And in the evening they return home. So I thought, I am with two girls, I will go up to the main road, and we will walk along the main road, it will be easier and faster than through the fields, without a path. We continued walking. It was sundown, the sun was about to set. Suddenly three Lithuanian policemen with guns – like this, Stop. Now it's like this, you can't go to the Ghetto with a gun, I left it for a friend in the forest. But, I did take a grenade. It was a grenade round like an egg, a German grenade. And I said, I will not give myself up alive to the Germans, if something happens and I see there is no choice, I will blow myself up. And I walked with this grenade in my pocket. When these two policemen came out and stopped us I thought of running away, I said I will run away, but the girls won't make it, if they kill them, we'll wait and see. I stopped. One of them goes up to me, they didn't look at the girls, it was to me he came, Hands up. I raised my hands, he started searching me. He searched and felt the grenade from the outside, like I said, the grenade was round. He said, What is this? I said, An egg, and he accepted it. You will go with us, he says. They took us to the police, they had a police station, 9 km from the city of Podbrodzie,⁵⁹ from the town Podbrodzie. And there they put us in the station, locked us in a room, a wooden room, didn't say anything. We lay on the floor, we were tired, we asked for water, they gave us water. Food – we didn't have the courage to ask for food, but we asked for water, they gave us water. And we're lying on the floor, and this girl starts harassing me, Moyshe, if they start searching you and find the grenade, we're done for. And her face changes all the time, and I saw that if one of the policemen sees her face, they will see that there's something going on. So with no other

Podbrodzie is located between Świąciany and Vilna.⁵⁹

choice, I called the policeman and said, I want to leave. It was dark, you couldn't see a meter in front of you. He said to me, if you run away, I will kill them both. I went far into the field, dug the field, I dug the grenade in. I came back. We lay down, they were playing with cards. And suddenly we hear someone come. So we hear them talking. Explaining something, we didn't know Lithuanian, but one stood up. The opened the door, and a policeman says to me, he was an officer, their officer, saying, There they are, he was drunk. So they say, it's Jews. They asked me, Who are you, I said Jews. Where are you going? To the Ghetto, we said, we're going to Vilna. So he says to them, Jews, you couldn't find anything else to mess with, they go, let them go. Nu, that made us happy, hearing things like that. The night passed, next morning the policeman came with me, he brought us to Podbrodzie town. We went through the town, empty houses, everything empty, it made an impression on you, a difficult one. I went through this town more than once, and it was a town with Jews, with children, there was life there. Jews were, and here are closed windows, doors swinging on the hinges, a wind blowing through the courtyards, it made our hearts shiver. In the end he brought us to the town jail. Put us in jail. Put us in jail, there were benches and a tiny window with a bar, and it was about – before noon, at noon they brought us food. The food was really angel food, the food of angels: rice, a good soup, bread, we ate, we were full, thank God in the meantime we're living. Three days passed, we sat in jail, they didn't say anything to us, didn't interrogate us. On the fourth day the policeman comes: Come with me. He takes us, we don't know if we're being led to be killed or what. On the way I couldn't resist it any longer, I asked him, Where are you taking us? I asked in Polish. So he says, I am taking you to Vilna. OK, what will happen in Vilna we will see. We get on the train, he's guarding us the whole time. I said to myself, jumping from the train – not to jump, the girls are with me. So we got to Vilna and he brought us to the police station on Zawalna street. There was the Lithuanian police there, a station of the Lithuanian police. And there was a hall there, with many people sitting on benches. And the policeman said to us, sit here on a bench, I'll come by in a bit, and he goes into some room, and we're sitting and I see through the window, it was a low window, people walking on the street. I said to myself, jump through the window, because at the door a policeman stood and guarded. The girls can't move, we're sitting, sitting, suddenly I see a sergeant from the Jewish police go in. I wanted to shout out to him, but didn't have time, and he's already entered the room. We're sitting nearby, hungry, we didn't eat, didn't drink, we're waiting to see what will be. Suddenly this Jewish sergeant walks out with a Lithuanian officer, and the Lithuanian officer says to him, Here. So he walks over to us and says, You will come with me. And he takes us out of the police station. We go past the policeman who's guarding, he didn't say anything, and we walked. Where are you taking us? You're free to go, he says, I am leading you to Vilna Ghetto. How did you know about us? Who told you? He says, This, when we come to the Ghetto, I won't tell you on the road. We come to the Ghetto, there was *Torwach* there,

the gate guard,⁶⁰ they took us into the gate guard room. He sits by a table, Sit down, are you hungry, do you want to drink? We don't want to drink, don't want to eat, how did you [unclear] us? So he says, look, Gens has a deal with the Lithuanian officer of the Vilna police that he gives him 20,000 ruble for every Jew he catches. You're lucky that the Lithuanians who caught you did not kill you. You're lucky that the jail in Podbrodzie did not kill you. And the commander of the jail asked in Vilna what to do with you. So obviously this officer when he heard that there are Jews, so there's a living. He called Gens and Gens organized 60,000 ruble and gave me the money and I paid him now and so I released you. We said, Long live Gens, he saved us. Do you have a place to go to? I said, Thank you very much. If not we will organize a place for you. I said, Thank you, I have an uncle. And this girl said she has acquaintances. So we split up, and I went to my uncle with my sister. The uncle did not live in the Ghetto. There was another camp in Vilna, called Kaylis, there were two blocks, one not far from the other and my uncle lived in Block 2. So in the Ghetto, I said to the policeman, I want to go to Kailis⁶¹ to my uncle, so he gave us a policeman and the policeman took us, brought us to Kailis. We came to my uncle, Oh, you're alive? What do they tell us? That all the Jews that they took to Kovna, were killed. My mother was slain, my sister Rachel, her two-year-old daughter, the brother-in-law, Hayaleh the little sister, Saraleh the older sister. I had a wound in my heart. I started smoking. The short time I was at the uncle's place, it was just Passover, later it was Passover, and they conducted a Seder. There were no Matzos, there was bread. With a little soup, he prayed with a Siddur⁶² and we heard. And in the middle of the Seder my sister burst out crying. I don't know, I was uncomfortable in the face of my uncle and his family, because his whole family remained and I was a little – not annoyed but at my sister. That her behaviour, that she cries in the middle of the Seder and spoils for them the whole.... Everyone was silent, and so we passed the night, we sat on the floor, the room was small and very crowded, eight people in the room, and so I was for a certain period in Vilna Ghetto. But its didn't take a long time and I met there Shike, he also came to Vilna Ghetto. And he said to me, Look Moyshe, I am going back to the forest, you stay here because I'm not sure exactly where, and I'll come back. OK? And he went, after two weeks he came back, and we agreed we would leave to the guys in the forest. This girl Zletka asked us to take her. Like she asked me to take her to Vilna, like this she asked us to take her. It was May Third, the Third of May which is the Holiday of the Constitution for the Poles. So the Germans.... They put more guards, more Germans, more Lithuanians, so that the Poles would not do some

The gate guard at the Vilna ghetto consisted of Jewish policemen who checked those entering the ghetto to prevent smuggling of food and other items. See Aaron Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto* .140(Haifa: Moresht Publishing, 2013),

Kailis was a fur processing forced labor camp near the Vilna Ghetto, where Jewish workers and their families lived. See Daniela Ozacky Stern, "NS-Zwangsarbeits- und Vernichtungslager in Litauen als Orte der Gewalt, des Widerstands, der Rettung und Erinnerung." In: Axel Drecolli, Michael Wildt and Mitarbeit von Kolja Buchmeier (eds.), *Nationalsozialistische Konzentrationslager: Geschichte und Erinnerung* (Berlin: Metropol Verlag, 2024), 256-265; Gregory Shurr, *Notes from the Vilna Ghetto* (Tel-Aviv: Association of Jews from Vilna and Vicinity in Israel, 2002).

The *Siddur* is the primary Jewish prayer book, containing a set order of daily prayers used in Jewish worship services.

sabotage or disseminate some flyers in the city. And that very day we decided to leave. Shike had a weapon, he had a Parabellum. I had nothing, and the girl had nothing.

Interviewer [00:59:48]:

Ester stayed in the Ghetto?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:50]:

Excuse me?

Interviewer [00:59:50]:

Your sister stayed in the Ghetto?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:52]:

And my sister, I left her with my uncle. When we came, we passed the streets, so there were many policemen, there were many Germans. What did we do? We wore, Shike had two... how do you say?

Interviewer [01:00:11]:

Bands?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:12]:

Bands of train workers. So I wore one and he wore one and like this we walked the street and no one looked at us and no one asks us anything, and like this we got to the train station. Nu, there, there were a lot of Germans and a lot of Lithuanians, and inside the station German soldiers going to the front, coming back wounded. We climbed aboard the carriage, no one asks us anything because we are as if train workers. And we started to look, same business as there was from Dukest, we started to look for a carriage, this time the other way, one going to the front. But it's - they're not going empty, it's all full. We start looking, we're walking around the *shalons* and the station there is big, many tracks. A German soldier starts looking at us, we're walking and he turns his head at us, oy vey, not good, he could arrest us. I didn't think much. I walk over to him and ask him in German if he knows, [in German] from where the train goes to the city [unclear]. And he says, I don't know [in German] and I went to Thank you, thank you. And I went. We started looking for a carriage. A problem.

Interviewer [01:01:57]:

The tape is finished.

Moshe Shutan [01:01:58]:

Finished?

Interviewer [01:02:01]:

Yes.

Moshe Shutan [01:02:02]:

Nu, that was enough.

Interviewer [01:02:02]:

That was enough.

AMoshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 4 – transcript

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Interviewer [00:00:55]:

Please.

Interviewer (male)⁶³ [00:00:56]:

We're taping.

Moshe Shutan [00:00:58]:

I want to correct a mistake from the previous tape, where I said that the Jews of Świeściany were taken to Poligon a month after the Germans came. They took the Jews to Poligon after three months, around the end of September. Now, one more thing. I told in the previous tape that all the Świeściany Jews were murdered in Ponary,⁶⁴ a lot of guys escaped from there and some of them managed to escape and make it to Vilna Ghetto, but among those who escaped and were shot as they escaped were the two brothers I mentioned, Haim and Shlomo Lishonsky. They didn't manage to get to the forest, they were shot. Now I will progress from where I stopped. We were in the station of Vilna City, in the train station, and were looking for a train going in the direction of the front. Eventually we found a freight train and needed to board it, but boarding is not simple, because in the last carriage were Germans, they guarded the train. It was a freight train, and the door was open on one side and the door was closed on the other side. At the start of the war the Germans didn't guard the trains going to the front, even those who would walk about in town, in all kinds of places, they would walk with their

There are two interviewers, one man and one woman. Unless otherwise noted, "interviewer" indicates ⁶³ the woman.

Ponary (Paneriai), located approximately eleven kilometers southeast of Vilna, served as the primary ⁶⁴ execution site for Jews from the Vilna region during the Holocaust. Over a three-year period, from July 1941 to July 1944, the Nazis systematically murdered around seventy thousand people in pits that had been previously excavated at this location. While the overwhelming majority of victims were Jews, others killed at Ponary included anti-Nazi Poles, Soviet prisoners of war, Lithuanian clergy, and Roma people. The executions were carried out predominantly by shooting, making Ponary one of the most significant sites of the Holocaust in the Baltic region. See Ozacki Stern, *NS-Zwangsarbeits- und Vernichtungslager in Litauen als Orte der Gewalt, des Widerstands, der Rettung und Erinnerung*; Kazimierz Sakowicz, *Ponary Diary 1941-1943: A Bystander's Account of a Mass Murder* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 2005).

pistols. For instance, that Field Marshall I spoke about, where we worked, in Ochlonka, after the event where the partisans killed the two German officers, so he wouldn't, not only he would come with a pistol, but he would come with an automatic, with a submachine gun. We saw the Germans on one side of this carriage, sitting at the door. We moved to the other side, we advanced, found a *tambour*, we climbed on to the *tambour* the three of us and sat down, because there was a window, so that we're not seen.

Interviewer (male) [00:04:12]:

What's a *tambour*?

Moshe Shutan [00:04:15]:

What's a *tambour*? There are carriages, before you enter them there is a kind of small corridor which separates between the carriage and the corridor before the entrance, that's where we entered and sat down on the floor. After a while on the train we heard one whistle, that's a sign we're moving forward, and we started to drive. When we already left the station, we stood, we could stand already because no one will see us during the journey. The train reaches a certain station and stopped, stopped, we sat down again. And we heard Germans walking along the freight train, along the carriages, so they stood right by us, and they met with more guards and one asks the other, What are you carrying? This one says, I have 25 carriages to guard, the second one says, I have thirty, and their commander, Everything is OK, and we sat down. The train starts driving. Nu, we can breathe and relax, you can get up, we got to Nowe Święciany. We got to Nowe Święciany, before the train enters the station it slows down, so we jumped, the Germans were in the last carriage so we said goodbye to them and carried on to the town. We came to town and the girl who was with us, Zletka Misoshchin, we decided we would leave her among an acquaintance of ours in Novo Święciany. That was Kozlowsky. I will mention him again. And we said that she would be at his place and we will see, we will find the guys and take her then. Shike, I don't know how, but he, like his father, he knew the places, knew everyone, he knew where Kozlowsky lives. We came there, it was in the morning, around 10. We knocked at the door, he looked through the window there and opened the door, said, What do you want? We told him, [he said], Leave the girl and you get out of here as fast as possible so that you're not seen. So we did so. He belonged to the Communist Party, he was in the Lithuanian Resistance, and helped Jews. We continued walking, Shike and myself, alone. We walked through the town, we met a policeman, we said to him *Labas* ..., and he said to us, he replied to us, and we continued. We came some 6 km from the town of Święciany, there was a grove there, we hid and waited for the evening. Because by day, one couldn't walk. Once it was dark we set out. We came to the river of the town Święciany, a small river, by this river called Kona (Kiauna), there was a ghetto. We continued by the river, and there was there *halonka*, how do you say, grass. We hear people walking. We stopped, Who goes there? In Russian. They answered us, Who are you? By the voice I recognized Dovke Yohai. Nu, there was great joy, we went to look for them and here

by chance we found them. So he and Schimke Michalson, and a third guy, I don't remember. And I was with Shike. Where are you going? We're going into action. Where are you going? We're looking for the guys. So they say, Peretzke Grezul is with Father, with the tanner at the tanners' workshop, the attic. Go quickly and you will meet him and you will go together to the base where the group is. And we told him, Dovke Yochai, that his girlfriend is at Kozlowsky's, so he said OK, I will come already and take her.

We came to the attic of the workshop and we met there Haim Yochai with Peretz Grezul. Haim Yochai hid there, and the person who gave him food and took care of him was Koba, a Tatar who lived in Święciany. There were a few Tatar in Święciany, and he was good man, a brave man, and helped him. With Peretzke we left for the base. The base was in Cherkalisky (Cirklišķio) forest, 12 km from Święciany.

Interviewer [00:10:49]:

One second, I want to ask you about this ghetto you mentioned. Yes. Kona, right?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:55]:

Yes, the river.

Interviewer [00:10:57]:

So it was close to Święciany, this ghetto, it was part of the population of Święciany?

Moshe Shutan [00:11:01]:

The Święciany Ghetto was by the river.

Interviewer [00:11:05]:

Yes.

Moshe Shutan [00:11:06]:

By the river.

Interviewer [00:11:07]:

And this is the same ghetto you are mentioning now, this Kona Ghetto that you?

Interviewer (male) [00:11:12]:

It's not Kona Ghetto.

Interviewer [00:11:14]:

The river, but you mentioned a ghetto by the river. The ghetto was... there's no ghetto now?

Moshe Shutan [00:11:21]:

No, no, no, it's all empty. We got to the base, and he said, it's good that you met me, we left the old base. Either someone snitched, or the Germans found out, they came and

searched the forest and looked for the group. But the forest guard, who knew us, how did the forest guard know us? We were up until the first days in the forest, always two guys were guarding. Suddenly we hear someone coming, someone comes, Stop. He stops, comes over, Who are you? I am the forest guard and I came to warn you, it's not a big forest and you're lighting a fire at night, it can be seen, I happened to have heard shots, I don't know, I think you fired shots. And it can be heard. And for me, as a forest guard, for me it's not good, because it's my duty, I have to report it to the Germans that there's a group of partisans or bandits or whatever they're called. I need to turn you in, but I will not turn you in, But what do I ask? That you be quiet. Now, he was called Goyga. This Goyga, he saw that Lithuanian police with Germans are going to the forest. So he ran to the base, he knew where the base was, and said to the guys, get out quickly, so we had time to get out. They came.... They saw the three tents, so they didn't know if there were or were not, so they opened fire, and then there was no one. They burned the three tents and went. Thanks to this Goyga, you could say that the group was saved. When we came there, we met all the guys, How, they ask us, we ask them. We told them that in Ghetto Vilna, all the Jews sent to Kovna were killed in Ponary, and that the first time, a German called Weiss from the Gestapo, he said that Jews came, Jewish police came, to gather the bodies of those who ran away. So he said, here are the graves of this *Akzia*, here are the graves of this *Akzia*, and here are the Poles.... Until then in the Ghetto they didn't know, they didn't know, where they're taking them, what they're taking. Now it was already known in the Ghetto that the ones that they took, that they were murdered.

Interviewer [00:15:21]:

Weiss said this in front of all the Ghetto, or before whom did he say this? Weiss?

Moshe Shutan [00:15:25]:

In front of... the police who were there, the Jewish police, who came to pick up. Besides, they told them to take the clothes of the dead and brought whole carts with clothes and distributed it to people in the Ghetto who didn't have clothes, and at first people thought - to take, not to take, in the end they took. Now this is what we told them. They told us that they found a connection with partisans, and that two guys from our group went with the partisan called Vasya and that he needs to come back and they made an appointment with him in Bernishky Forest which is some 30 km from where we're at, and on such and such a day we will meet with him there. He, when he comes to the forest, he will give three shots, and we will respond to him with three shots, and then we will meet. We were a few days more in the base at Cerkelishky, and then when the night came we went, walked, we walked and reached the Bernishky forest. And we put one on guard duty, Moteshe Bushkenitz, he stood on guard and suddenly he hears three shots, he responds with three shots, and that's how we met. The first time we heard, partisans, partisans, and for the first time I saw a Russian partisan, a little short, a little round, a round face, a sweet face like this, gentle, he had nothing in common with a warrior, with the look of a warrior, but what? The weapon he had, so he, he had

an *automat*, a submachine gun; he had a pistol and *Finka*, a Finnish knife. And he treated us like there was no war, like nothing, we're old acquaintances, like we just met up. He says, How are you doing, OK, good, he says, listen, we walked all night, I'm tired, I'm going to sleep. And the two guys who were with him, Solka and Wolfson, and one more, I don't remember the name, they also went to sleep. He lies under the tree with his head on the trunk and slept, and we sat and waited for him to get up. At one o'clock PM he got up. He got up, says he needs to eat something. He had a bag, took out, we also had something to eat, we ate, and he says, Let's go. We looked at him, what is this Let's go, it's only one, one thirty PM, how can you walk in the middle of the day? We just walked, we were used to walking only at night, only at night we would walk to get food. And here, in the middle of the day? But we were quiet. He's an experienced partisan, what shall we tell him? So we set out, we're walking. Before we... set out, it happened that at Berka Yochai's the pistol fired and he's got a wound in the foot. So this partisan, Vasya, he also had a bandage, he took it out immediately, he said, it's nothing, the shot went through. So it will pass, in a few days it will pass. But this dude couldn't walk. So two held him, he jumped on one foot until we got to a place, he said, No, this isn't walking, he says, so we, he says, I will go get a horse and cart. He brought a cart, we put him on the cart, and we will go. The time was then three, he goes to the village, he went to the village with a few other guys, and brought a farmer with a cart. They put the dude on the cart, a few other partisans also sat on the cart, and we walk, walk, we come to the end of the forest, and in front of us is a field, and above it, over a kilometer, we saw the houses of a village. So he released the wagon bar, he released it and he drove away. I saw his face like this, he looked at us and said to himself, "osya Zhidi", he saw that we were Jews, and he drove off.

Interviewer (m) [00:21:03]:

What's the first word?

Moshe Shutan [00:21:06]:

All, all Jews. So Vasya says, I need four more guys and we will go to the village to take and replace a cart. I went, Dovidka Yochai, Yoske Rodnitzky – no, not Yoske, someone else, Srolke Wolfson went, and we got to the village. The time was three in the middle of the day. We came to the village and still hadn't entered, so Vasya says, two stay outside to guard, and he with two more entered the village to see in which house to ask for a cart. I look around, I see from afar maybe 800 meters from us, the length of the village, I see carts with big wooden logs, and by the carts black figure. I said to Srolke Wolfson, Look, what is this? He says, I don't know. I said, Let's look. We will advance, have a look. We started advancing towards them. Suddenly we saw, one after another, Lithuanian policemen, they started to run in order to surround us. We ran fast into the village, we shouted, Vaska, he came out with the two guys, we said, Policemen. He went out to the edge of the village, saw them, They're running away, he says, to the forest. We started running, we were running in parallel. They are maybe 800 meters apart from us, later it was less than that, and we are in the direction of the forest. Now

whoever gets to the forest first - wins. We had to get past a barbed wire fence, we got past it. Then they started shooting at us, and for the first time I heard bullets whistling next to me. I don't know, you don't think in such a moment, you just have a goal, as fast as possible, run, get to the forest. And the guys next to me are all running, Vaska runs first and we got almost to the forest, we saw that the Lithuanians stop, we heard more shots and we entered, we just managed to enter the edge of the forest. He said, Now we will occupy positions, so that if they go into the forest we can return fire, they should know that they must have respect for the forest, that they can't enter as they wish. But in the end we saw them retreating, and we went into the forest. We said, let's look for the guys, and it was already evening. He said, How will we look for them now in the forest, it's hard to find them, I know the guys, there are some among them like Berka Yochai, there are some like Itzke Taitz, you can trust these guys, they will know how to get to the forest, to the partisan base, I told them where it is. It was the partisan base in Kazia forest. We weren't comfortable leaving the guys, but naturally he was as a commander for us, we had to listen to him, so we went with him. We went with him, we came to a village at night, he entered to take, take a drink, so the farmer says to him, What are you doing here? He says, We want water to drink. So he says, the farmer, Run away from here, the village is full of policemen. We ran away from the village and they immediately started with flares, lighting. We lay down when there was light from the flares, and when they stopped we ran forward, there were shots, but the shots weren't on us, they just fired. They knew, there was a noise, that there's something, but what and exactly where – this they didn't know. So we got to the Disenka river, it's a pretty broad river and we needed to cross, and I knew how to swim, so did he, all the guys knew how to swim. We swam across the river and Vaska approached the *hotor*, a *hotor* is a lone house in a forest or a field, so we entered there, there was a farmer and we thought we would carry on walking, it was already dawn. So Vaska says, don't be afraid, after the river the partisans are in control, it's a danger that there will be police after the river, it's our territory. So in the morning, he gave him to eat, to drink, the farmer did. And we got to Kazian (Koziany) forest. The road there was a kind of dirt road, but it wasn't dirt, if it was dirt it would have been good, we walked in the mud. It was very difficult to walk there because it's not like here in Israel, there also in summer there are rains. After the rain then the mud was very, it stuck to us, to our shoes, it was very difficult to walk. We walked some seven kilometers in this mud, until we got to the base. We got to the base, there were trenches there, we saw partisans, on the road we also met up with partisans on horses, we saw a different world. Anyone who was in the ghetto and knew the situation, the sight of someone who was in the ghetto, the Jews there, even in the city you walked, you weren't free. The Poles were also oppressed, you saw people that the war affects them, how to say, that it affects them severely. And here – partisans, on horses, walking, talking, like this, with such freedom.⁶⁵ Nu, for us

Major works on the Soviet partisans include John Armstrong (ed.), *Soviet Partisans in World War II*⁶⁵ (Madison: The University of Wisconsin Press, 1964); Bogdan Musial, *Sowjetische Partisanen 1941-1944: Mythos und Wirklichkeit* (Paderborn: Verlag Ferdinand Schöningh, 2009); Kenneth Slepyan, *Stalin's Guerrillas: Soviet Partisans in World War II* (Lawrence, KS: University Press of Kansas, 2006).

it was encouraging. So he says to us, go rest, Vaska does. We went to rest. In the evening, the next day in the evening, no, that same evening, the guys come, our group came. They found the way and came. Nu, and now we are with the partisans.⁶⁶ What will happen? So the next morning they organized us in rows, and the commander of the *Otriad* came, named Sidiakin.⁶⁷ He was about 30 years old, blonde, with such a good face. He looks at us, says, It's good that you came to the partisans, I will receive you in my Otriad. I see that you have weapons, but not all of you. I believe you are brave. I have in my Otriad Jews, one of them is Leibke Wollak, and I wouldn't exchange Leibke Wollak for five Russian partisans. He took our oath, and we became regular partisans in Chepayev Otriad, the Otriad was called Chepayev. Another day goes past, another lineup. And he talks to us, he says to us like this, Look, we came to the forest here, not in order to sit around, but to do something. Since not all of you have weapons, go arm yourselves, find weapons. However you see fit. That's the first action I give you. OK, after he goes and gives us this mission, we sat down, how to do this? Some had, so they stayed. And he said that you, the group that will go off and get weapons, they should go with some with guns. And the rest, without guns, you will get them. And you should know that when you walk at night and you hear someone walking, you should evade them and hide, not say, even if you hear that.... Even if they say to you partisans, don't meet them but hide. You must one thing, he says, nothing is.... No side tracking, your only mission is to get the weapons. That's your mission and that's what you need to do. OK.

Interviewer [00:33:20]:

What kind of weapon did you have?

Moshe Shutan [00:33:24]:

Me.... I had a gun. I, when I worked in Ochronka, I took out a gun. There was a time I also had a pistol, also had an Atrezenka, but when we left for the partisans from the Ghetto I went with the gun from our base in Cherkalishky forest. I returned to the Ghetto, you don't return to the ghetto with a gun, so I took from a guy a grenade and left him the gun. I don't know, when we came there, the guys who had guns could stay, only some would go with the group. I didn't have the guts to say to my friend to whom I gave the gun, Listen, give me back the gun. I don't know, because without a weapon in the forest, you are not a combatant, and to take from him the gun it's as if I [unclear] I When you take a weapon from someone, how do you say, his weapon. So I left it with him, I didn't ask for it back, I said I will manage, never mind. I said, I will go with

On the Jewish partisans in World War II, see Shalom Cholvavsky, *Resistance and Partisan Struggle: 66 Belarus Jews during WWII* (Jerusalem & Tel-Aviv: Yad Vashem and Moreshet, 2001); Yitzhak Arad, *Under the Red Banner: USSR Jews Fighting Against Nazi Germany* (Tel-Aviv: The Ministry of Security Publishing, 2008); Daniela Ozacki Stern, "Militarization of Jews in Soviet Partisan Units in Lithuania and Belarus during World War II," in Grzegorz Rossolinski-Liebe (ed.), *Operation Barbarossa and Its Aftermath: New Approaches to a Complex Campaign* (New York: Berghahn Books, 2025), 107-129.

Nicolai Sidiakin was the commander of the Chapayev regiment. Sidiakin was born in Siberia, where ⁶⁷ he worked as a schoolteacher of natural sciences.

the group, they're sitting over there, he gave us a day to prepare. So I met this Leibe Wollak that he spoke about, a strong guy, light haired.

Interviewer [00:35:20]:

Where was he from?

Moshe Shutan: [00:35:22]:

He was from Kazian I think, from the town of Kazian. He said, it's good you came, there's no point to sitting in the ghetto, the ghettos were all liquidated and if there are other ghettos they will be liquidated also. And our job is to find the Germans, and with your coming to the forest, you will not only be a combatant, you have also been saved from death. And I thought that he said this to me, and I saw that there's a place for people, for Jews in the forest. Before, we thought, we didn't know how we would be received, but here I saw that we were well received. And that there's space to bring more Jews. So I said to myself, since I know that in Vilna Ghetto there's a resistance, FPO,⁶⁸ so I ... it's an idea... I got an idea that instead of looking for a gun I will go to Vilna Ghetto, I will get in contact with the resistance, I will bring combatants, I will bring Jews to the forest. And I told this to Leibke, so he said, it's true, go and tell them that there's no point to them sitting there, that their end will be death, and bring as many as possible. But how will I carry out the mission, it's not so simple, from there to Vilna is 200 kilometers and to go by yourself is very difficult; you need someone else, so that if you're resting, then someone is guarding, he sleeps, I guard him. So one Yatzke Porush from the group agreed to go with me.

Interviewer [00:38:01]:

But you also needed weapons.

Moshe Shutan [00:38:05]:

Excuse me?

Interviewer [00:38:06]:

You also need weapons.

Moshe Shutan [00:38:07]:

He had a pistol, I didn't.

⁶⁸ The FPO (*Fareynikte Partizaner Organizatsye*, or United Partisan Organization) was a Jewish resistance movement established in the Vilna ghetto on January 21, 1942, initially commanded by Yitzhak Wittenberg until his surrender to the Gestapo in July 1943. This underground organization attempted to organize armed resistance against the Nazis, acquired weapons, and encouraged ghetto inhabitants not to surrender, with some members eventually escaping to join partisan units in the surrounding forests after the ghetto's liquidation. See Daniela Ozacky Stern, "First Call for Resistance to the Nazis in the Vilna Ghetto: Let Us Not Go Like Sheep to the Slaughter," *The EHRI Document Blog* (June 12, 2019), blog.ehri-project.eu/2019/06/12/first-call-for-resistance.

Interviewer [00:38:12]:

And a permission from a commander?

Moshe Shutan [00:38:14]:

One second. So I said, I will go to Sidiakin, since he received us so nicely. I said, I will walk in, I will talk to him. And he received me. I entered his tent – everyone had, the partisans had trenches, and he had a tent. He says, Sit, what do you want? I told him. We were a group, you saw, we came with weapons, even though not all of us, but there's a possibility we can bring more combatants. And I told him about Ghetto Vilna, that there is there a resistance, they have weapons, they even have submachine guns and combatants, not just guys, and I will go to Vilna and bring them. So he looks at me, probably in his eyes I was still a kid. So he says, No, it's not for you, you will go there, Germans will catch you, will kill you. It's not so simple, he says, to go such a long way, and you still don't have experience. I insisted, insisted he agreed, Go. I said, But look, if I go, I will come there and say, I was with the partisans, and I want to take people in groups to the forest. So they will say, Who are you, what are you, who knows you anyway? So he says, so I said to him, I want you to give me a letter. Oh, a letter, he says, that – no. If the Germans capture you with a letter, it's not good. I said, Look, there are people there, there are officers in this resistance, I knew, so I heard, older people, serious, they won't listen to some kid who comes to them telling stories, they won't believe. But if I bring a letter, there's no argument. OK, I will write you a letter. He wrote me a letter. I said, Give me a stamp. Oh, a stamp, he says, If the stamp falls into the German hands, then they will forge it and we're lost. I said, They will say there that I wrote the letter by myself. It's hard, but if there's a stamp it's a different story, I will give you half a stamp. So he puts the letter like this on the table, folded it like this, and half he did on the table and gave me half a stamp. Nu, now that I had a letter from a partisan commander, I said, I already accomplished half the mission. And I came to the guys, I said to them, I'm going to Vilna Ghetto. And Shike Gertman said that he will go to Markov. Markov is in the Narocz forests. They told us that the...

Interviewer [00:42:18]:

Here, here, show me, Show me? Here.

Moshe Shutan [00:42:30]:

They told us that the Chepayev Otriad, that the commander Sidiakin belonged to Markov's Brigade, the name of the brigade was Voroshilov,⁶⁹ and it has a few bases, so one is Kazian, and the main base is in Narocz forests. So Shike Gertman, he knew Markov personally. So he said, he wants to go to him, he will speak with him. About what he will speak with him, I don't know. And with him went Srolke Wolfson. So the next day Shike and Srolke went to Narocz, and I with the group that went to get

By November 1942, the Markov regiment had grown to become the “Voroshilov Belarusian Republic”⁶⁹ Brigade.”

weapons, I went with the group, and we said, they're going around Świąciany. Until Świąciany I will go with them, and from there we will split up, and I will continue to Vilna with Itzke Porush.

Interviewer [00:43:54]:

The decision was a group decision? Who goes where? That is, you and

Moshe Shutan [00:43:59]:

Who goes, he left to us the decision who goes.

Interviewer [00:44:05]:

And how did you decide?

Moshe Shutan [00:44:07]:

We decided that a group of about eight people, eight people will go and get weapons, and I am going with them. And I will carry on to Vilna, and they will see how to get weapons. Either they will attack policemen here, Lithuanians, or German, they also heard that the farmers have weapons, have guns. And we set out, we set out. It was evening. We arrived, we walked again with these swamps, and we got once more to this river, we crossed the river. And we continued. Now the guys, while they were in the forest, they learned one thing, they learned something. What did they learn? That the roads are not so well known, and that you don't go on the main road, you go on the paths, through the forests, through fields. You have to know how to go. So they would take a *paravednik*, that's what it's called, a guide. They would go into one of the villages, take some *sheigetz* or a farmer and say to him, Look, we need to get to such and such a village. And he knows, he lives there, and so he will lead us and we will advance. We enter a village and we take a guide, it was a *sheigetz* 20, 21 years old. He walks first, and Berl Yochai – Berl Yochai was in the group, and Motshke Bushkenitz, Peretzke Gerzul and Berke Tochai walks behind him. Naturally Berke was like the leader of the group. I walked last, and before me walked Peretzke Gerzul. Suddenly I hear how Berke yells, Stoy, stop, who goes there? They answered them. The moment we heard someone driving across there, the *sheigetz* heard that something is going on and he ran off. He ran off, so me and Peretzke started to run after him to catch him. The forest was some 200 meters from the road. He goes into the forest like into the sea, disappears. So I wanted to go back to the group. So Peretzke says to me, Don't rush. I said, What's up? The guys are there. So he says, You hear, there's shouting there. Let's see what going on first and then decide what to do, so I listened to him. 200 meters from us you see figures in the dark, but what exactly are they talking about? We only heard shouting. Shouts, and then we saw some carts with horses driving off, and the guys remained in the middle of the road. When the carts drove off, it became quiet, and we advanced. We advance, we come to the guys. *A brokh* [a problem]. Those who had weapons, they took the guns. What happened? Berke shouted, Who's there, they said to him, Partisans. Who are you? Also partisans. So they came and looked at the group, there were also two

women, so he saw they're Jews, not all of them with weapons, most without weapons. You're some kind of band, he says, a group of, of, of, hanging around here, stealing from the farmers, stealing their food, and he took their weapons. And the guys said, We're from Sidiakin's Otriad, What is this? We belong to Chepayev Otriad, commander Sidiakin, he sent us on the mission. So one of the partisans who came, a short guy like this, so he says to them, You're telling me who the Chepayev Otriad partisans are? I'm the commissar there. When we got to the forest, he wasn't there, so he didn't know about us, and we said to them that we're from Chepayev group so he said it's a lie and left the guys and drove off. Itzke Porush had a pistol, his pistol was in the pocket and they didn't search; if they saw a gun on you they took it. So he kept the pistol, and one more kept a pistol. And the rest were without weapons, and I have the letter in my shirt and say to myself, what a mess this whole story is. Here they received us well, everything good, everything nice, but on the other hand we meet people like that who took our weapons. We didn't expect such treatment, we were like in shock. But I said in my heart, I started something, I will go on. We will get through this somehow. And we walked, we come to Świąciany, I said goodbye to the guys, and we arrived to Nowe Świąciany train station, and again with a passenger train, a passenger train enters the station and a German stands there looking at us. We, Itzke and myself, we put our hands in the pocket so that he thinks we have weapons. Because he sees that we're not policemen and not this. So he stands, the soldier had a gun on his shoulder and didn't notice, and I also put on the train worker band but he saw it wasn't it. We get on the carriage, we're looking at him the whole time, the train starts driving and he left us, he looked at us, the train drove off and so we set goodbye to him. We got to Vilna, before the station we jumped and entered the city from the side streets. I am walking together with him, I had a problem with him, he looked 100% like a typical Jew, you didn't have to think twice to think he's a Jew. So I said to him, Look, no matter what, I walk first, you walk behind me. OK. Where to go, you can't enter the ghetto. First of all, a Jew who walks in the city needs the yellow patch, and we didn't have the yellow patch, we walked on the sidewalk like Arians.

Interviewer (m) [00:52:26]:

You can take a drink

Moshe Shutan [00:53:28]:

And he walks after me, and suddenly I see a policeman I know walking, with a group of Jews. I said, it's dangerous to tell him that we exist, because they can see, how come two Arian are talking to Jews, I went past him. And since you can't enter the Ghetto when there's a Lithuanian policeman, so I said before then, there were two blocks in Vilna were only Jews lived, they called it Kailis. I went to Kailis, and that's where my uncle lived. So I got to my uncle, there in Kailis there was no guard, only guarding by Jewish policemen. The policeman who stood at the gate, I knew him, he knew me and let me enter, we entered, me and Itzke Porush. The uncle saw me, he was there at home with the aunt, his heart falls, Oy, the bandit comes from the forest. They were afraid

that if they catch a family with partisans, it's one sentence, one law. But what can the uncle do? Will he throw me out? He asks me, Why did you go? You were already in the ghetto, you worked a little, and in the end you went to the partisans, and here you came back. I told you, you shouldn't go, I will set you up in the ghetto and you will be in the ghetto. I said to him, I come from the forest not in order to be in the ghetto, but I have a mission. What mission do you have? I said to him, You know, there's a resistance in Vilna Ghetto. He said, There's a resistance in Vilna Ghetto? I said Yes. And I need to meet up, I said, with the commander of the resistance, with Itzik Wittenberg.⁷⁰ He didn't know who is Itzik Wittenberg. You're dealing with very dangerous things. I said to him, This is the situation. To this guy, who knew a runner from the FPO, I said to tell him that two partisans came from the forest to the ghetto. The runner was Itzik Averbuch.⁷¹ He... the next day he came to us in the morning like this, maybe 10, 11, he said, come with me. I said there are two blocks, so he took us to the other block, I am leading you now, he says, to Itzik Wittenberg, you will have a meeting with him. We entered the building through corridors he brought us to one door, they opened, and there's a man sitting there, 35 years old, a stool, a small room, a bed. He says, Come in, and this Izik Averbuch who brought us, so he went. And there was someone else there guarding. And we stayed in the room together with Wittenberg. He looks at us, What did you come for? I told him, I said I also have a letter, I gave him the letter, he opened, starts reading, he read it a few time. And Sidiakin, when he gave me the letter, he said, I, he read it to me, everything. From everything, what I remember from what was in the letter, that I ask you exit with armed groups, the young people should exit to the forest with weapons. He thought a long time, said, Nu, how did you become partisans? What did you go through? I told him, and since I was under the impression of the event where they took our weapons I told him also this story. Before this he said, OK, I will not send young people to the forest, but we will keep in touch. I will give you a man, I will give you forged documents, and you will go with him, you will take him to the forest and this will be our contact. And then we will see how things develop. After I told him about how they took our weapons, he listened, he was sad from this story. And in the end he said, OK, I will let you know when you will go with our man to the forest. Another week, it will take a week. OK, we go off. You have, he also asked do you have where to stay, I will arrange a place for you in the Ghetto. No thank you, we have. I walked off. A week passes. No answer. No answer, I met up with Izik Averbuch, I said, what's going on, he says, I still don't know, I will give you an answer tomorrow. The next day

Yitzhak (Itzik) Wittenberg was the commander of the FPO Jewish resistance organization in the Vilna⁷⁰ Ghetto. In mid-July 1943 he was arrested, managed to escape, and surrendered himself to the Gestapo in July 1943 to prevent collective punishment of the ghetto inhabitants. A Communist and experienced underground organizer, Wittenberg led efforts to acquire weapons and organize resistance within the ghetto until his death. See Chaim Lazar, *Destruction and Resistance: A History of the Partisan Movement in Vilna* (New York: Shengold Publishers, 1985), 71-75.

Yitzhak (Itzik) Averbuch, a Jewish policeman in the Vilna ghetto and also a member of the FPO⁷¹ underground, was accused of collaborating with the Germans. Later, Jewish partisans attempted to assassinate him in Vilna. He was wounded, captured by the Germans, and his subsequent fate unknown. The case associated with his name is controversial. Some claim he was guilty, while others maintain his innocence. See M. Geffen, C. Grossman, S. Cholavski, Y. Segal, A. Kovner and R. Korczak (eds.), *The Book of the Jewish Partisans* (Merhaviva: Sifriat Hapoalim, 1958), 142.

he comes, he says to me like this, that the FPO HQ decided not to send a man, not to send young people and also not to send a man. Our goal is.... For fighting in the ghetto, uprising.

Interviewer [01:01:16]

End of cassette.

Interviewer (m) [01:01:18]:

We need to change the cassette.

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 5 – Transcript

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Interviewer [00:00:27]:

Speaking....

Moshe Shutan [00:00:59]:

Averbuch told us that if we want to join the ranks of the FPO, they're willing to accept us and we would be regular combatants. I announced, I told him, that I already reached a stage where I'm already a partisan and I won't give up this privilege. After Itzik Averbuch passed on to me the message that they're not sending a man to the forest with me and also not sending young people with weapons and not willing to enroll us in the ranks of the FPO and to be regular combatants, I announced to them about this and decided that I would continue my actions as a partisan. What did I have to do? First of all, I had acquaintances in the Ghetto, friends I knew from town. And one day Shike Gertman came with Solke Wolfson. I met up with him and he told me that he's meeting with Markov, and that Markov said to him that if he's going to Vilna Ghetto to bring Jews, he should also bring him his students. We said OK, when we have such an offer from the highest officer, from the highest commander, what more do we need? We said that we would cross over to the ghetto, we would be in the ghetto itself with the guys, organize a group and leave for the forest.

Interviewer [00:03:29]:

[unclear]

Moshe Shutan [00:03:32]:

Alone, with no contact with the FPO. They didn't want, they gave up this connection, so when I met with Shike he told me that the base in Narocz is bigger than in Kazan, there's also Jews there, it's best to bring people. The instruction of the commanders was

that those who come to the forest should have weapons, only, only with weapons. And nu, this for us was a problem, because most did not have weapons and those who did, had a pistol. But in the ghetto we considered anyone with a pistol to be armed. The provincials who came to Vilna Ghetto, about 2,000 people, about 2,000 from those who were sent to Kovna ended up in Vilna Ghetto, they didn't send all of them to Vilna Ghetto, they sent 2000 people to Vilna Ghetto, not all of them came, they sent to Kovna. So they introduced into the ghetto an atmosphere of the forest, of partisans. And there was one case of one group who left, of the provincials, and in one gate came back and it was from Świąciany, he was commander of the police on the town, of the Świąciany Ghetto. He returned from the city to Vilna Ghetto and at the gate he shot a Jewish policeman. They wanted to search him and he had a pistol so he saw they wanted to take his pistol so he said I will kill you all, so they threw him in a room there, there was a detention room by the gate and they closed the door, and he started going crazy, just, I will kill you all. The moment he said I will kill you all they ran to Gens. If there was a problem in the ghetto they would run to Gens. And Gens came to Tor Wach [the ghetto gate], it was in Tor Wach, the guard of the Ghetto gate. And he shouted to Haim Hersh - his name was Haim Hersh Levine - Throw down the pistol. So he started shooting and hit one policeman in the stomach, the policeman fell. Gens had a pistol, by the sound he worked out about where he is standing, the wall was made of wood, wooden planks, and he shot and hit him, killed him.

Interviewer [00:07:22]:

He was commander of the police in Świąciany?

Moshir Shutan [00:07:27]:

He was commander of the police in Świąciany, of Świąciany Ghetto, at the time when there was a ghetto in Świąciany, but after they liquidated the ghetto he came to Vilna as one of those who came from Świąciany to Vilna, as a citizen, as a regular guy. After this incident, so I estimate that Gens saw that he's dealing here with provincials, but it's not just guys living in the ghetto and other people, but that they're endangering the ghetto, with shots fired in the ghetto they're endangering the ghetto and maybe they have ties to partisans. And he had a completely different perception, but the first thing he saw, what was burning in the ghetto, is not to let this fire spread. And he decided that all these guys who came from the forest – me, Itzke Porush, Shike Gertman, Solke Wolfson, there were other provincials who were suspects. He also arrested them, they also caught guys like that with weapons and sent them to prison in the ghetto in Lidica.⁷² So since it was against his perception, he said I will liquidate them. How? So you need to catch them. I didn't know about this. But what he talked after the incident he spoke in the ghetto, there was a *balkon* at his place there, on Rodnitzky, where the Judenrat was, and he said that the provincials are endangering the ghetto.

The prison of the Vilna Ghetto was located at 7 Lida Lane. See Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto*, 154. See also, Svenja Bethke, *Dance on the Razor's Edge: Crime and Punishment in the Nazi Ghettos*. Trans. Sharon Howe (Toronto; Buffalo; London: University of Toronto Press, 2021).

Interviewer [00:10:19]:

You heard this?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:20]:

I didn't hear it but they talked about it, at Dworzecky's there is this incident.⁷³ It was known, he spoke about it. And it's a danger for the ghetto, and it's not – this perception of going to the forest is not correct, and these people only want to save themselves, people in the ghetto need to believe that with work they will gain freedom. We who organized the group, so I met with friends, with one and another one, one came to me from Świąciany, I know him, he was a policeman in Vilna Ghetto, he was a policeman also in Świąciany, and asked me to take him to the forest, he says he has a weapon. Usually those who had a weapon didn't have a problem, I agreed, so he said there's another one who wants, another policeman who wants to go to the forest, and he also has a pistol. Who was the second guy? That was Bomke Boyarksky.⁷⁴ That Bomke Boyarksky was a Vostochnik,⁷⁵ from Russia, from Dnieperpetrovsk. He knocked about during the war and ended up in Vilna Ghetto, he was also on Oshmiana Ghetto. He got to Vilna Ghetto, or maybe he was in Grodna Ghetto? Never mind. And was a regular policeman in the ghetto. So I said, I want to see him. So he arranged a meeting between me and him. I spoke with him in the street for some 20 minutes and I liked him. Flowing talk, with a lot of temperament, sure of himself. He had the look of a combatant type and these were the types I was looking for. I said goodbye to him and went to a friend, this friend lived on Rodnitzky 6, where the Judenrat was, or next to it, I don't remember, either close by or inside the courtyard where the Judenrat was. Who was this friend? He was from the town of Ignalina,⁷⁶ I knew him from the Świąciany Ghetto. During the Poles he studied at the Gymnasium in Vilna, he was an intelligent guy, what he spoke, he thought what he said, and I liked him as a friend and we were friends inside the Ghetto in Świąciany. I went to him and I decided that I would take him to the forest. I came home, they lived all in one room, all the family, him, his mother, and his little sister Gitke. Bromberg, the Bromberg family. His father was sick, he lay in bed, and the mother was concerned from all this situation that the husband is sick, there was no lack of troubles. Now, since inside the ghetto people were against the provincials,⁷⁷ because they would bring disaster on the ghetto, so the feeling was very hard. Anyway, his father said, Ah, if the son, I heard you're going to the partisans, taking to the partisans, but you need a weapon and to buy a pistol is 20-30 thousand rubles. Where will I get this money, he says, to buy for my son so he can go to the forest? I was a merchant, he says, Moyshele, you should know that money is the world, *Gelt is a welt*. I was silent, I didn't

The reference is to Mark Dworzecky, *Jerusalem of Lithuania in Revolt and in the Holocaust* (Tel-Aviv: Israeli Labor Party publication, 1951).

On Bomke Boyarksky, see Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial," 9. Boyarksky was killed in the forests by Belarusian police gunfire in winter 1944.

Vostochnik: a man from the East who originates from the Soviet Union.⁷⁵

Ignalina is located on the border between Lithuania and Belarus.⁷⁶

The reference is to Jewish refugees who came to the ghetto from provincial towns, such as Moshe Shutan, who was originally from Świąciany.⁷⁷

say anything, she made a cup of tea with food, bread something with jam. Suddenly, we hear noise in the yard, something is going on, we look through the window - people are running, in the houses, everything is like this in a great panic, and policemen are in the yard, a lot of policemen, maybe some 20 policemen. I was [starting] to think that maybe they're looking for me also and in that moment, there was no... when the policemen came people started running so I sat with him outside on some stones at the entrance of the house and spoke to him and said to him, I will take you to the partisans. So he says to me, I have no weapon. I said, It doesn't matter. And suddenly came this panic, and people ran away, they were afraid. Jewish policemen, they didn't so much believe in the policemen, maybe they catch, the Germans want some hundred Jews, a thousand Jews, doesn't matter, so everyone was afraid. I, he says, let's run home and hide, I said, No. If they catch me in his house it's not good for them. I said, You go, I will manage somehow here. I saw a barrel, I said I'm going to get in, I'll overturn the barrel and get in under it. I saw... but they will see, there was there an old house of the building guard, there was a Polish guard, but now during the ghetto it was a ruin with no one in it. I entered there, there was a big brick oven and wall by the oven. I entered into the wall, next to the wall, between the wall and the oven I hid. I hid and I'm lying there, suddenly they came in, when the policemen came in and they say to search, one of them shines a light - it was dark there, he shines a torch, there's no one there, he leaves. He leaves and says - there's no one there. So someone outside says, But I saw him enter this courtyard, he must be there. After a few minutes they come on again, they search better, and hop - the light of the torch on the face, on my face. So they shout, there he is. Nu, when I saw they found me, what, am I going to lie there, I came out. I came out dirty from the oven's soot, so I see that they're withdrawing backwards. I walk, they withdraw. I didn't get it. Then it occurred to me, they must think I'm armed. And since it already happened that someone shot, so maybe they can also be killed. So first of all I said, Don't be afraid, I'm not armed. As soon as I said that I'm not armed, they jumped on me, caught me and took me out into the courtyard and started shouting to everyone, Come down, come down, we got him. They brought me, one held my hands here, here in my hand, the second held the other hand, like this inside the ghetto, and they brought me to the criminal police. They put me inside a room, closed like here, no windows, one electric bulb, and one sitting like on a ramp on the table, and silent. He is silent, I am also silent. Then some guy enters, his name is Zeidel, I can't remember his first name. He was the head of the criminal police in the Vilna Ghetto.⁷⁸ He walks up to me, Get up, I get up. Who are you? I told him the name. Do you know you are endangering the ghetto? Please tell me, who are your friends? I said I have friends. OK, he starts searching, he starts searching on my body and finds a note with the list of the people who are going to the forest with me. Because I made a list of those who are

On the Jewish police in the Vilna Ghetto, see Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto*, 138-149.⁷⁸ According to Einat, the head of the Criminal Department of the Jewish Police was Henryk Zagajski. For further reading on the Jewish police in the ghettos during the Holocaust, see for example Katarzyna Person, *Warsaw Ghetto Police: The Jewish Order Service during the Nazi Occupation* (New York: Cornell University Press, 2021); Dalia Ofer (ed.), *The Jewish Ghetto Police in Vilijampolė: A Document from the Kovno Ghetto* (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 2016).

going with me, so that I know, and he found it. And started reading the names. The first is Honke Upeskin, a guy from Święciany, I can't say that I don't know him. I said I know him. Where does he live? I don't know. But here, he appears on the list, how do you not know where he lives? How did you find him? I said, I met up with him in the street, I don't know where he lives. Reads onwards, those who were from Święciany I said I know them. Then he come to Bomke Boyarski, he says, Bomke Boyarski, do you know him? If I say I know him, and he's a policeman, then it's like he's a traitor. So I didn't want to warn him, I said I don't know him. The moment I said I don't know him, two slaps, with one hand and with the other hand. Tell me, he says, where do they live? That's how you know Bonke Boyarski. I said, the Święciany guys I know, I don't know where they live. Bomke Boyarski I don't know. Where in the ghetto are you? I said, no where. That's not possible, you must sleep some place. I said, I sneak into stairways and sleep in the stairways. When I said I sleep in stairways, the guy who sat up there, his name was Margolis, he came down, walks up to me, opens the shirt collar to look at the vest, and says: Tell me please, you say that you're knocking around stairways for the past week, you say, in the ghetto. How can it be that your shirt is so clean like it was just washed? And it's true, that day in the morning, my uncle sent me a clean vest and I was wearing a clean one. So, I said, My uncle sent me and I have a clean one. Tell us, where do you live? I told you. Where do you know Bomke Boyarski from? No. So he takes a rubber truncheon, and says, You, are you going to say or no? I said, I have nothing to say. *Baf*, on the face, like this. He hit me on the face, and another one, so I started hiding my face with my hands, so he threw away the truncheon, come over to me, takes out those things that ties the hands....

Interviewer (m) [00:24:32]:

Handcuffs.

Mosh Shutan [00:24:36]:

Handcuffs. He took my hands back, and tied my hands with handcuffs, now you will talk, he says. And he starts with the truncheon on the face. And he doesn't hit once here and once there, but in one place. I bled from the nose, didn't say anything, my cheek swelled up, my mouth twisted to the side. But I held on, I stood on my feet. Are you going to talk or not? I said, I have nothing to talk about. So he takes out a *kastet*, a *kastet* is something that you put on the fingers of the hand

Interviewer (m) [00:25:28]:

Knuckleduster.

Moshe Shutan [00:25:28]:

A bronze knuckleduster, and he says, if you don't speak, I will finish you here. I said, You can finish me. He lifts his hand, wants to bring it down. Suddenly, the door opens, and some high officer comes running in. He sees he's still with the hand with the ... how did you say?

Interviewer (m) [00:25:52]:

Knuckleduster.

Moshe Shutan [00:25:52]:

With the knuckleduster. He says, Wait. So, he lowers his hand. With a, a high officer, and it was with, with, with a star on the hat.

Interviewer (m) [00:26:15]:

A Jew?

Moshe Shutan [00:26:16]:

A Jew, yes, in Jewish policeman's uniform. So he says, Sit. I sit down. He sits by me and he was annoyed, he walks like this, in glasses, he takes the glasses off and cleans them, puts them back on. Tell me, he says, we're now besieging two of your guys, partisans, they went up on the roof and the police is surrounding them and they don't want to come down. Tell me, do they have weapons or not? I said, How would I know if they have weapons or not? They could shoot, he says, and if they shoot, it's a danger for the whole ghetto.

Interviewer [00:27:13]:

In which prison are you sitting?

Moshe Shutan [00:27:14]:

Please?

Interviewer [27:14]:

In which prison are you sitting?

Moshe Shutan [00:27:16]:

It wasn't a prison, it was a criminal police station.

Interviewer [00:27:24]:

The Jewish?

Moshe Shutan [00:27:26]:

Yes, the Jewish.

Interviewer [00:27:27]:

But you said that Zeidel came to interrogate you.

Moshe Shutan [00:27:32]:

Right.

Interviewer [00:27:32]:

Zeidel is German.

Moshe Shutan [00:27:32]:

No. He was a Jew. So he says to me like this, and I am the prosecutor of the ghetto, the prosecutor of the ghetto, my name is Busbaum. And it's important for me to know if they are armed, because if they shoot it's a danger to the whole ghetto. So I saw that from all this situation and from all these fancy uniforms with the hats with the big stars that they are not worth anything. That they are in a situation that the Jews are in, they are nothing like all the Jews in the same status. I said to him, Listen, why should you take a risk? Leave them alone, stand your police down, and then you're done with this whole story, if they shoot, if they don't shoot. Who are you with? I said to him, I am a partisan, I came to the ghetto, and here they caught me and look what they did to me I barely spoke. And he is interrogating me, I say, but I have nothing to speak with him. If you want me to talk, then only with Gens, I want a meeting with Gens.⁷⁹ He says, I'm in a hurry, I'm running to stand down the policemen, but I will get you this meeting. And he says to Zeidel that he should not interrogate me. And he leaves. He leaves, then this *secrétaire* sits and with Zeidel they felt miserable, here they were the big guys, and here he comes and tells them, Shut up, sit quietly. So they put me in a room, and there I was, at 6-7 in the evening, it was still light. Two policemen came, took me under the arms, one on one side and one on the other side, and like this they brought me to the Judenrat, where Gens was. There was a place there where other people were waiting to come in, there were a few rooms there, not just Gens's room, there were other Judenrat clerks. They sat me down on the second bench, the policemen, and they guarded me and I sat, I just sat next to one that I saw by his face, by his clean uniform like this, a handsome young man, I saw he's some hotshot officer in Vilna Ghetto. And he's smoking. I said to him, maybe you give me a cigarette? Oh, please, he says. Gives me a cigarette, takes a lighter, lights it up for me. I said to him, You've enjoyed yourselves here, like a *paritz* (serf-owner), high status, you smoke such good cigarettes, so good, with us the partisans we smoke tree bark. So he said to me I am Levas, the head of the Ghetto gate guard.⁸⁰ I said to him, One of the chief beaters of the ghetto. You can't tell, he says to me, who's in the right. I told him, Yes, the Jewish police in yarmulkas, good kids. So he says to me, The Jewish police will prove itself. You are kidding yourselves. So he says to me, We will see... I say to him, You're walking down a slippery slope. So he says to me, Those who are afraid of slipping shouldn't walk. I look, such a gentle face, gentle like this, and I couldn't understand how such a gentle face has such a corrupt nature. In the end, they told me to enter Gens's room. The two policemen took me and put me in the room, they said to me, then Gens made a gesture to the two policemen

Gens is Jacob Gens, the head of the Vilna Ghetto Judenrat. For more on Gens, see N. N. Shneidman,⁷⁹ *The Three Tragic Heroes of the Vilnius Ghetto: Witenberg, Sheinbaum, Gens* (Oakville, ON: Mosaic Press, 2002).

Meir Levas was the commander of the gate guard in the Vilna Ghetto and according to several⁸⁰ testimonies was known for his cruelty toward the ghetto residents.

that they should leave. They left, I remained by the door. Next to a work desk, an office desk. On one side of the desk stood two *fauteuils*, sofas, Gens sat on one sofa and the second in the second sofa was Salk Dessler.⁸¹ I already knew Gens when he was in Świąciany, Salk Dessler I saw for the first time. So he looks at me, Gens, *Yatel*, come here. I came over. Sit down. I – he says – I'm taken aback. You partisans are combatants, but what kind of combatants are you when you're walking around with lists of friends in the pockets? If the Germans – we caught you, the Jews, but if the Germans had caught you? I was silent, what can I say, he is right. Listen, he says, you came to the forest, to take people out, and you're spoiling for me here all the... all the life in the ghetto, all the perception of life in the ghetto. And you are endangering the ghetto, I won't let you do this. From where – he says to me, What do you want, what – tell me, you say you want to save Jews? How many – he says – will you save? Two hundred, three hundred, five hundred Jews you will take out. If I find out that they're liquidating the ghetto, I will tell Jews, Run away, and five hundred people will also run away, maybe more. So for this, you need to endanger the ghetto? Before the time? I know, he says, that in the ghetto, the ghetto is a prison cell, and the people of the ghetto are condemned to death, but when they will carry out the sentence, this we don't know. If it's in my power to save Jews, I will fight that they will live longer, I will fight, not even for a day, even for every hour. Who gave you the right to shorten the ghetto's time and endanger the lives of women and children and old people?⁸² I was silent, not against such arguments, I didn't have what to answer him. But anyway, I said to him, Look, I'm a partisan, and my mission was to come to the ghetto and take out people, and if you object, then the partisans in the forest will know that you objected and that you didn't let us do this. And if young people will leave the ghetto to the forest to fight the Germans, it will not endanger the ghetto. Because otherwise, what will they say, that they all sat in the ghetto and waited until the last moment. I said, let the Jews fight, let them leave for the forest. So that they won't say that no one went and no one did anything. He thought and thought, and said to me, Listen, do you know Bomke Boyarski? I said Yes. And the other one you know? Yes. He left the room, called someone and sat down in his place. He said, tell me your story. I told him. He said, Listen, for me, that I killed Haim Hershke Levine from Świąciany at the gate of the ghetto, this was the first Jew I killed. And don't think that I am against Jews. I am sitting here in order to save them, in order to help them. And Dessler sits and says, What do you think, that we wouldn't also go to the partisans? We would also go to the partisans. Gens was, he says, a partisan also when he was young. In the Lithuanian army, Gens was a captain in the Lithuanian army. He was also a combatant. But how can we leave the ghetto? You don't care, but we are responsible for the ghetto. After some 20 minutes, half an hour, the door opens and this policeman comes in with Bonke Boyarski. First the policeman comes in, the first. He was white as a sheet. What did I find out later? That when they searched us in order to

David (Salek) Dessler was the commander of the Jewish Police in the Vilna Ghetto.⁸¹

This section of Moshe Shutan's testimony reveals a central debate regarding the ambivalent role of ⁸² Judenrat leaders during the Holocaust. For recent research examining *Judenräte* in various locations, see Laurien Vastenhout and Jan Láníček (eds.), *"Jewish Councils" in Nazi Europe, 1938-1945* (Göttingen: Wallstein Verlag, 2025).

catch us they were arrested. When during the interrogation at Zeidel's, Zeidel said to me, What are you telling me that you don't know Bomke Boyarski, when we saw you for 20 minutes standing and talking with him in the street. So they also stopped him, with the second. And he was white as a sheet. I saw his face and was scared, I said, I haven't seen my face either. So I said to him. Don't worry, everything will be all right. Gens said to him, Sit down, he sits down. After a few minutes they put in the room Bomke Boyarski. Do you know him? He asks him. He says no. He asks me, Do you know him? I said Yes. Then Bomke later told me that if he had had a knife, he would have stabbed me. Killed me. The reason why I said that I do know them, is that the moment Gens told me that he killed the first Jew, and that it's not his fault, so I saw that he's like justifying himself to me. I said, if he's justifying himself to me, then the situation is not so bad. In the end when we talked of the partisans, we spoke of the ghetto, so he says to me like this, Look, there is in the ghetto FPO, and to tell you that they are endangering the ghetto like this, like you the partisans do – no, because they sit quietly and don't do anything, if they have weapons, I can't do anything against it. But, he says, I did, I did – not raids, how do you say, he looked at their place, made, nu, revisions,

Interviewer [00:42:28]:

Searches

Moshe Shutan [00:42:34]:

Searches. So he says, you know, I was in a few places, I saw hidden weapons, and I took it, it belonged to the FPO guys. But there were a few places, he says, where the weapons were in my hands and I left. Do you know why, he says? Because those who can't handle weapons shouldn't handle weapons. Those who hid well, I left them, they're allowed to have weapons. I said, I ask you that if you don't let us leave, I will let the partisans know that you objected to Jews leaving for the forest. I will let you leave, he says, but you should know, tomorrow morning with your group you should not be in the ghetto. I said I need to leave through the gate. I will give an order to Levas that he will let you leave, because from the ghetto groups usually left – work groups, each group had its accompaniment, a policeman or a brigadier, and in the rest of the ghetto the police that stood there they knew it, but a Jew or a group that they don't know, can't leave. So Gens gave me the opportunity, he said he would tell Levas to let us leave. I ask you one thing, that you shouldn't have the ghetto numbers, that if you're caught you don't belong to Vilna Ghetto. They will come complaining to me, I don't know. Now he asked for one more thing, I want, I will let you leave, but the weapons you must hand over. I said to him, That's out of the question, What will I do, hand you the weapon so that you say we were caught in Vilna with weapons, that's a grave thing, no weapons means less trouble. But what will I do if I come to the ghetto gate and your police surrounds us and you arrest us, send us to Lideska⁸³ or hand us over to the Germans? I don't believe you, with weapons we won't give. OK. I said, Listen, there's one more

He means the Ghetto prison.⁸³

thing. I am going to the forest, so Dessler says, Dessler says like this, Dessler says, you're going but don't come here again. If you come back, you should know that if I see you in the street, with no warning I will kill you. So I ask Gens, Tell me please, you're a commander in the army. If a commander gives a soldier an order, to do some mission, can he say no? If Markov sends me to the ghetto, I will go, even if I risk my life. So he says, OK, but if you come, first thing come to me. I said OK. We talked more, it's difficult for me to remember now, because I sat with him until after 11 o'clock. I said to him, One more thing. This guy Shlomo Yehilchek told me he has a friend, Reuvke Feigel, and this Reuvke Feigel was caught with weapons and he's sitting in the Jewish prison of the ghetto, in Lideska, the prison was called Lideska, and I knew that there one more sitting there who was caught with weapons and that when the Germans ask for people they are the first to go. I said to him, Listen, I have two friends of mine who are sitting in your prison. I ask, release them, I want to take them to the forest. OK. Before we part, he calls one, Bagel, Bagel was the commander of the ghetto prison.⁸⁴ He calls Bagel and says to him, Listen, he claims that there are in prison two guys, I don't know them, and maybe you don't know them, you go with them and they will already say who it is and release them. I said to him, How, all the night, I need to gather up all the guys in the night, how will I go, it's forbidden to walk at night in the ghetto. So here, he says, your two policemen will go with you, Bomke Boyarski and the other [unclear]. I said OK. So we went with Bagel with the two policemen, we went to the prison, it was dark, the time was 12 at night. We took them out, and to my great surprise when I said to them You're free, you will come with me to the forest, they both said that they're not going. This Feigel said to Reuvke, I still have time, and the other one said there will yet be time to go. I need a weapon, yes, but as to when to leave, the time will come. They didn't want – OK, they didn't want. All night I went and I found Shike Gertman, Srolke, all the guys on the list. And in the early morning – I didn't sleep all night, in the early morning I came to the ghetto gate, we gathered there, there was a group of about 20 people. And they're looking at me, and they're saying, Look at how you look, how will you go to the forest like this, how will you come? So I thought like this, what, will I tell the partisans that the Jews beat me up? But I had no choice, this was on the side, the mouth all swollen, the nose swollen, the eyes, one eye was red – I said this is the situation, this is what we have.

Interviewer [00:50:32]:

Were there some people inside the ghetto whom you had a hard time convincing to leave with you?

Moshe Shutan [00:50:42]:

No, no, most wanted to leave, I can't say that all wanted to go to the partisans, I can't say. But all those I met asked me to take them to the partisans. To my great sorrow I can't take them all, I had one case where someone asked, from Święciany, he said take me to the forest, and the group was already big enough. And he didn't have a weapon.

Ferdinand Bagel was the commander of the prison. See Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto*, 154.⁸⁴

I said I will see – this is before the case where they were caught and one guy comes, says I have a weapon, how did you buy the weapon? I have money. So I had to choose between the two. Whom shall I take. The order was to come with weapons. So I need to take him, rather than the other guy with no weapon. You told me like this, the one without a weapon I knew him, he worked hard in the ghetto, he had no acquaintances, he barely lived. The one with the pistol had food, he had money for the pistol, in ghetto terms he lived well. I said, Look, look, he who is buried in the earth, so he should stay in the earth and he who lives well, all roads are open before him – I said no, I will take the poor guy.

Interviewer [00:52:45]:

What about Markov's students?

Moshe Shutan [00:52:49]:

Some, some we took. There were also women who wanted to leave, they were ready for anything. One said, she said to me, what have morals got to do with me if I don't live.

Interviewer (m) [00:53:16]:

Why did she have to say something like that?

Moshe Shutan [00:53:20]:

You don't understand? She wanted to give herself up, only that I take her to the forest. And she said, What have morals got to do with me, I'm just 18, if I don't live. These are the stories when I was in the ghetto, by the time we got organized and we're by the gate. By the gate I took from all the guys the numbers, I gave it to Levas, he gave me some five-six packets of cigarettes. At Gen's place I also asked that he give me bandages, with iodine, he gave me a package.

Interviewer [00:54:17]:

What about food?

Moshe Shutan [00:54:19]:

Food is not a problem, it's on the road, at the farmers. And Levas said, Please, the gate is open, go in peace, and we left. We left, now the person leading us was Shike Gertman, because he came from Narocz, so he already knew the way. So he was he was always pushing to be first to go, always. And I am the exact opposite, I would always go last. Ask me why, why did I go last? I will tell you, there were some who had a hard time walking, they can stay behind, and guys who were never on the road, who aren't familiar with walking at night, if something will happen then they will get lost. So I said I will keep an eye on them, that's why I go last. We arrived, we arrived safely at Narocz base. We passed through fields, through forests, we passed rivers – the Vilenaks, the Vilenaks river, the Vila, we had to get past and we got to the Narocz forests. Before the forest

was a village, Sheremshnitsa. And this village was completely burned, why – half burned, why? Because the Germans in the winter of '43 did a blockade, so the first thing they burned the village by the partisan forest, as collaborators.⁸⁵ Now this forest is called Narocz forest, because it is by Narocz lake, this was the biggest lake in Poland, some 10 km by 20 is its size, and the view is so beautiful. And we are by the lake, we passed through the village and we enter into the road, we saw partisans coming across, and we entered into the forest. By the forest was a guard and they stopped us, Who are you? We said, We were sent on Markov's errand and now we came back to the forest. He let us pass. We came to the base, we came to the base, there were some Jews there, one was called Blat, Itzik Blat, one of the Jewish partisan heroes, he was killed.⁸⁶ Also Leibke Woliak was killed in one of his actions.⁸⁷ And we found there Jews from the surrounding town, families there were, whole families, even - little children we didn't see, but say age 16, 17, and older, say age 40 and even 50. I felt good among Jews. But when we went to report to Markov, after we came, we went to report to Markov that we arrived from Vilna. So Shike and me went. He received us, he's sitting in a spacious tent and by him is the commander of the HQ. Well guys, how are you feeling? How was the road? OK. What will you drink? What will we drink? He says, I will tell you what you will drink, you will drink milk. There was a jar by the side, a jar with milk, he puts four glasses, himself, the officer from HQ, and we two. Three, three, three glasses, in three glasses he puts the milk, and for the fourth he takes out a bottle of *samogonka*⁸⁸ and puts in the fourth. Him and us we drank the milk, the HQ commander drank the *samogonka*. Cheers, he says to the commander, you see, these are... not children, my students. And he asks us, How's it going in the ghetto? I don't know from where, Shike found a pamphlet. From where, he took the pamphlet that was in Vilna city, not in the ghetto. And the pamphlet was for May 1st, in Polish, it called on the population to resist the Germans, not to go to work camps in Germany but to run away. And to do sabotage, so he showed Markov the pamphlet, so he thought that there in Vilna they would soon liquidate the Germans. And Shike had.... He could persuade, he had such a flowing and self-confident way of speaking and so he influenced him. So he said, You brought a group, we said yes. So we told him that not only is there resistance in Vilna Ghetto but also resistance in the city, Polish and Lithuanian, and this resistance is what we heard from the communists.

On the German fight against the partisans, see for example, Ben Shepherd, *War in the Wild East: The German Army and Soviet Partisans* (Cambridge, Mass, London: Harvard University Press, 2004); Philip W. Blood, *Hitlers Bandit Hunters: The SS and Nazi Occupation of Europe* (Washington D.C.: Potomac Books, 2006).

Itzik Blat was born in Globoki, and during the *Aktion* managed to escape to the forests. He was a brave⁸⁶ partisan, considered by his commanders as a hero, and was killed during a partisan mission on January 19, 1944. See Yechiel Gernstein and Moshe Kahanovitz (eds.), *The Lexicon of Bravery* (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 1965), 90-91.

Leib Woliak was born in a village near Świąciany. After losing his family in deadly *Aktionen* he⁸⁷ managed to escape to the forests and organized a Jewish partisan unit of approximately 50 fighters. He was killed with other partisans from his group during an ambush. See *The Lexicon of Bravery*, 147-148. Homemade alcoholic drink, common among the peasants.⁸⁸

Interviewer [00:01:48]:

How did you hear it?

Moshe Shutan [01:01:50]:

In Vilna Ghetto.

Interviewer [01:01:56]

Tape has ended.

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 6 – Transcript

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Moshe Shutan [00:00:38]:

Where was I, just a second, where was I? At Markov's.

Interviewer [00:00:45]:

They drank the...

Moshe Shutan [00:00:47]:

They already drank, we drank milk.

Interviewer [00:00:50]:

[the camera is] Running

Moshe Shutan [00:00:55]:

Markov was so impressed by what Shike told him that he asked us how we enter the ghetto, how we do it, the whole way. So he said, We took the train. What, he said, you took the train? It's full of Germans. So he says, And how did you enter the Ghetto? We told him how. So he says that he's heard that there's a resistance there, in the city and in the ghetto, so he says, Maybe I can go with you? Then we got scared, I got scared. Why did I get scared? If he goes with us, his rank is *polkovnik*, brigade commander. If we go and fall into German hands, or he gets killed, they will say, Because of those two the commander was killed. I didn't feel like going and risking in Vilna Ghetto or Vilna city with an officer with such a high rank. So his commander said, Listen comrade, *tovarich*, I see that the guys sitting here, they can be trusted and you cannot leave the brigade. Let them go if you want them to go. So he considered and gave up his idea. Anyway, he was so much under the impression of what Shike told him that this idea came into his head. Suddenly, someone comes in, his adjutant, and says someone want to come,

the commissar of the Lithuanian Brigade, Jurgis.⁸⁹ So he says, Let him in. Jurgis comes in, He comes in, and nu, they greet one another, Markov says to him, Please sit, he sits down. Yes, he says, what did you want to say? So he says, I heard that two guys just came from Vilna, and they are from the region of Lithuania, and since I am the commander of the Lithuanian Brigade, the commissar of the Lithuanian Brigade, I can take them to me. So Markov says, Here they are. So he asks us, Jurgis, Nu, what do you say? I looked – what, I should betray Markov, I should leave him and go over to Jurgis? I don't know Jurgis, I heard that he's a Jew, everything is OK, but anyway, the connection, the old connection I had with Markov as a teacher whom I knew, who was kind-hearted, and here, look at his treatment now to all our guys. So Markov says to him, Look, if you want to take them you can take them. It's just that I now gave them a mission, after they complete this action, then they can go to you. What do you say? He asks us. And we said, both of us, We want to stay with you. So Jurgis got up and went. And he says, Listen, I will give you a mission, to go to Vilna Ghetto and get in contact with the resistance in the city and bring me one of them, bring him to the forest. And inside the Ghetto, the resistance, since I heard that Wittenberg is a communist and I as a brigade commander am also a communist, I have the right to order him to the forest, like a [unclear] order. He said, I will give you a letter for Wittenberg and you will go back to Vilna and bring people.

Interviewer [00:06:49]:

You already had weapons?

Moshe Shutan [00:06:29]:

No, you reminded me. I said, I don't have a weapon, so the commander of the HQ took from some place a Nagan with three bullets and gives to me. I take the Nagan, I try to put the bullets in and they don't fit in, I said, What did you give me? He said, That's what I have. I took it. And with this weapon, with Shike, they gave us a letter, and we said goodbye to our acquaintances in the forest and all that, and we started off again to Vilna Ghetto. Shike had a girlfriend, Haike Porus. So she said that she want to go join us. She also wants to go. So we said, we will ask Markov. We said to Markov, he said to Markov, Look, there's a girl who wants to go. So he said, You, this is better, because they see two guys and a girl, they won't think so much that you're partisans, good idea.⁹⁰

Jurgis, whose real name was Genrikas Zimanas (1910-1985), was born to a prosperous Jewish family⁸⁹ in Marijampolė and exemplifies the complex position of Jewish Communists in the Lithuanian resistance movement. A fluent Lithuanian speaker who worked as a grammar teacher in Ukmergė and Kaunas, Zimanas operated under the nom de guerre "Jurgis" as political commissar of the partisan group "Žalgiris" (Green Forest), which he had helped establish in the Naroch forests by autumn 1942, where his leadership would navigate the delicate balance between Soviet partisan objectives and Lithuanian national identity. See Dov Levin, Ziman (Zimanas), "The Lifestyle of a Jewish Communist Leader in Lithuania," *Shvut* 1 (1972): 95-109.

For further reading on women in partisan units, see Daniela Ozacky Stern, "Heroines of the Forest: ⁹⁰ Jewish Women in Partisan Units in Lithuania and Belarus," in: L. Weintrob and J. T. Baumel-Schwartz (eds.), *Heroines of the Holocaust: Reframing Resistance and Courage in Genocide* (Oxford: Routledge, 2024), 190-202.

Now, he says, you will leave, rest three days and you will be on your way. Today before you leave, come see me.

Interviewer (f) [00:07:59]:

So about the girls, there was some policy? Whether to bring girls or no?

Mosh Shutan [00:08:07]:

He didn't note it, didn't note it.

Interviewer (f) [00:08:09]:

And you don't ask?

Moshe Shutan [00:08:10]:

He only said, we didn't ask, but he only said, with weapons. Young people with weapons. He said, Why are they sitting there? They will all be killed in any case, you have nothing to wait for, for the Germans' mercy, and it's better you come to the forest.

Interviewer (f) [00:08:26]:

In the first group you took out, did you take out any girls in the end?

Moshe Shutan [00:08:33]:

In the first group? No, there weren't any. There weren't any. So he said like this, The day before you leave, come see me. We, before we prepared to leave, he called us, and there in his tent were two partisans. One brawny like this, the other thin, older. So he says to the brawny guy, his name was Vaska. So he says, Listen, here are the two guys, you will go with them as far as Podbrozie. Podbrozie is some 50 km from Vilna. You have a mission to go to Podbrozie, so you will walk with them and guard them.

Interviewer [00:09:30]:

Just a question first, in these three days that you were resting, what did you see there?

Moshe Shutan [00:09:39]:

What did I see? I saw there, first of all, the atmosphere was different than in Kazan [Koziany]. So ask me why? The very forest was different. There were pine trees, very tall pine trees. Now the air was so good, and Narocz lake, in terms of nature, it made a better impression on me than the swamps that were in Kazan. Now what else was there, in Kazan I didn't see Jewish families in the base there, but here there were Jewish families from the town around. They said also that during the blockade, in winter, many Jews were killed.⁹¹

On Jewish partisan "Family Camps," see Yitzhak Arad, Jewish Family Camps in the Forests: An ⁹¹ Original Means of Rescue," in: Michael Marrus (ed.), *The Nazi Holocaust: Historical Articles on the Destruction of the European Jews* (vol. 7), *Jewish Resistance to the Holocaust* (Westport, 1989), 19-220.

Interviewer [00:10:43]:

You got some kind of medical treatment there?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:47]

I got over it, I got over it very fast. No one asked me why. They didn't ask that. If they had asked, my answer was that I fell. I wouldn't say it to the Russian partisans. The Jews asked, to them I said, but to the Russians it didn't even occur to me to say. It was an atmosphere, there was more a sense of family, that the Jews were there and there were also Jewish partisans who were very famous in that period, they were very famous. This Jew Blat, he went, they said, three times, he crossed the front line and came back. And that was a very difficult mission. Among Jews I always felt better. My environment, I was born among Jews and studied with Jews and when the Russians came, I told you that I didn't go to the Russian gymnasium, I stayed among the Jews, the Jewish heritage, the Jewish authors, they were close to my heart.

Interviewer [00:12:15]:

In that period, Bogen⁹² was already there?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:21]:

Not yet.

Interviewer [00:12:22]:

What date are we talking about, approximately?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:25]:

We're in May.

Interviewer (f) [00:12:26]:

Still in May?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:28]:

Still in May. May 1943. End of May, approximately, end of May.

Interviewer (f) [00:12:32]:

So that means in one month you went to Vilna twice?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:39]:

End of May. Maybe the beginning of June. Wait. No, it was later. It was already later because we were in Vilna some time, and because of the road. I'll tell you exactly, we went to Vilna, when Markov sent is - we went about a week, a week, I got to Vilna

This refers to Alexander Bogen, a known partisan who was also an artist. See his testimony at the ⁹² Fortunoff Archive, HVT-3374.

Ghetto on the 15th of July. Why do I remember these dates well? I arrived on the 15th of July because on the 16th of July was Itzik Wittenberg's day.

Interviewer [00:13:46]:

So now let's go back to the road.

Moshe Shutan [00:13:49]:

So the two partisans, so Markov says to them, Look that you guard them so that they get to Podbrozie safe and sound, from there they'll go on their own. To us he says, Now I told that he will guard you, but I ask you now to guard him. We looked, What's going on here? So he says, He's a big drinker, he drinks too much and sometimes when he drinks he forgets in which world he is, so you should know so that If he wants to drink, don't let him drink. He says this to his face, and the guy laughs. We went on our way. We left - us, these two partisans, and one more. We walk, we left the base in the evening hours, Markov said goodbye to us, wished us luck. We arrived, we crossed the river, we got to a forest road, we walked, suddenly in one place I see this Vaska put two fingers in his mouth and whistle. He whistles, we hear from the forest, also two whistles. And he answers his and we see some 100 meters from us, 150, comes out this big *sheigetz* with the farmers' coat, with a rope, and goes over to this Vaska. I didn't know what this is about and where did he come from all of a sudden? Whistles, and answers.... He carried with him eight kilograms of dynamite and we shared on the road, sometimes I carried, sometimes Shike, sometimes Vaska, sometimes the other guy. He was going to derail a train, and since two people is a very small group, it's hard for two people to carry out such a mission, so on the road he picked up partisans who.... They were undercover partisans, they lived in the villages and worked and everything and had ties, so they would let them know that on such and such a day you will come here and here, you will meet up and go together to derail a train. Nu, so this *sheigetz*, he comes over, he looks at him, he says, Did you bring Vodka? Did you bring Samogon? He says no. So go to hell, I don't need you. So the *sheigetz* went, went, disappeared among the trees, after a few moments he comes, he comes and takes out from under the coat a bottle of a liter Vodka, Samogonka. Oh, this, you are *maladziez*, he says. Meaning, you're a good guy. They sat down immediately and drank. He finished, both of them. He gave us also to drink, we drank a little, but he with the other one finished the whole bottle. And we walk on. We walk another 5 kilometers, and he whistles again, so I knew already. And like this he gathered three guys, and each of the three brought a liter Samogonka, with each one he drank, and continued on the way. And I will tell you, he was so strong, and he would eat so much, in the night we would take in the villages, we would take *saba*, it's pork fat with black bread, eggs. Once we sat down to eat, once we entered a village to take food, so the farmer didn't want to open the door, so a fight started. So he says to him, if you don't open I will kill you. The farmer stands at the window, and he says, Kill, so he took down the *avtomat* and fired. After he fired, I see, the farmer is again standing in the window, that when he puts the gun on his shoulder, the sub-machine gun on his shoulder, then he would duck down. He would

fire and that one ducks down. Finishes shooting, that one gets up. Like this three times this game carries on. So he sees that he's not opening, he says, I want to come into the house. Breaks the pane and wants to come in. So the farmer says, Wait, wait, I will give you, what do you want? So he says, I need a coat and a clean shirt, so the farmer gave them. Gave us, entered the house, he gave us. So he also wanted a guide, so we went to a guide in a different house. He knocked on the door, they opened immediately, from fear they opened, they hear the shooting in the village at night. So he came out, the farmer, said, Get dressed and you will go with us. OK, after a few minutes he comes out. In the meantime, he said to a partisan to gather food. So they brought a basket with eggs, if there weren't a hundred eggs in there then I don't know. And bread and pork fat, and when we got to the forest, also Samogonka. And when we got to the forest, so we came, it was already morning, early morning, we sat down, we sat, we sat all of us for some two hours. And then he gets up, Nu, guys, let's go eat, let's eat. OK, I want to see, he says, how many eggs you can drink on an empty stomach. Uncooked eggs. Well, one has to participate in this game. I drank ten, I couldn't anymore. Shike drank fifteen, couldn't any more. He drank forty eggs. Now, he say, we eat. After forty, then he eats maybe a kilo of pork meat with bread, half a loaf, and the Samogonka, sure, he drinks, and like this we came out and sat. Suddenly we hear shooting. It's that he fired in the village there, so they must have told the Lithuanians and followed us. We heard shots not far from us, so he says, quickly, get up, get up. We.... And he walks first and we're after him. He walked maybe 300 meters and stopped. Well, I thought we would run away from the shooting, we would run from the police, or Germans, so we run away, he walks 300 meters and sits down. Sit, he says. We sat, and after about a quarter of an hour, again there's shooting at us. They followed our tracks, how they found it in the forest I don't know, but again they're shooting close by. Again he walks maybe half a kilometer, again sits down like this, we walked all day until the evening. And in the evening it was already quiet and we set out. We arrived in the region of Podbrozie, and there he said goodbye to us. And I am with Shike, with Haike, we walked alone already. There was one day, we were in the forest, we were already some kilometer and a half. So I said to him, We won't go to the village, it's still daylight, we don't need to risk it, and besides, Markov said like this, that we go into the city not together, but separately, in case they catch one, maybe the second will succeed in entering, and if you go now you will risk yourself and the whole business will be lost. So I said, here is bark from the... the farmers used to remove the bark from the trees, it serves for leather, for tanning, so there were whole piles there. So Shike is quick, he is always quick, so he grabs one piece, it was short, so he grabbed two pieces, lies under the trees, puts it on top of him. Haike the same thing, on her, and me - I didn't rush, I always went last. Must do something, I think, I said, if - I said - if I take two, then through one it will pass, through the second, and water will enter on my back. So I didn't rush, I looked and looked, and I found a long one. I sat down, I was like a king in his palace. I wasn't afraid of rain, There wasn't rain. But he lies five minutes, after five minutes, it all enters, he jumps up and says, I can't bear it, I'm going. And she is silent. I said, You're not going. Go look for a longer one and lie down. We were both wet as dogs. We were like

this all day, but at maybe four o'clock we already left for the village, this was early yet, but we left for the village already. But we got to the village, we didn't want to enter in the daylight. So we entered, it was already We passed one village, then we came to another village, we said, we need to enter to take food.⁹³ We came to a village, it was already, when we entered the village, it was 12 at night. House after house, we entered the second house, we knock on the door, the woman opened the door with no questions, without anything, she says, Tseshkek, but when she opened the door she got scared, suddenly she sees two men with a girl. Who are you? We came to ask for food. Oh, she says, I thought it was my husband. He went to the flour mill and he is supposed to come back this late, he's still not back. So that's why I didn't ask, I opened, I was sure it was him. Well, she says, you're already here, enter. We entered, and half an hour later he comes. He comes, we ask for food. So he says, I don't have bread. There's a little milk, he says, I will give you milk. Then he reconsiders, he says, You know what? I will go to the neighbor, I will ask for bread. He didn't go to the neighbor, you will not go. We didn't want them to know. How come he asks at night? Don't worry, my neighbor, like you're talking to me. And he goes to the neighbor, brings half a loaf of bread with milk, we ate, we drank, we started to talk. Who are you, what are you. We told, no, we spoke Polish. That we, the Germans wanted to take us to a work camp, so we ran away to the forest. And that we are Polish partisans, and we now arrived, we ran away from Vilna also and we got here to him, we just want food and that's all. OK, he gives us food, and then he looks like this, a girl, two guys, no weapon, no nothing. Shike always wanted to show off, so he takes out the parabellum. He had a Belgian parabellum, 14 bullets. So he sees the weapon, so he starts to look at us differently. We ate the bread, we drank the milk, I take out, I took out money. I had fifty marks. I said, Take, Oh no, no, I will not take money. I said, Look, I see as you told us that you only have one animal and only a hectare of land, it's a very small piece of land and it's hard to live off it, how do you live. He says, I go to the forest, I gather, nu, *shwemelech*

Interviewer [00:29:03]

Mushrooms

Moshe Shutan [00:29:04]

Mushrooms, and also wood, and she sells it. From this I live, he says. But from the beginning he thinks, when you asked for food, then you didn't ask like partisans, you asked like poor people like this. Now I see, he says, that you are really, he saw the gun, so they are partisans. OK, we were wet, full of mud, the shoes, the feet. So Shike says, Nu, let's go. I, by nature I am never in a hurry, there's time. I said, Listen, maybe we stay the night and another day and go tomorrow evening. We are completely wet, full of mud, you can't enter a city like this, because they will see that it's something unusual. So he agreed, and we asked the farmer, Listen, did you hear anything about Vilna? So

On the complicated relationship between partisans and villagers, see, for example, Kenneth Slepyan,⁹³ *Stalin's Guerrillas: Soviet Partisans in World War II* (Lawrence, KS: University Press of Kansas, 2006), 73-79.

he says, there's a curfew there, and we hear that they captured the leader of the Lithuanian resistance, and they check anyone who enters the forest, ummm, the city, and the situation is difficult, and we thought, it's really not good. I want to remind you that I am talking - that it's difficult to enter the forest, I skipped something, I will tell about it. When we walked with Vaska and the partisans, we got to Bernishky forest, the same forest where we met with the first partisan, Vaska. And he and three, three people are walking towards us. Who are you? Stop! Vaska shouts. And they walk. So he lowers, he grabs the submachine, Stop or I shoot. They walk, they come over and laugh, so he says, why didn't you stop when.... We're partisans, they say. But why didn't stop when I told you to stop? He says, If you had any brains, you would see that we're not Germans, that we're partisans. How do you know? He says, Because in the forest Germans can't enter just like that. In the forest where there's a partisan base, they can't just enter, it's not so simple. So he says, Where are you from? We said, We're Markovitzers. Those who were under Markov were called Markovitzers. So that means that we're from the Lithuanian brigade. And we have an *otriad* and a base, and we're going now to this base. If you want, if you're hungry, it's not far from here, a kilometer, walk with us, and we will take care of you for lunch, because we respect the Markovitzers, because we were also your guests in the forest. So Vaska accepts the offer, and we come to the base there and who do we meet? Haim Yochai. We met Haim Yochai, what are you doing here? What's here? Where's Berke, where's Dovidke? They say, They're all on missions. And the main missions there are to go derail trains. And Berke, he says, is one of the specialists for this. OK, where are you going to? We said to Vilna. So he says to us that in Vilna he has his woman and his daughter; so the Commissar hears his, this was the commissar we met; so he says, What, are you going to Vilna? We said yes. Oh, now it's very dangerous to go. Why? Because in Vilna there's now a curfew, they arrested the leader of the Resistance, Vitas, they arrested Kozlowsky, and if you go now you might fall into German hands. And what's going on there and what's the end? I sent our runner. Who's the runner? Koba, this Tatar. He went to Vilna to see what's going on in the city, and he's supposed to come back in a few days, so until he comes back, sit here. He will come, we will know what the situation is, and then you will go, you will decide what to do. So I agreed, I said better to know the situation and not go like that. But Shike was hot headed, he heard that in Vilna the ground is burning up under their feet, so he says like this, What do you think? For the Jews the ground is burning up under their feet and we will sit here and wait? Let's go. I said, But you heard what the commissar said? No, and he gets up and goes. Vaska says, Where to? He says, This is what I decided. I saw that he went and Haïke is already after him, so I will not stay alone, so I walked after him. Vaska with the guys also got up, so Haim shouts, he was the cook there. So he shouts, he says, You didn't even have lunch. No, that's it. Shike ran off, he was, he had red hair, reddish. And so we carried on our way. And we came to this village, and this farmer Tseshkek, where we ate the bread and drank the milk. So he says, Tseshkek also told us that in the city it's a mess right now so... I told Shike, How will we enter the city, we're so dirty, let's stay a night, we stay another day, and tomorrow night we go and we clean ourselves up. And this village was 25 kilometers

from Vilna. So he was persuaded and agreed, he said OK. We stayed at night, he opened for us the *sherya*(?), the barn, we entered the barn, one stands, doesn't sleep, and two sleep, and like this we took turns all night. At four thirty in the morning, I hear someone coming over to the barn. I sat down. Also Shike and Haike sat down. And this farmer Tseshke - he was short like, skinny, he came in because he shut us in from outside. He comes in and I see in the dark that he's leading a horse and when a tiny bit of light started I saw that the cart in the barn and he's harnessing the horse to the cart. I asked him, What is this? And he said to us, Sit quietly, my woman, I told her to fix you mushrooms to eat with *kartoshkes*, with potatoes, so that you're not hungry, you must be hungry. Where are you going? I ask him. He says, I am going to Vilna. What for? You see, he says, the cart is full of wood, and fruit from the forest, he also had mushrooms and more, I don't know what you call them, small like this.

Interviewer [00:38:08]:

Berries.

Moshe Shutan [00:8:08]:

Berries, yes. With berries, I am going to sell this in Vilna. I said, He's going to Vilna? I said to him, Can I go with you? So he says, Why not? So Shike jumps up, What? You will go? I will go. I said, Look, there's no point in the three of us going together. As Markov said, one will go, maybe he's successful, maybe not, never mind, then the other one will succeed. Then the next. So I said to him, You want to leave me with Haike? So he said, OK, OK, go. I got on the cart and said, When he comes back he will give you details. I climbed on the cart, I asked him to give me a farmer's coat with a rope, I tied, like this, I sat down and him in front of me, as if I'm his son. We left for the main road, machines with German, with Lithuanians, driving, there's traffic, carts with farmers, *Lebnik*, there's life. It's close to Vilna, so we arrived at the city of Nova [New] Wilejka. We arrived at Nova Wilejka, a woman stops him, Oh, you sell wood? He says, Yes, go ahead. She comes over, How much do you want. He must have asked for a price higher than she thought. She says to him, You know, she says, I will give you so much, he says, Not so much. So she says, You bargain like a Jew. Bargain like a Jew. I sit and laugh. In the end he sold to her. We carry on, drive further, I see that we need to cross a bridge, a bridge on the river Viliya, and the bridge is big. I see that there are guards on one side and on the other side of the bridge.... At night they guarded both sides, and during the day only on one side. What did the Germans do? So that the partisans would not blow up the bridge, they put strings with tin cans, that you would touch if you wanted to reach the bridge, you have to touch these strings, and the tin cans start ringing. That was their alarm. I said, how will I cross the bridge, the Lithuanians are there, its dangerous. I saw that it's not good, I thought about what to do. I told him, you know what? You step down. I thought, what does he need to be caught up in this scramble, if one bullet is shot – because I thought, if something happens I will shoot, if I shoot there will be a chaos and then they will kill him also. So I said, you step down, I will drive, you walk after me, I will cross the bridge, I will wait for you. And he steps down, didn't

ask any questions, stepped down. And stayed afterwards, he walked behind me but I didn't look at him. I sit, I took the reins. I'm driving, I came to the bridge. Two policemen, Stop. I stopped. Where are you going? To Vilna. What have you got? Wood, berries, mushrooms. They turned over the cart, they looked, Drive. I passed. I passed, he came after me. I drove for maybe half a kilometer, I stopped and he came. We sat down, we're driving, suddenly I see a carriage passing with two passengers and a Star of David patch, a yellow patch on their back. So I shouted, they looked at me and ran away with the horse. I thought, Jews, I would ask how's it going, what's going on, they ran away. And I shouted to them in Yiddish, and it didn't help me. And so with Tseshke I got to Vilna, before Vilna I said goodbye to him, I just took a basket with berries and another basket with mushrooms and I said, Look Tseshke, I said a street where he should come in Vilna, I asked if he knows it, he said Yes, I know, are you there, Come at one hour in a day. First of all, I will pay you for this, what I'm taking. He says, Are you kidding me, what are you, there's no need. I said, Listen, I'm asking you, come. So he says, OK. And I entered the city through side roads, through alleys. I entered the city and reached Kailis. On the way a Polish woman asked me, how much does it cost? I said, I already sold it. In Kailis when I came, my uncle looks at me, Oy vey, here he comes again. But he must have also gotten used to this type. He says to me, Maybe you will finally decide that you stay in the Ghetto, and not run here and there, stay in the forests or stay in the ghetto, but what is this running back and forth? I said, OK, it will be all right. I went over to this guy I knew, and said, Tell the FPO that I arrived from the partisans, from Markov. And again the same, Izik Averbuch. He comes over in the evening, dressed me in a black coat, puts dark glasses on me, on the eyes, with a hat, yes, a hat, and he brings me to the ghetto, he brought me to the ghetto and put me in a room and there two guys sat. When I came in, they were silent, they didn't say anything. I was tired, and there was there a place to sleep, I lay down and slept, When I got up it was already about eight in the evening, I saw that there are other guys, more came. There were maybe five guys inside the room, and something, shshshsh, something talking among themselves. And I, what, I will ask them? And they're like afraid of me, I'm a stranger in this group. I carried on sleeping, carried on sleeping, and four in the morning someone came, someone comes in, Guys, Liza is calling, *liza ruft*, in Yiddish they said. I didn't know what is "Liza is calling", this password,⁹⁴ so I asked, What's going on here? And the one who came in asks me like this, Do you have a weapon? And this pistol, I took with me, and in the ghetto there was the Penausov family that they fixed weapons, and also at the partisans they fixed weapons.⁹⁵ I knew them and gave them the pistol so that they could fix it for me. So I was left without a weapon, so he says, you have a weapon? The weapon, a pistol with three bullets, two don't enter. He said to me, I said No, so he gave me a piece of iron, 10 mm like this. About 70 cm in length. This will be a weapon, he says. And he distributed to some other guys like

This FPO password, which meant to start an uprising, was named after Liza Magon, an FPO activist⁹⁴ who had tried to warn the Jews of Oszmiana of an upcoming *Aktion*. However, only a few heeded her warnings. She was captured by the Gestapo and executed in Ponary on February 17, 1943.

On the Penausov family, see, Lazar, *Destruction and Resistance*, 149.⁹⁵

this. He distributed the pieces of iron, some had pistols, others said come. So I left last, I always leave last. I put the iron in the stove. I will fight against Germans with iron? I saw that it's a lost battle, there's nothing to do here, Maybe they were right, those who thought about it, in my eyes it didn't look like an instruments that you can fight the Germans. As a weapon that you can. I said, we will see, what will be will be, and I thought to myself, it's a shame that I didn't keep the pistol, but anyway I don't have it, and it's a shame that I entered into this chaos, I was already with the partisans, and here I fell back into the ghetto and who knows what will be? We went out, we went out, we went out on the street, I see on all sides more people coming, more groups, more groups. And I didn't know what this means, so they told me that this is something, I saw that something in the ghetto is going on, they told me, you will see already, come with us. I want to note that the room where they put me, where I was, Chaim Lazar used to live there, and he told me this later, I didn't know. I see, more people, more people, it's already more than 100, 150, and they're leading us, and I walk last. I walk last, after them, suddenly I hear shouts, and they're all starting to run back, I was already among bullets shot at me, I didn't hear shots, I didn't run away. As I'm walking, I carried on advancing. And they ran. So I ended up first, I see one girl standing with her hands up shouting. "Where? Back." Before her were some 50 or 60 Jewish policemen from the ghetto with clubs, and they went against the camp that went in a direction – I didn't know, later I found out that they went to Strashoon street and the police didn't want to let them pass. When the police went against the whole group then they ran away, they ran away so she stood in the middle and shouted, Where? Back. So the guys stopped, they were ashamed, before a girl. How is this, they are combatants, men, and here is a girl who is not afraid, so they came back. Some, I saw, inserted bullets into the gun and started running after the girl. Later I found out that it was Sonya Madeisker.⁹⁶ They started to run against the policemen, so the policemen ran away. They ran and we got to a courtyard. There in the yard many guys gathered, there were many. There was a tap with water, it was early morning so we washed ourselves, everyone stood in line to wash themselves. Then about 7 in the morning they gave out rolls to eat. I asked, What's going on here, no one said anything, no one talks to me. I now understand why they didn't talk to me. Because in the FPO resistance there were groups of five. And only among them they could talk. Someone whom they don't know, they weren't allowed to talk to them. And since I was a stranger for everyone, no one told me anything. I said, anyway, I came with the guys who put me in the room, I will wait, and the one who put me in their room is from the FPO, he knows that I came to the ghetto as a partisan. I sat, I sat, at 11 AM they told me, one comes over to me, Come. Where? Come to the FPO HQ. They brought me through wooden stairs, there were two stories, every half-flight stood guards with pistols. They brought me to the door, opened the door, big

Sonya Madeisker (1914-1944), a Vilnius-born Communist who had served eight years in Polish ⁹⁶ prisons, commanded an FPO unit in the ghetto, and helped organize escapes to the Rudniki forests. Captured by the Germans one day before her own planned escape, she shot herself during her arrest and died several days later from her wounds after enduring torture in German captivity. See *The Lexicon of Bravery*, 45-46.

room, long table, benches, chairs. And I see, I understood that it's the headquarters of the FPO. So there I met for the first time Aba Kovner, Glazman, Nissim Reznik.⁹⁷

Interviewer [00:53:48]:

Nissan

Moshe Shutan [00:53:49]:

Nissan Reznik, Yes, a few others, Chvoinek, Chiena Borovska. So Aba Kovner asks me, What have you got to tell? I told him, I was sent by Markov to get out people with weapons. So Glazman intervened then

Interviewer [00:54:17]:

You didn't tell him that you were sent to get Wittenberg out to the forest for a meeting with Markov? Because that was your original mission.

Moshe Shutan [00:54:30]:

Our mission, what Markkov said, it was, with the letter to the FPO, was to take out young people from the resistance. And an order, he wrote, I command, I order you. And to bring a runner from the resistance in the city. I met the runner in Kailis and he brought me to the ghetto and from the ghetto from Chaim Lazar's room I got to the yard with all the guys and from the yard they called me to the FPO headquarters. I met them and he asked What are you doing here, so I told him that Markov sent us to take people out to the forest, and then Glazman intervened, he says, You came at the right time. Do you know, he says, that Gens gave Itzik Wittenberg to the Germans, and Gens knows all of us, he knows the whole headquarters, and if the Germans, the Gestapo, demand that he hands us over as well, he will hand us over. So we need to leave, go to the forest. I said, How much, how many are you? So he said two hundred people. When? He says, Even tonight. For me it seemed a very complicated mission. When you go, with a group of five people, ten people, twenty people, thirty, but two hundred? It will be found out. Easier to find out two hundred people than one or two or five or twenty because you're going through villages, by villages, food, it's not simple. I told him, I don't want to risk taking a group of two hundred people to the forest, because if I take people it's my responsibility to being them safe and sound, and to risk it with two hundred people – I'm not willing to do it. I told him, We will go in groups. I'm here, Shike Gertman is supposed to get here in a few days. He will go, I will take a group, he will take a group, we will teach among your people how to go and so we will come back and like this, in groups, we will take the guys out to the forest. So he says to me, It's not possible. Why isn't it possible in groups? He says, because Gens, Gens won't let us. What, we're going to the forest, what has Gens got to do with it? He says, Gens know of every action we take. So if we leave with a small group, say 25 people, he will immediately know about it. He will seal the Ghetto shut, we won't be able to go. Because he is against leaving for the forest. I said, if the obstacle to doing this mission is Gens, then I will go to Gens.

On the FPO HQ, see the testimony of Nissan Reznik, Fortunoff Archive, HVT-3193.⁹⁷

Going to Gens is like going to the Gestapo. I said, Leave this to me. So Sonya Madeisker shouts at me, when I left, from the way that I got up and left – I am apparently also hotheaded, that I didn't want to continue arguing, so I heard, Gens is the problem, let's go to Gens. So Sonya Madeisker shouts to me, You mustn't go to Gens, it's like the Gestapo. I went down the stairs and went to the Judenrat. I come to the Judenrat, enter a corridor, waiting. I knock on the door of Gens's room, I can't hear anything, suddenly I see, he comes, he comes out of a room and walks off. I said to him Hello. He was like this, surprised. And also not surprised. He says, What are you doing here? I said, Here it's impossible to talk like this. So he says, OK, enter my room, wait, I will come in a bit. I waited some ten minutes and he came with Dessler. Sit down, I sat. The first thing he said to me was, You said you would come to me if you came back to the ghetto, but you've already gone to them. You see? He already knew. And why did they send you to me? He says, to show that behind their back stands the forest, the partisans, like I am for them, I am the Gestapo, I am the traitor that behind me stands the Gestapo. I said, Look, the fact that I didn't come straight to you, that's how it worked out. But I now come to you for a reason. What's the reason? I want you to help me. I said to him, I was in the forest, and we spoke with Markov, and I spoke also about you. And Markov said to me that if you want contact with partisans, you need, you must contact him first, because he is not allowed to make contact with someone who has ties to the Gestapo. I first skipped this, now I remember it.

Interviewer [01:01:18]:

This was a conversation you really had with Markov

Moshe Shutan [01:01:21]:

Yes, it was with Markov. Yes, about Gens, yes. Listen, yes, I told him, my mission is, I came to take people out of the forest. That's what Markov commanded me. And I want you to help me. So he says to me, Where will I get people to send to the forest? Here there is the FPO, they have members, they have weapons, let them go. I said, there's some misunderstanding...

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 7 – Transcript

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Interviewer [00:00:49]:

Recording

Moshe Shutan [00:00:51]:

In the previous recording I spoke of meeting Gens for the first time and he asked me how many people I want to save, 300, 500, and he answered that if he knows [when

will be] the end of the ghetto he will also say and 500 people will run away, maybe more. I asked him, Where will they run to? So he said to me, You mean that there will be a base to run to. But I won't let you ruin the ghetto. You want to - those thanks to whom the ghetto exists, and again, nothing – the Germans won't leave children and women and old people with no one to work. Here, he says, Rommel was thrown out of Africa, there's a reversal in Italy, the Russians are advancing on the eastern front, and one cannot tell what tomorrow will bring. As I already said, I had nothing in response to such claims. Now I will pass to where I ended in the second recording.

Interviewer [00:02:31]:

The second conversation

Moshe Shutan [00:02:35]:

Yes, in conversation, in the second meeting with Gens. He said to me, You came from the FPO, and they think I'm a traitor. But nothing, I didn't hand over Wittenberg. I have never obeyed others' commands, I made my own calculations, based on my own opinions, I made the situation of the Ghetto and according to the situation I always decided what to do and acted as my conscience led me. Now they are saying that I handed in Wittenberg, but I didn't hand him in, the Gestapo found out about Wittenberg from one of them, from Kozlowsky.⁹⁸ When you fight, you have to be prepared for victims, and he fell victim. I thought after they released him, after I turned him in that they would resist. But when I demanded Wittenberg from them, because the Germans said to me, It's Wittenberg or the Ghetto, and I saw that they were consulting among themselves, so I understood that there would be nothing. Instead of preparing for a struggle they consulted, and if you're consulting you're not fighting. I understood, Gens said, that I am dealing here with people who are looking for glory and the right thing, what they did for sure is art.

Interviewer [00:05:09]:

It's what?

Moshe Shutan [00:05:10]:

Art. They founded a theatre and concerts and I helped them here because it suited my tactic in the ghetto. But when Wittenberg had a choice to go to the Germans or not and he was in their hands, they shouldn't have behaved as I did, they should not have given him up. If they gave him up then they did the same thing I did for the ghetto. In order to save some I gave up others so that the other half would remain, and they actually did the same thing, they handed Wittenberg over in order to save themselves and the ghetto. Later I talked to him about what I already said, that I came to the forest to take people out, and I said, You have misunderstandings with the FPO, and I suggested that they hold a meeting. Because they need to straighten out the misunderstandings, the mutual

See, Yitzhak Arad, *Ghetto in Flames: The Struggle and Destruction of the Jews in Vilna in the Holocaust* (Jerusalem: Yad Vashem, 1976), 311-316.

lack of trust. He said, Go ahead, they can come. When? Tomorrow at six, at five in the evening. I said goodbye to him, and went straight back to the FPO headquarters, the place from where I went to Gens. I found everyone there and passed on to them what I had agreed with Gens. They heard, they even said to me, What, you came out alive? He didn't beat you? Didn't beat me, I came out alive. So they agreed to go to a meeting. The meeting was the next day at five, it was on Shabbat, and Aba Kovner went, Chiena Borowski, Yankel Kaplan and Avraham Chvojnuk. When we came to Gens he was there, also Dessler was. I opened the conversation and said, Since one doesn't believe the other, please talk, to iron out, how you say.

Interviewer [00:08:32]:

The difficulties.

Moshe Shutan [00:08:32]:

The difficulties. Gens spoke first. He said I actually now have no objection to you going to the forest. Because I spoke with him from the start, I saw that it's not the same Gens who was sure of himself and in control of the situation, but now it's a different Gens who ended up in a difficult situation and is having trouble getting out of it. And he says, I will let you go to the forest, I will not disturb you, only one thing I want from you when you leave the ghetto, that you not have any documents and numbers, in case you fall into German hands so that they don't know that you belong to Vilna Ghetto. If they find Vilna Ghetto documents they will come to me with charges, because I am in charge of the ghetto. And they agreed. It was agreed that they could go. We left the meeting, I go back where we came from, I went over to Aba Kovner, I said to him, Organize a group, tell me when I can take them. He said we will let you know. OK. The next day came Shike, Shike with Haike. It was a Sunday, the farmers or young people go to church to pray, nu, so he like a *Sheigetz* with a *Shikse* going to town to pray, he left with her in the morning, and like this he came safely to Kailis first, from Kailis to Vilna Ghetto and we met up. He told me that the farmer told him this road we went through, that we came through safely, that there were troubles but we got through them. And I told him what happened in the Ghetto what happened with Wittenberg. Wittenberg, they handed him over at 10 in the morning because the Germans told them that if you don't hand him over by 10 in the morning they will bomb the ghetto. An hour later I was in the FPO and I met with the staff and then to Gens and back to the FPO. I told him everything, he said OK, I will go meet them because I have the letter, I want to give them Markov's letter. We arranged where, when to meet. He told me where he will be in the ghetto, and I told him where I will be in the ghetto, and we waited, we waited until they would give us, would organize a group, that we will go. I at the same time organized people I knew that I wanted to take to the forest, and I also met with Sonya Madeisker. Once in the meeting with her - it was in the ghetto in some courtyard - I told her that I intend to take from FPO only 10 people and the rest I take whom I choose. She said to me No, you are a messenger on Markov's behalf and you were sent to us, and now you are under our command and you have to do what we tell you to do. I said,

I'm a free man and I owe nothing to no one. If I came, then I came to get people out, and you won't tell me whom to take out. You're not disciplined, we also do things we don't want to do. I said, think about what you want. If you want to get more people out, then give me FPO members, from the resistance, I will train them how to walk at night, and like this you will take our groups. I can't take everyone, I can go and come back again. So she went from me not depressed, but *toysht*, how do you say, disappointed. She went, she went, and I carry on with my own business. I don't know what she thought of doing, but anyway I dealt with the organization, preparing people that I would take them to the forest. And every day I met with Shike and he also told me that he's waiting for a group. One day he's talking to me and he says, listen, you go to Gens too much, and you shouldn't believe everything he says, and what the FPO say is true, we need to hear what they say, and if they tell you how many people and what people to take then you shouldn't resist. I thought, how come he's suddenly telling me that I'm going so much to Gens? And it was really one incident, after the meetings I had with the FPO at Gens's, I went to him once, I met a girl in the ghetto and she said that her little brother, 14 years old maybe less, was arrested outside the ghetto, maybe I can help with something, since I know Gens and Dessler, maybe I can get him out of the Gestapo. So I went, I talked with Dessler, and Dessler said he would do what he can. And when Shike spoke to me, What are you doing going to Gens, so now I saw that they're following me. How would they know that I went to Gens? If they knew, it's a sign that they're following me. And don't believe me. But I got over it. I thought, Shike thinks according to his worldview and I according to mine. I didn't care what people he got out as long as he gets people out, but for me it was important, the people that I decided to take, that I take them. Who were these people whom I wanted to take? There were friends, I had family, relatives, my cousin with his wife and his mother. When he asked me to take them to the forest of course I said that I would take them. I told friends that I would take them, I had left my sister and saw that the situation in the ghetto is very bad, I said, while I'm at it I will take her from the ghetto, she shouldn't stay any longer, because what happens now is unknown. A lot of people at the time, those who knew me, almost everyone, wanted to go to the forest. So I met with Shike every day, from the FPO I didn't hear anything more, apart from my meetings with Sonya Madeisker. One day I come at 10 in the morning to the house where Shike and Haike were, and the tenant, the *balabuste*, the land lady, says to me, What, you don't know? Today at 5 in the morning Shike left with a group of FPO for the forest. I was amazed, how is this? I am in touch with him, not in touch from the Partisans, me with Shike - we were like brothers, from childhood, neighbors since I knew him we were neighbors and we were always on good terms with one another and one understood the other, how is it that he left and didn't tell me that he's going? We came to Vilna together. I went and met up with Sonya Madeisker, I asked her, What is this, a group went out and I didn't even know about it. And what about me? She says, That you didn't know, we think it's better, you don't have to know everything. And everything after this, the second group that you will take from us we will again... wait and we will let you know. All this day I walked around like someone who has been abandoned, who was betrayed. How is it that you

don't tell me that you're going? I couldn't do anything. I wasn't depressed from it, I wasn't afraid from it, because I knew the way and for me to go to the forest without Shike, it wasn't a problem, because today I see that whoever walked once in the forest, who walked at night and had to move from place to place, hundreds of kilometers, if he did it once and he is resourceful then it's not a problem for him to walk it again. So that, for me, it wasn't a problem, what hurt me was the behavior towards me. I saw that they did not trust me. I got over it. Now, since the day went past, and the next morning there was a fright in the ghetto. What happened? Those who went out with Shike fell into an ambush by the Lavoriškè river, by the Lavoriškè bridge, and many fell and a small portion remained. And they found Vilna Ghetto documents on the fallen, they found numbers.⁹⁹

Interviewer [00:22:7]:

The ones that remained, they ran away or they were caught?

Moshe Shutan [00:22:4]:

Some ran away and some were caught. They found Vilna Ghetto documents on the fallen. According to what I knew and what I heard later, Shike went with this group as a guide. The commander of the group was Yosef Glazman. So they said in the ghetto that they would gather the brigadiers, where these people worked, that they found, the gathered the families and led them to be killed. They spoke then of 80 people, others said 35, I don't know exactly what, what the number is, anyway the families and the brigadiers were taken and murdered, they killed them. I went to Gens, I said, What, what's going on in the ghetto? How's it going? He was furious. You sat, he says, and you heard me say to them to go without documents. It's not to them that the Gestapo comes, Neugebauer,¹⁰⁰ a Gestapo man he was, Neugebauer, it's not to them that he comes, and bangs on your desk, You have bandits in your ghetto, it's to me. With these numbers, he says, and throws on my table, here, the ones in your ghetto, and I had no answer. I don't want to talk about them anymore, I don't want to know them, there's no one to talk to. I left. I said, Look, I am organizing a group and I will need your help to leave, to leave the ghetto. He says, No problem, whenever you come, tell me, the gate is open. Nu, I had to organize everything by myself and leave for the forest. I went once more to Sonya Madeisker, I met with her again, This disaster, what happened – happened, no one can guarantee if you will succeed in the mission or not, and I said, when will you give me the people you want to send to the forest? So she says to me, We're not going to the forest anymore. I said to her, What, one incident where you're not successful and you already want to fold, give up the idea of leaving for the forest? You had already decided to leave. So she says, We're back where, to the same situation that we thought, there will be a rebellion, we will not go to the forest, we will rise up in

On this incident, see Daniela Ozacky Stern, "From Victims to Fighters: Jews in the Belarusian Partisan Forests," *S:I.M.O.N.* 12 (2025): 120-123, and Shlomo Kenet (Kanterovitch), "With the Partisans in the Narocz Forests," *Edut* 1 (June 1987): 92-108. Nazi commander Rudolph Neugebauer.¹⁰⁰

the ghetto. I didn't look to convince her, because I am not the person to tell her what to do and what to decide, I didn't ask her for a meeting with the other comrades in the headquarters, for me what she said was enough, that she was a member of the headquarters, and with that I was done with the ties with them, I didn't go to them and they and they didn't turn to me. Now what was Vilna Ghetto, actually? Vilna city - when the war broke out, there were about 40 or 60 thousand Jews, as far as I know. The Germans after a few months murdered 40,000. 20,000 were left. These they put in the ghetto. If you're talking about collaboration of Jews, there are some people that talk about it as if the Jews collaborated and they helped kill Jews and if they hadn't helped it wouldn't have happened. So I say that if they managed to kill 40,000, and if they had decided to kill everyone, they could have done it, and they did it without help from the Jews, they murdered the 40,000 without help from Jews and it wasn't a problem for them to murder more. Why they decided to leave a ghetto, I don't know. Anyway, in the ghetto in the time I am talking about, 20,000 Jews were left in the ghetto. How did people live there? There were three elements in the ghetto. The first element was Gens with the Judenrat, the second element was the FPO, the resistance. The third element that started being active later in the ghetto were the partisans. And each had their own outlook, each thought they were correct and going down the right path, but if you take the situation as it was, and look at it today, then I see that the hero in the ghetto, the ghetto heroes were not the partisans, and not the FPO, but that the true hero of the ghetto was Yaacov Gens. Why? The partisans didn't have a solution for the ghetto, they could have taken out up to 500 people, maybe another 100. The FPO, their approach of an uprising in the ghetto, what would they give to the ghetto if there was an uprising? Ruin. They would all be destroyed. The only one who gave some hope to Vilna Ghetto, to the people of the ghetto, was Gens. Because most, most did not have the solution of the partisans and the FPO, of resistance in the ghetto. Most were ordinary people who went to work, to bring the bit of food that they could, and the person who organized it and helped them with it was Gens. And he gave them this hope that maybe a miracle will happen. There's a situation where people see in a situation with... with no exit.... Without.

Interviewer [00:32:09]:

No way out

Moshe Shutan [00:32:10]

No way out, they hear what someone is promising them, someone who gives them a solution and hope for their problems. And the person who gave this to them was Gens. When Gens would leave the ghetto then people would say, who knows, why was he called, why did he go? When he came back, and clouds, and worry on the face, so they said, how did Gens come back? So, if not in a good mood, then the whole ghetto was not in a good mood, who know what will be. When Gens would come back from the Gestapo with a smile on his face, then the whole ghetto smiled. There's a story about a revolutionary from Hungary in the 19th century who was caught and condemned to die.

His mother came – and he was a Baron, a Graf, the son of a nobleman. So his mother came and said, Write a petition for pardon and I will go to the emperor. So he wrote. And she said to him like this, Listen, if they lead you to the gallows I will go, and if you see that I am in a depressed mood you will know that you have not been pardoned. But if you see me smiling you will know that you will live. And on the day that they took him out to be hanged he looked at his mother walking, and she smiled, and like this with the hope that he was pardoned, they brought him to the gallows and hung him. This road, from the prison to the gallows, this road of two years where there was quiet in the ghetto, this smile, this hope, the person who gave this to the ghetto was Gens and this was his reward. Furthermore, with the situation that there was, it wasn't possible to help the Jews. Now, when I started to organize people, they came to me. A girl I knew from Świąciany Ghetto came to me, Mirka Ligomoski, and since I knew her better I said I will take you to the forest. She said to me, I am finding it hard, deciding to go or not. She was pretty, and she said, I don't know how I will manage in the forest with partisans. She experienced, she had a difficult incident, and she was depressed from it, she stopped believing in people [unclear] and said I won't go. When they set up the ghetto in Świąciany, then she came to the ghetto, so people, each brought a chair, a table, clothes, something to bring, to make it easier to live, she didn't take anything, she in the ghetto brought lot of books, and in Świąciany Ghetto I would go to her and take the books and read them. What kind of books? *Forty Days of Musa Dag*, *Sparta*, Victor Hugo's *Ninety Three*, and I looked at her as a person that does not look too much at the little things, what is missing, what's not there, but for her the books were her life's world, and here in Vilna Ghetto she is standing despairing, with a decision not to go to the forest. I – it pained me a lot, because most of the people asked me to take them, and she decided not. There was one more that I met, an 11-year-old boy also from Świąciany, Shmulik was his name, Shmulik Takinsky. Shmulik, come, I will take you to the forest. So he looks at me, he says, How can I? How can I go through such a road, partisans, and besides, he says, I can't go. Why can't you go? He at his age was already tall, although he was young he was tall, he was strong, and I think for him to make the move from ghetto to partisans is not such a problem. But he didn't want, he said I can't go. Why can't you go? Because I live in a family where there are ten, there are ten children and only two are working, me and another one. And if I go, then I leave the children without food, they will die of hunger. I won't go. It was a sad case, but it was the reality, and I didn't even try and persuade him to cast everything aside and go. And there was another one who came to me, Sheinele, what's the family name, Sholkeiper, she was once a revolutionary during the Poles, Communist to such a degree that she moved from Poland to Russia, with a boyfriend, the boyfriend was then arrested and sent to Siberia and she stayed and then when the communists came to our area she came back to Świąciany. And she was already quiet, she wouldn't talk of revolution and equality, and not in the ghetto, when she saw that they're going to kill everyone she looked for a way to be saved. When she heard that I came from the forest to the ghetto, she met with me and asked me to take her. She said I have a problem, but I fixed it. What was her problem? She had two little kids, a three-year old girl and a five-year-old boy. So she

says, I gave them away, I found *goyim* who agreed to take them. I don't know what is better, that I gave them and I don't hang on to them until the last minute, but like this, she says, maybe it's better, because at the last moment you never know what will happen, how it will happen, if I can help them or not, like this at least, she says, I'm calm that that they're with *goyim* and I hope they stay alive and I want to go to the forest. She also had a brother, Take us. We had in the family a personal quarrel, I won't go into all these details, but I told her, Find someone else to take you, certainly people will come, maybe the FPO will change their minds, I will not take you. I didn't take her. In the end she managed to get to the forest with the shipments that were later. I met also with my teacher Motl Genitzky, he was in Vilna Ghetto. I told him also, Motl, let's go to the forest. There are types who don't see themselves, they see the others by their side. He said to me I won't go, I have a wife, he said [unclear] and she can't go, and leave her, I won't leave her, what will be will be, but I won't leave her. I am proud today of such a teacher because the The *akzie*.... I don't know if to compare to Janusz Korczak, like he didn't want to leave the children, for him a wife, a life companion was also something sacred, and he decided not to leave her. I look back at having parents like this with such a moral compass. I also remember the teacher Devorah Fisher, I had something similar, what happened to me with the teacher Motl Genitzky, that they sent the Jews from Święciany to ... to Poligon, so they took out some families, a few dozen families, they took them out and put them back in Święciany Ghetto. And someone suggested to take her out, and she said, Take out, she says, those younger than me. She was 70. I will share my fate with everyone. Such teachers I had, and when I stood in front to my teacher that he said he's not going, it touched me and hurt my heart, and it was very very difficult for me to judge them. The opposite, I gained respect for them.

Interviewer [00:45:50]

Markov allowed you to bring to the forest people without weapons?

Moshe Shutan [00:45:55]:

His order was to bring only with weapons, only young people with weapons.

Interviewer [00:46:00]:

I imagine that all these people that you're telling about did not have weapons.

Moshe Shutan [00:46:09]:

No, most didn't. But I didn't go through the fine print of the order, as you might say, because our group that went out the first time to the forest, then too not everyone had weapons, we managed. The important thing was to bring the people, to take them out of the ghetto, to save them. And some could also be combatants. And I myself, did I have a weapon? Some pistol I had, with three bullets. I don't regard the weapon as the most important thing, in these actions.

Interviewer [00:47:07]:

I'm sure, I just wondered if you weren't afraid of having problems with Markov for bringing people without weapons.

Moshe Shutan [00:47:16]:

No, I didn't think about it. For me it was important to get them to the forest, since there

Interviewer 00:47:25]:

One second, there's some rustling here. Danny, can you hear a rasping in the earpiece? Stop, stop the recording a moment. Can you hear? There's some disturbance here.

Moshe Shutan [00:47:25]:

Since I was already in the forest and I saw families of Jews in Narocz, in the woods of Narocz, and they lived by the partisans, so I said, whoever doesn't have a weapon will not be accepted to the *Otriad*, so he will live like they lived. Better than the ghetto. Usually I never looked at the fine print. A man has to be flexible. The day came, the day I set for departure. And in the ghetto I met up with a few more people, I met with one of the *shterke*,¹⁰¹ of the strong ones, and I said to myself, if guys like this, like they were, were in the partisans, then that is good material for fighting. We moved on. They didn't go down that path. They were simple people, they knew only that in life you need to take everything by force, and where it doesn't work with force, you give in. And I spoke to one of them and he said to me like this, Nu, resisting the Germans is nonsense, what can you do to them? I can take two Germans and kill them like anything, but where would be the courage, when afterwards they kill thousands of Jews? So what can I do? This is the situation. I also knew the Penausov family, in Vilna Ghetto, the one that fixed my pistol. And my cousin he worked in a place like this and he was quick like this, with lots of energy, and he would bring food not just for himself but also for others, but to others he would give the food not for free. They would sell. So he was in a good situation like this. Also Penausov who would go to a café. There was a café in the ghetto and all kinds of people would sit there. What did they eat at the café? First of all they drank Vodka, that there was. And the food was bread with some vegetable fritters, that's what they ate. But anyway there were in the ghetto people who... lived like they wanted to imagine the good days when they were free. This Penausov, I wanted to take him, he said I will not go yet. I got money and gave it to him to buy a pistol. And the day for leaving the ghetto came. What else did I want to say? That the group I took included Alexander Bogen. He came to me and said, Moshe, take me to the forest. I have a weapon. I said OK. Take my wife. I said, I can't. I already had women. You need.... So he said, You know what, but I have one guy you must take. Who is this? He says, It's a young guy, age 28, a big mathematician, Bobke Zelikson, and this is the elite of the Jewish spirit, of the Jews. He wrote a book about higher mathematics, an important book that was accepted. And we cannot leave these kind of people but we must all make sure that such people stay alive because this is the future of our nation, the spirit, this is the future of our nation. He explained to me like this, I

On these "strong ones" in the ghetto, see Einat, *Everyday Life in the Vilna Ghetto*, 137.¹⁰¹

agreed. OK. I do need to say, that afterwards when they sent the Jews to Estonia, Bogen's wife also got a call to present herself for the shipments to Estonia. And in the room, where they arranged all the.... This procedure, she sees Levas and says to him, You know, my husband left with Moshe Shutan for the forest. He heard, he said to her, then go home, he let her go. Then Bogen came and found her in the ghetto. There's one more thing I want to say. Before I left, when I was in the ghetto after a few weeks, they talked about catching people. Averbuch came to me, he knew me, he was in the ghetto, he was a sergeant, in the police but he belonged to the FPO, the resistance, and he came to me and says to me like this, Moshe, you know, tomorrow morning when the workers go out to work they will be caught and sent who knows where. If you have acquaintances and friends, tell them that tomorrow they shouldn't go to work. I, when I heard this, I went cold all over. What does it mean, workers will go to work and will be caught? And sent who knows where? Where do the Germans send? Usually, it is known. So I said to him, what is FPO doing? So he said to me, That's what thy told me to tell you. So I thought, if it's like this, that they want, they want to take, he spoke about 2,000 people. And when they want to take these young people who are working, then there's two things going on here. The FPO is not begging for an uprising because when will they do an uprising? To my mind, that was the end of the ghetto. And what Gens also thought I didn't know. Because they're taking the very ones on which he's hoping, on which the ghetto is relying. And the FPO did not come out with a call to people not to go, they only said on the quiet, they let acquaintances know, as I understood. But later they spoke about how in the ghetto many people knew that tomorrow they would catch people going to work, but not everyone believed it. Some said better not to go work, others yes. Dr. Mark Dworzecky also wrote about this incident in his book.¹⁰²

And the shipments to Estonia started.¹⁰³ After they caught the workers the next day, 2,000, they sent them to Estonia. And in the ghetto the Judenrat said that it's not for death, it's for life. They will be there in camps and will work there and the Germans are also demanding that their families also go there. And that everyone, all the families of those that they took, should present themselves and go to Estonia. Some were afraid and some came and said Yes, I want to go to my husband, I want my family. That went in a, they agreed of their own accord. During that period I left the ghetto. I gathered all the documents and all the numbers, and again I gave them to Levas, and I said goodbye also to Gens, and Levas again gave me cigarettes and like this we left. If in the first time I left with Shike in a group, the first time, we went by train with workers going to work in Nova Wilejka, this time we went by foot.

Interviewer [00:59:41]:

We're right at the end of the tape, so I prefer to reach the exodus in the next hour, just tell me one thing, how long altogether were you in the ghetto in this visit?

Mark Dworzecky, *Jerusalem of Lithuania in Revolt and in the Holocaust*, 366-370.¹⁰²
For more information, see Anton Weiss-Wendt, "The Business of Survival: Baltic Oil Ltd. and Jewish
Forced-Labor Camps in Estonia," *Yad Vashem Studies* 36.2 (2008): 45-71.¹⁰³

Moshe Shutan [00:59:54]:

I was a pretty long time. I think I left mid-August, mid-August. I was, in July, because in mid-July I came – about a month I think I was in the ghetto. Then I left for the forest, maybe a little less, but a period, so it took some time, because I wanted before to wait until the fear, the turmoil, and what happened with the FPO, with the FPO group, that it will be a little quiet, then they started with the shipments to Kovna, to Estonia, when they caught people, I wanted things to calm down, and when things calmed down I said I'm leaving.

Interviewer [01:00:55]:

And actually, without anyone from the FPO?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:58]:

Myself, without anyone. I stopped the ties with them. What, I will go beg? They will give me people? There were enough people who wanted to leave. What does it matter, every person is a person and everyone wants to live and everyone wants to go to the partisans. Today when I see this I am very sorry for those who asked me to take them and I didn't. If I had to go through it again today, I think I would take. I wouldn't leave. I wouldn't leave, because to this day it pains me.

Interviewer [01:01:54]:

OK, we will take a few minutes break...

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 8 – Transcript

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Moshe Shutan [00:00:49]:

I said that I left the ghetto for the forest. I want to remind you that I was at Gens's and we also spoke of Wittenberg. He said that he thought at the beginning that they would fight, but in the end he says, Wittenberg went to the Germans. And why did he go, do you know? He said to me. Because he thought that he had friends. But he was wrong. I – he says to me - will not be fooled by anyone. I have no one, I have no friends, I know that I am lonely, no one will betray me. Now, there were people I wanted to take and they postponed the departure. Now I ask myself why they postponed the departure, when they knew that the ghetto is in any case temporary. So I think that the passage from the ghetto to the partisans is a passage from a state where you , as long as you are in the ghetto you live quietly, you sleep like a human being as long as it's quiet, so you pass these days also in peace and quiet, but from the moment that you leave for the forest you are in constant danger and with this constant danger you need to fight, and this requires courage, you need courage to hang in there, because at any second, any

minute, there could be some surprise, for better or for worse, and I think that only because of this people were reluctant to go, because they didn't want to enter into a situation that endangers their life at any moment. Now we left

Interviewer [00:03:39]:

We wanted to speak more about the question of how did you know that Wittenberg gave himself up at 10 in the morning, and not at a different hour, like someone else claims?

Moshe Shutan [00:0:58]:

First of all, they received me at 11, at 11 to the FPO

Interviewer [00:04:0]:

That day?

Moshe Shutan [00:04:04]

On that day, all the guys were in the yard, waiting for instructions, they didn't know what will be. They received me at 11 and said to me, Gens handed Wittenberg over to the Germans, that means that he wasn't there, that he had already been handed over. Also Gens told me that later, and hour later I was at Gens's place and he also told me, only he said that it wasn't him who handed Wittenberg over but that they handed Wittenberg over. I don't think that if the Wittenberg affair was not yet over that the FPO would have received me an hour later, or that Gens would have seen me, because the situation in the ghetto was very tense. Besides, they said to me that, Here, he gave Wittenberg up. Glazman said, Also Gens knows all of us, the entire staff of the FPO. And if the Gestapo demands us as well, he will give us up, like he gave Wittenberg up. The conclusion, these are the things that I now said, you can draw yourselves, alone. I don't want to get into arguments now, I will deliver my testimony in its entirety. If there are any questions, then we can talk about it later. Anyway, we left. We left, one went like a brigadier [responsible for a work group] and we are like a group that is going to work with axes, with a saw, they took... we left Vilna, we arrive a few kilometers, it was early in the morning. You can't walk with a group, about 20 people, during the day, because as far as I know, work groups from the ghetto don't go about by then. I found a grove, we entered and I said, Here we will wait till the evening, There was there, not far from us, a shepherd youth with his sheep, and we were terrified that he would see us and we hid and I told everyone not to say a word, to be quiet, and we got through it. In the ghetto, anyone who had a pistol considered himself, I wouldn't say a hero but someone who is hard to hurt, who can fight, you won't be able to take him down just like that, he's got a weapon. But outside the ghetto a group of 20 young, sturdy people, not everyone but with pistols, we were afraid of one lad. Maybe, if you can say it, maybe many people would leave the ghetto, would run away from the ghetto, if it wasn't for this fear from such a lad or a farmer or some townsman, doesn't matter who, because there were incidents when people left and the local population gave them up to the Germans, they informed on them and they were caught. I won't say that the whole

village, if they saw Jews or a Jew, ran to the Germans to give them up. Here, we saw Jews. It's enough for one or two to inform, that's already enough. To say it correctly, this was one of the things that closed the road outside of the ghetto to Jews. The hostility of some in the population was always worse than the Germans because the Germans weren't everywhere, but where groups of Jews needed to pass or single Jews, they always encountered the population, and you didn't know who you would encounter. Since there were many cases where people were caught like this, so it stopped people from leaving the ghetto and hiding in the forest and this was one of the reasons for the Holocaust, one of the important reasons for the Holocaust, is that many people could have escaped if it wasn't for the help of the local population to the Germans. Night came, the shepherd with his sheep went before then, and we continued, we were supposed to reach train tracks. To pass train track was a problem, because the Germans guarded every 200 meters, they guarded the tracks from partisans blowing up trains. We didn't know what to do. I thought, we would get there, then see. The Germans did one more thing, they cut the trees 200 meters on each side of the tracks. So that the partisans will not be able to get freely to the train tracks. I walked first, and Leibke Gurevich, my relative, he was sturdy, strong, he was also a soldier in the Polish army, I told him to walk last and watch the guys that they don't fall back. Next to me walked Bogen, Alexander Bogen. I asked him to walk behind me, not next to me, it's distracting. When you're walking at night, your eyes are in a situation where they don't count. What counts at night is the ears. Because you hear faster than you see at night. And I'm walking first, suddenly I hear someone driving. Driving, I gave an order for everyone to get in between the trees. To get off the road and get between the trees. Everyone entered, I also entered, next to Bogen. One cart passes with a farmer with trees, after 50 meters another one. Like this, five carts went past. Since they weren't close to one another, with the last one I came out and Bogen and I stopped him. He was scared, we came out with the pistols, he was scared. Where are you going? To Vilna. Did you pass the tracks? Yes. What did you see? Nothing. What do you mean nothing? He says, There was no one there. I say to him, Can we believe you? We're Polish partisans, and Bogen starts also talking in Polish, his Polish is better than mine, and the farmer believed us that we're partisans and that we are in no danger, he says, in crossing the train tracks. We said, Drive on, thank you very much and drive on. When we approached the tracks, we saw that on both sides the trees are cut. 200 meters, like I said. So there was a situation like this, that if you walk along the road, you might meet Germans; if you walk through the trees, they can hear the noise, also not good. I, although the *goy* [non-Jew] said that there's no one, did not believe, and by the road was a hut, there was a hut for guards, and I didn't know if there would be someone there or not. I said to everyone to lie down in the forest by the road and I with Bogen and this Leibke approached the tracks by crawling, and I said like this, we will wait here an hour, if there are Germans there, within an hour someone will come out, someone will light a cigarette, someone will talk, it cannot be that people stand like statues. And we waited a long time and there was total quiet, so I said to the group to be ready, but what did I say to them? We walk ahead and they walk 100 meters behind us, not to come closer until they see that

we've crossed, then they cross. We stepped on the tracks, me and Sorke - Alexander Bogen, they called him Sorke – and Leibke, and we went over to the hut. No one. I gave an order that they cross the tracks. We crossed. We crossed and from there we already entered a bigger forest. How did I know how to walk? I had a topographic map with a compass. When we went to Vilna Ghetto, when Markov sent us, he gave me a map with a compass, he also gave Shike a map with a compass. We hid in the forest, dawn started, and we lay there. I put two guards by the road, to see if someone is walking, to raise the alarm. We're lying like this, some 100 meters from the guards, comes one guard, he says, You know, a farmer went past. I said, Why didn't you stop him? Oh, not good, what will I do? Today I see that it was my mistake, I should have told them that if someone sees them they should stop him. If, say, he sees police, to come to us and say, Police, so that we can run away. I didn't tell them. We sat. we sat, after an hour – it wasn't far from Voronian. Voronian is a town, and there was there... there was a *garnizon* of Lithuanian police. After an hour we heard shots by us. I said to everyone, Quickly, and then we advanced and advanced, like the time with Vaska in the forest when they shot at us, 300 meters, half a kilometer, and every time the same story, they shot at us, they came closer and shot and we walked, I walked in a zigzag because the forest wasn't big and by dusk it was quiet, we waited a little bit longer until it grows dark, and we carried on. We continued, another night went past, and by day, me and Bogen would look at the map to choose, to choose the path for walking. We marked the way how to walk and we left, entered a village, took food, I asked a farmer on this road, Are there any noblemen's farms? He said No, the important thing is he said no. Why did I ask about noblemen's farms? Because lately the Germans put in every farm Lithuanian police to guard the farm against partisans, because partisans would enter, take all the food, all they had, and in the end burn it down. So to keep the farms, they would put Lithuanian police, and nu, since in the map I looked that it's fine and the farmer also said there are none, anyway when we had passed some 10 kilometers on the right of the road there were tall cypresses. When we walked by the cypresses, suddenly opened fire on us, opened fire right by my head. I shouted to get off the road, to run away. Unfortunately for us, we needed to run further away. Then they started shooting at us, but we were up the hill. When everyone came up, I said to count off. Because I wanted to see if anyone is missing, two are missing. The aunt, about 54 years old, and another young man from Vilna. I said to head down and search, maybe they're wounded, maybe killed, we need to know. We headed down the hill, we searched, and the whole time they're shooting. It wasn't fire like this... nu, not big like this, but they shot. There were maybe.... They must have had some 5-6 guns. That's what they shot. We didn't find. We didn't find anyone. I said, I can't do anything in the darkness. What can you see? As far as we could look, we searched, we didn't find, we carried on our road. I will make it brief, we arrived... we got to the Narocz forests.¹⁰⁴ Later, a week later, this guy we lost, he came to the partisans. Where is the aunt? The aunt, he says,

For the testimony of Alexander Bogen on these events, see Moshe KelcChaim (ed.), *With Proud* ¹⁰⁴ *Bearing 1939-1945: Chapters from the Partisans' Fighting in the Narocz Forests* (Tel-Aviv: Organization of Partisans and Ghetto Fighters Publishing, 1991), 188-190.

went to some *goyim*, when she saw they were shooting on us, she dragged me, she says, come aside, why should we go with those who are being shot at, we will go aside, so they went aside and like this they stayed. And she knew the area, so she found shelter at a *goy's* and he came on his own to the partisans. I was glad, her son also, her son was the cousin, like I said. He was also, like this he's worried, Oy vey, I lost Mother. Nu, well, they stayed alive. I got to the forest, wanted to go to Markov, Markov wasn't there. What's in the forest? They told me that they founded a Jewish Otriad called 'Revenge' and the commander of the Otriad, a Jewish Captain from the Red Army, who was a *Desatnik* [paratrooper] and the commander of the HQ, Yosef Glazman.¹⁰⁵ Nu, when I came with the group, I saw, I met Yosef Glazman. He looked, he says, Oh, it's good you came, and he told what they had been through in Lavrishky. So he says to me, I don't see in your group anyone from the FPO, where are the FPO people. So I told him the story, and I told him that they decided not to go to the forest anymore, they are doing the rebellion. "Not good," he says, "if they decided to leave for the forest they shouldn't change the decision."

Interviewer [00:25:55]:

What did he tell you about what happened on the road?

Moshe Shutan [00:26:01]:

What happened to them on the road, he said that they walked, they got on the bridge and were shot at. They started to shoot, there were many wounded, killed, and some crossed over. They stayed there, ran away, stayed, ran away through the grove in the forest, so they were, he says a group, they were 55 people he told me, because on the way joined them from Nova Wilejka – they went through Nova Wilejka, and more guys joined them, another group. He said, We were left more than ten people, and he said we need to search if someone is alive, we need to help, and Shike Gertman said, There's no need to wait, we need to go, whoever is left is left, we need to go.

Interviewer [00:27:06]:

According to Glazman. This is what Glazman told you.

Moshe Shutan [00:27:10]:

Yes, Chaim Lazar also tells this in his book.¹⁰⁶ I spoke to Haike [Shike's girlfriend] later. I met her. So she said to me, that they didn't want to listen to Shike, that he said they need to go, so she and one more, they went. And those that stayed wandering in the dark, Oy, where is the guide, there is no guide, they stayed by themselves. It took them some two weeks to get to the forest with Glazman at their head. And when they got to the forest, so probably Glazman or someone else from the group complained to Markov, and when they came, then Shike was there already, he came before them. So

On the "Revenge" unit, see Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial," and Lazar, *Destruction*¹⁰⁵
and *Resistance*, 119-121.

There were 35 people in this group. See Lazar, *Destruction and Resistance*, 78.¹⁰⁶

they said that Markov called Shike and gave him two slaps for leaving the group and running away. What can I say? This whole exit of this first FPO group, they named it after Leon, I swear to you, after all the FPO, the FPO resistance, the guys from Vilna, they had no experience in walking at night. If anyone had experience it was Shike and myself. And if they planned the exit to the forest and did not consult with me or Shike how to go, so I see that as a mistake. They relied only on him. Sometimes there's also another opinion that you need, that you should hear, but they didn't do that. What about the ghetto? I told Glazman that they're sending to Estonia, that the situation in the ghetto is not good, here, that I think Gens is seeing with his own eyes that already his whole idea of keeping the ghetto with the working people is gone with the wind because the Germans caught all the workers from the ghetto, 2,000 people. He said, OK, I, the whole group, I will get an Otriad, but, he says, you – after I told him all that happened to me in the ghetto, the argument with the FPO - you know what? Jurgis is not far from here. Go to Jurgis and tell him what you told me. I said, what does Jurgis need to know? That they spoke badly of you, he says. Today I see one thing, like in Vilna they did not trust me, then also there in the forest, in the group that left, also did not trust me, and suspected me, that maybe I was the one who told Gens that a group is leaving. So today I know that if he had passed this on to Jurgis - Jurgis was Jewish, if he had passed it on to *Osobe Otdail* [Special Unit], it was like the secret service here, would have passed it on to the Russians, then they would have taken me out and killed me like nothing. That was my luck. After this, I had a thing, and I spoke to Sonya Madeisker, so she interrogated me, She says to me like this, Tell me please, you didn't tell Gens about the partisans? About going out to the forest? I said, How could I talk to them about going out to the forest because I myself didn't know when you're leaving. Anyway there was suspicion that the group left and Gena knew about it and he informed the Germans and the Germans ambushed Lavrishky bridge and I am in this mess. When he told me, I was done with Sonya Madeisker, I told her that I, where would I even, I didn't even know that you're leaving. So she says, And with Gens? I said, I spoke to Gens about the *partisanka*, I spoke to Gens about the Narocz forest, I spoke to Gens about Markov, and if I told him about the Narocz forest, so you think that the Germans don't know that there are partisans in the Narocz forest? Like they know that there are Russians in Moscow. They don't have the power to go in and destroy them. After he said, Go to Jurgis and tell him, I decided not to go to Jurgis, what, I will bother him with such things that I don't know, I told you once that I in that period believed in Jews. I believed blindly. And Jurgis after all knew me already, he met up with us at Markov's. I let it go, I knew after all that my conscience is clear, so I didn't make a big deal out of it. I only thought about the behavior towards me on the part of the FPO. We were all received into the Revenge Otriad. A few days passed, Bogen comes to me, Moshe, I want to go back to Vilna, let's go back to Vilna. Since I was sick of the arguments with the FPO, the problems with my family, with my uncle, that every time I came they were afraid, so I said, What do I need all these problems? I will be a partisan like anyone else, I will fight and I will remove all these problems. I wanted to save all our family. I said that I came to Vilna with this guy Czeshek, that we drove with a cart. And I told the uncle

that I am ready to take out all the family, he will come with the cart and some will sit on the cart and some will walk and like this I will take them out of the ghetto. He refused. One of his sons decided to go with me and at the last minute when we stood at the gate to leave, he changed his mind and did not leave with me. Also Baboke Zelkinson that Bogen said to take him, his old aunt came and took him out too. He also stayed, he didn't go, and when Bogen said to me now to go back to the ghetto, I said, I was jealous of all these guys there on.... Riding on horses with *avtomats*, fighting with the Germans, what was the point after all of all my going out to the forest? The idea was all the time to fight the Germans. But... and I decided to stay, and today I see that my decision not... to stay in the partisans, to be one of the guys and not to go to Vilna ghetto, it was childish behavior. And because of this I take my hat off to Alexander Bogen and one more called Yudke Rodnitzky, whom I also brought to the forest, that they went back and said that they're going to Vilna ghetto to take out Jews. I stayed in the Otriad, they went, and I met there Bomke Boyersky. Bomke says, Moshe, we're now going for a reconnaissance around here, come join me and be with me. I said OK. Weapon? Don't worry, he says. He was the, the commander of the group. We were maybe eight people, he gave me an *avtomat*, nu, I picked up an *avtomat* in my hands, I felt myself such a hero, a warrior, and I drove with him. We drove, passed villages, entered villages in the middle of the day. Because usually it was in partisan surroundings, partisan area. Some nights we passed villages. The main mission was, if there are no Germans around, to show the villagers that there is a partisan force, that there is a partisan presence. Well that in itself is not nothing, because the war was still full-blown and those who still believed the Germans would win and those who believed that the.... Russians and Americans, that they would win, but the partisan presence had more meaning for those who thought the Germans would lose. There was an incident where we entered a *goy's* yard, and he says to the *goy*, Listen, food, prepare us lunch. The *goy* says, OK, he had fowl in the yard so all the guys started catching chickens, they caught, I don't know exactly how many, I think we were eight, so if they caught eight chickens. I didn't participate in this story, I stood, I looked. And the *goya* – they slaughtered the chickens and she prepared food and when everything was ready she gave each one chicken on a plate. And I thought that she's giving us the fowl to eat but her heart is bleeding. Me, they all finished the chicken, I, I couldn't eat more than a quarter. When we left I said to Bomke, What kind of behavior is this? Nothing, he says, don't look at such things, we're taking revenge, we need to eat and that's it. For me, this business, this manner of asking food from farmers, that you need to bring them closer to you, but like this you push them away. When we came to the forest, I said, with his team, I'll be better off in Revenge Otriad. I could have stayed in his group, I didn't want to, and I staved with Revemge Otriad. After a few weeks Bogen came back with a group, after a few days Misha came, Yudke Rodnitzky with Kotza, and another, Gilman went with them, three went out, and he also brought a group. This time there were FPO people, Bogen brought FPO people and also Misha Yudke Rodnitzky, among those that Misha Yudke Rodnitzky¹⁰⁷ brought were two poets, these were Shmerke Kacheginsky

See Rodnitzky's testimony at the Fortunoff Archive, HVT-3566.¹⁰⁷

and Avraham Sutzkever. Nu, when more power came in, more people, so the Otriad grew, but the problem was that there weren't enough arms for everyone and the HQ saw that it was both a fighting Otriad, and a non-fighting Otriad, with women. One day they ordered us to arrange ourselves for roll-call, and Markov was there, and he said with another one, Klimov,¹⁰⁸ who was sent from Russia, they said that they're taking apart the Revenge Otriad since not everyone has weapons, and that they will leave those with weapons and integrate then with the Komsomol Otriad, a different Otriad, and that the name of the new Otriad will be Komsomolsky Otriad. And those who don't have a weapon, he will make a '*provizontzia grupa*', a productive group. One girl called Mirka Bernstein stepped out of the ranks and preached in his face: "What, do you think that we came here to cobble shoes, sew clothes, bake? We came here to fight." So he says that the productive group, since you have no weapons, is as important as a partisan unit, because without shoes and shirts and food you cannot exist, but she protested. And when he said to disband, so we the Jews stood still like we're cast aside, but we cannot do anything.¹⁰⁹ I stayed in Komsomolsky Otriad. And my sister was also later in the Otriad. She was a cook. And there was another decree, those who came from Vilna. One day Volotzka, the commander of the brigade named after Voroshilov, Markov's brigade, ordered all the newcomers from Vilna to present themselves in his *paletka*, his tent. A few partisans stood there guarding the tent, and each of the Jewish newcomers, each of them went in and I saw how they left. Whoever had pistols, they took them, whoever had watches, he took them. What else did I see? One who came out, so a partisan standing by the tent said to him, Give me your boots. He was scared, he said, Don't talk much, give me your boots. And he took off his shoes, threw to him torn shoes, and this Jewish man from Vilna Ghetto, he happened to be on the FPO staff, I don't want to say the name. He took off his good boots and gave to the partisan, and took the torn shoes. I got like a stab in my heart. We knew that there are antisemites, we knew that there is attitude, sometimes for better, sometimes for worse, but such a brutal behavior I hadn't seen yet. And then, it entered my head that the Jew is miserable, those in the ghetto are miserable, those in the partisans are miserable, and I thought of the brotherhood of nations that they spoke about, of freedom, and I saw that each nation has their own country, that this time not the Bundsmen are right but the Zionists are right. And from this moment that I saw how they took the boots off of him, I had in my head the Zionist idea that the Jews need their own state. It was difficult for those who were there, such behavior. They were left without weapons, didn't know what to do, but with food they managed somehow. They got food. It was a humiliated state, but if you compare it to the ghetto, there's no comparison. No one is being killed, there's no fear of death for those who are here. They are in the partisan zone, not being chased out. It's true that not everything is rosy, but anyway it's not like in the ghetto. Some days pass, and what does Glazman tell me? Glazman told me that from the Revenge Otriad the first guys went on partisan operations, they cut iron tracks so that the trains cannot run, they sawed telephone poles, committed acts of sabotage, bridges, and that the Jews do the work

Ivan Klimov, the Belarusian Communist Party representative.¹⁰⁸

On this humiliating event, see Bender, "Life Stories as Testament and Memorial," 10-11.¹⁰⁹

willingly and bravely, but in the end, after all, what happened - happened. There were reports that the Germans are placing a blockade. How did they know that the Germans are placing a blockade? There were runners in the towns around the forest and villages. And so they said that to the city of Alt Wilejka, Stera Wilejka, came 4,000 soldiers by train. And then in another area around the forest more and more, many Germans. So they understood why the Germans are bringing so many soldiers, so it was obvious that it's against the partisans and they want to do a blockade. Those in the Otriads didn't have a problem, they had leadership, they had a commander, the commander took care of them, but who will take care of the Jews? Those who are there and are outside any Otriad, the productive unit. They didn't have a commander. Maybe someone was responsible, but not a combatant commander.

Interviewer [00:53:21]

Did they have arms?

Moshe Shutan [00:53:23]:

There were some with guns. So one day this Volotzka says to Komsomolsky Otriad to line up. Nu, I had a gun, so they didn't throw me out of the Otriad, so I was there. I lined up with everyone, I stood in the first row, also unarmed *shkotzim* came to the forest, they received them into the Otriad, they didn't receive unarmed Jews. So Volotzka says, Now, the situation is tense, the Germans are doing a blockade and we need....

Interviewer [00:54:18]:

It's rustling

Moshe Shutan [00:54:19]:

And we need to leave the base. Since we need to leave the base, so he says, only those with weapons will go, because we are going to a battle, those without weapons will only disturb. The German chain, we're going to pass it by force. He comes over and looks at everyone, comes over to me, looks at my Nagan, looks at me, I, in the mirror - in the mirror I didn't look like such a hero. Not tall, I was skinny. He says, Give me your gun. I said, Why? Give the gun, he says, to this *sheigetz*. Behind me stood a blonde *sheigetz*. His face was like a rabbit. Like this, looking, like he doesn't know in what world he is, and to me he says that I should give him my gun. Why? I say. So he says, Because you didn't come to fight, you came to hide behind his back. I said, I'm not giving the gun. He says, I order you. Pulls his pistol from his belt. I said, I won't. At the side stood Sivalaik, This Sivalaik, it was, there were new people who came to the partisans, ran away from captivity, and he grabbed me by the hand from the side. He was tall, sturdy, in two seconds he had the pistol off of me, and I was left without a weapon. Because you did not want to fulfill the order, he says to me, to give up the weapon, I banish you from the Otriad and you can go to hell. I stepped out, sat aside. And I said, we will see, we will live and see. After the inspections he did, he said to

everyone, Half an hour, be ready to leave.¹¹⁰ We sat down, me and some guys and women and local Jews, all Jews. We said, What shall we do. Before this, when the FPO groups came from Vilna and the Jews and the locals, so it was jolly, the Jews were happy that Jews running away from the ghettos are coming, there were partisans, so Shmerke Kacherginsky¹¹¹ was master at organizing public singing, recitation, and there was a partisan with a guitar, so every evening they would sing, whoever is on the base, and would sing Yiddish *lieder*, Jewish, Yiddish songs, and Shmerke would direct everything, and the feeling was very good. But with time, when the persecutions against the Jews started, when they started taking away weapons, all the high spirits faded to nothing and now we sat stranded and thought what to do, because we are being left for the Germans.

Interviewer [00:59:25]:

The tape is done.

Moshe Shutan [00:59: 30]:

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Moshe Shutan [00:00:41]:

We sat in the base and didn't know what to do. After half an hour, the Komsomolsky Otriad organized in lines and the commander gave the order and they left the base. Since we had no idea where the Germans are coming, how, but they after all had scouts and they sort of knew where and what. We didn't know anything, so spontaneously, almost everyone who was there got up and started marching after the Otriad. So he stopped the Otriad and shouted, Back, you are not allowed to walk with us. And they marched onwards. How did they march onwards, they walked on, and again we are behind them. So he shouted, he said, If you don't stop walking after us I will shoot you, but who listens? They walked, we carried on. So he stopped and fired a few volleys from the

On antisemitism among the partisans, see Leonid Smilovitsky, "Antisemitism in the Soviet Partisan Movement, 1941–1944: The Case of Belorussia," *Holocaust and Genocide Studies* 20.2 (2006), 207–234.

Shmerke Kacherginsky (1908–1954) was a prominent Yiddish poet, songwriter, and cultural activist¹¹¹ who played a crucial role in preserving Jewish cultural treasures during the Holocaust. Born in Vilna, alongside Zelig Kalmanovich and Abraham Sutzkever he was a member of the "Paper Brigade," working to rescue books and manuscripts from Nazi destruction while secretly smuggling material into the ghetto. After escaping to join the partisans in 1943, Kacherginsky became a resistance fighter and continued his literary work, documenting the experiences of Jewish partisans and preserving their songs and stories for posterity. See his book, *Partisans March!...* (Bamberg: Auf der Wach, 1948). Kacherginski was killed in a plane crash in Argentina in 1954.

sub-machine gun, above our heads. Nu, and that defeated us, they left, we stayed. We went back to the base, I sat under a tree. Guys, acquaintances of mine around me, also my sister, and they're saying, What shall we do? Since many knew me as a person who walked, who knows roads, so they asked for advice, Moyshe, what shall we do? I was tired from all this mess, my head was like, how shall I tell you, like worn down, like *abas*(?). It was difficult for me to think. I said to them, I must rest. I can't think of anything. I went under a tree and fell asleep. When I got up, everyone is by me. Nu, what do you say, what do you decide? I said like this. To sit in the base and wait for the Germans to come – this serves no end. From the history that I learned, so from the history of wars, so it was the general who could maneuver and take his soldiers out, bring them somewhere. So I said, to sit, there's no point in sitting, one must maneuver. But how, where and when, I didn't know. But it was in my head that we get out of here. This is what I'm thinking and telling them. Suddenly one comes in on a horse, a partisan with a gun, and goes over to the tent of one of the commanders. Which commanders, there was a hospital there, so there was the commander of the hospital, and they left the base, all the partisans, all the Otriads, and the hospital with the sick they left. So this partisan comes, he says, I come from the HQ, and there's an order that the whole hospital with all, everyone who is left on base, that they go to the island. What does it mean, the island? Inside the river, in the forest, there were swamps, so in one place there were swamps all around and a small portion between the swamps was dry, above the swamps, and there, to this island, it was difficult, through the swamps, it was very difficult to get there. So that's where we'll go. So the commander of the hospital comes out, since he got an order to gather everyone, also those who do not have weapons, not just the sick. So he also used us to carry the sick. Took some carts, with horses, our food on the carts, the badly wounded put on the carts, and he says Let's go, we're going to the island. Nu, already we felt that we're not alone, that there is in any case someone who's taking care of us. We reached the swamps, already there, with the carts, the horses, you couldn't go, so they made stretchers, put the sick on stretchers, and like this we carried them through the swamps. When you would put a foot in where there's a swamp, it would sink to the knee. Anyone who says It's possible, I walked in the swamps to my neck – even when you're walking to the knee, you can barely pull your leg out. I entered the swamps with shoes, and the shoes stayed in the swamps, I just barely pulled my leg out and walked barefoot. I think that happened to others as well. We reached Ostrov. Nu, and the commander says, Here sit quietly, here I hope we will sit out the blockade. We sat down, obviously, all acquaintances in groups, also *Shkotzim*, they were unarmed, they were also in the hospital. There were some partisans with guns who guarded the hospital. We sit maybe Three hours. Around noon we hear shots. We hear shots on one side, shots on the other side, so the commander says, Not good. I see – he says – that they're coming closer. And the shots, we heard more on what's further, closer. In the end he told everyone to arrange themselves, we got in line, he says, I see that we will not be able to sit through the blockade here, and each person must save themselves. In small groups, each person should do as they think best, and disperse. Like this as we stood, so I see three local *Shkotzim*. There's a difference

between local *shkotzim* and those who came from captivity, from the Germans. Because those who returned from German captivity were all antisemites. They all learned from the Germans to hate Jews. I said, *shkotzim* from the village, they weren't in captivity, I will go with them, and the rest of the guys also joined me, where I was, and we left. We left, they left first together and then I see one is already some five meters ahead from the second and the third already ten meters from the second and we are even further, now they're almost running and we are after them. I didn't like that. I thought we would go as a united group, together, and here I see one doesn't even look at the other, they're running like crazy. I said, No, this isn't a salvation for me. And I stopped. I stopped, all the guys after me stopped. Moshe, why did you stop? I said, Here, this is a question of life and death. And whoever thinks that salvation lies with these *shkotzim*, should go with them, I'm not going. But we will be late, they are the locals, they know the roads. Here, look, I said to them. They're already gone. So what shall we do? I said, This we will see. In the meantime, between the trees, I see a Jewish girl.

Interviewer [00:11:55]:

Sorry, you returned, back, you came out of the swamps and are back in the forest?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:00]:

We are going from the island, walking from the island.

Interviewer [00:12:04]:

You are walking in the swamps now?

Moshe Shutan [00:12:06]:

We haven't entered the swamps yet.

Interviewer [00:12:08]:

You are still on the island.

Moshe Shutan [00:12:09]:

On the island. So I see a girl. Who is the girl? She is from Vilna. Vilna Ghetto. Mirka Ginionski,¹¹² maybe you heard. I said, Mirka, what are you doing here? I knew her already on the base. So she says, I don't know what to do. Come with me, I said. Don't stay alone, she doesn't know what to do, I said, Come with me. She joined the group. Now I am standing by myself, all the guys around me, saying, What shall we do? Our last chance of rescue, our opportunity to save ourselves, just went, now we are left alone. I said, we don't need anything worse than these *Shkotzim*. This is no comfort for me. I had in my pocket the map, I had in my pocket the compass, this is what there was. And I said, Let's see on the map where we are. We need to plan something. I took out the map, put it together with the compass, oriented it precisely, to the north. I saw here

Miriam Ginionski, a Betar member, liaison, and FPO activist, was killed by Lithuanian police, who¹¹² tortured her before her death in the Narocz forests in 1944. See, *The Lexicon of Bravery*, 116-117.

is our swamp, there is the base, here is the forest, there the river flows, called Narocz, there is a town, Miadzyel, here, and the name of the lake is Narocz, on the other hand a village, Czeremeshitsa. On the other side of the river and from Czeremeshitsa goes a road to the partisan village. I saw this small area between Czeremeshitsa and the Miadzyel river and the Miadzyel Lake, it was swamps, a relatively small swamp, a square kilometer, no more. And this swamp had the river on one hand, and Czeremeshitsa village and Czeremeshitsa lake on the other. The third side was closed by the road from Czeremeshitsa to the base. It was a small swamp, enclosed on all sides. Why did I say enclosed? Because where the lake and the river are it's closed, in Czeremeshitsa there are Germans, and on the road, in the forest, also Germans drove. We heard the machines driving. So I made a calculation. To run, to go someplace without knowing what will be, I didn't want that. I said like this, the Germans are looking, not for one partisan or two, they want to catch hundreds. The partisans wanted to leave the encirclement, they won't go to such a small swamp that is enclosed on all sides, that if they catch them there they have no escape. So I said, since the partisans won't go there, and the Germans won't look there, I will go in there. But there's a problem, you need to get past the river and not everyone knows how to swim. I looked at the map, put it in my pocket, took the compass, the *shkotzim* went straight, I said, According to the situation we need to go left, towards the forest, towards the river. We went through swamps and suddenly I see among the trees a shadow. And a little kid comes out, a 12-year old, *goy, sheigetz*. I stopped, I said to him, Where are you going? He says, I'm going to the island. What Otriad are you? I say. From Suvorov. I said, there's no reason to go there because there's no one there. In the trouser belt I had a German grenade with a long wooden handle, and where did the grenade come from? When everyone left, when the Otriad left and we were left on base, I see Bomke Boyarsky riding along on a cart with some other partisans, and among them were also guys that I took out of Vilna Ghetto. I said to him, Bomke, there is a problem. What is the problem? Such and such. Can you receive me to your group, to your Otriad? Me and my sister. He says, get on the cart. We get on the cart, he says I will go talk with the commander. After ten minutes he comes out, he says, I'm sorry, he won't take you. So when I saw that I'm left out, I said to him at least give me a grenade so that I won't fall in Germans hands alive. So he takes out the grenade and gives it and like this I said goodbye to him. So I see the *sheigetz*, Donka they called him. I say, Donka, you see the group, I am the commander of the group, and I hold my stomach out so he sees the big weapon, the grenade. He's an innocent kid, he says, So there's no one there? I said, If you want, I tell him, you can join our group, I will take you. He thought, he thought, OK. I asked him, tell me where you're coming from. He says, from Czeremishitsa. How are you leaving, came from Czeremeshitsa? There are Germans there, he says, I ran away. I was in the partisans already, I went to see what's going on in Czeremeshitsa, in my home, then suddenly the Germans came, so I ran away. So I say, if you ran from Czeremeshitsa then you had to cross the river, how did you cross the river? There's a passage, he says. Oooo, I think, this is what I'm looking for. I said so come, lead us to the place where the river passage is. OK. We come to the river, I don't see any passage,

nothing. I said to him, Where is your passage? He says, come, come, a bit more. Leads me a bit farther, he says, Here. I don't see anything. He says, Here, this is the passage. What was it? Inside the water, 30 cm, were two logs the width of the river. Very long, the river was not so big, but the trees were sufficient, that it was big, it was deep. The trees were big enough that they reached from one side to the other and maybe they were connected or some thing, I don't know. So he says, Here in the water, I put my foot in the water, 30 cm, right? So like this, slowly slowly, we crossed. Why did we cross carefully? Because the trees were slippery, you could slip. So one helped the other, held each other's hands, and like this slowly slowly, we crossed the river. Nu, when I was already on the other side of the river, I breathed in relief. I said, we will go some... 200 meters from the river and there we will hide. In this swamp the farmers would *ungeshnit*, how you say, they would mow the grass, how you say, not grass, grass yes.

Interviewer [00:22:06]:

Hay

Moshe Shutan [00:22:07]:

Hay, they would mow hay, make whole piles. So in summer it's impossible to take it out because of the mud. But in winter when everything is frozen, so they come with, not with carts, with sleds, and they take out the grass. Since it was still summer, it was September, so there was the mud, you couldn't take it out, so this was there. So I said, we will hide, we will sit among the grass. And like this we entered, I left two for guarding on both sides and we dug into the grass and there we sat. We sat until the evening, and Donka the *sheigetz* with us. Suddenly we see the skies are red, what is this, fire. Fire, we climbed on trees, looked next to us, the village of Czeremeshitsa is on fire. A big fire, and we heard shouts of people, shouts of animals, shots. I said to sit tight and that's it. What did we see? We saw that farmers and even women with grass on their backs, running in the swamp. What was also the problem? German planes, the Rama – there's a plane called Rama, a square like that. It's a reconnaissance plane, so they can see what's going on. So the farmers put the grass so that the planes will not see, although it's in the swamp among trees they did like that. And we are in that grass. Suddenly one ran into the grass, a *shikseh*, a girl, she looks, Oy, where are you from? She saw that we're Jewish. So she says, I'm so afraid of dying – you, you're Jews anyway, but me, what did I do? I said, Go away from here, so that I don't see you. So she went. We stayed until the morning, all night we were there, and early in the morning we heard shots from the riverside, maybe 200 meters from us, shots of machine guns, of ... of submachine guns. As it appeared, the Germans reached the river on the other side, but didn't cross it, only shot across to the other side, towards our swamp, where we were and so they passed with shots, and it grew quiet. We were there all day, in the evening I said, Now, all night we heard machines on the road, we were not far from the road in the forest, we said tonight we're leaving here, and going in the direction of the swamps to the west of Narocz forests, there was a big swamp, we will go there. We came to a road, there were cars, we waited for them to pass, and crossed the road and

came to the swamps. In one place we saw a house, a lone house. We entered the house, maybe we will find some food, and luckily we found some. The farmers from the houses and the villages also ran from the Germans, so the house, it was empty, no one was there, but the stove was hot. They left, maybe ate something and left. I opened the stove, we found there a pot with borscht, nu, it was food for us, we drank the borscht, everyone. Each person held the pot and drank a little. We also found some meat bones, we ate, carried on.

Interviewer [00:27:24]:

About how many people are you?

Moshe Shutan [00:27:26]:

It was about twenty also. I arrived, I saw a house and light. I went over, then I said, I will go with Mirka Ganionsky, she looked like total *goya* [non-Jew]. I said, if we need to go into a farmer's house, he shouldn't see that we're Jews. I go to the window, I look inside, There are Ukrainians sitting, in uniform, those that served the Germans. Oh, I said, not good. Suddenly I see someone entering from a side room, and who is he? Vaska, the guy who walked with us to Vilna, and he was going to take down a train. When I saw him I already said, These Ukrainians must be on our side. I told her to wait outside, went in by myself. Vaska, Oh, how did you get here? I said, I told him in brief, I said, Look, I've got 20 guys here, I need food for them, bread. He says, I will give you, there is some. How did you stay alive? He says, I didn't believe you would stay alive. I went to take down a train, that's nothing for me, but to go to a city full of Germans and not get caught, not be killed – I thought you wouldn't live anymore. Here, he says, I was wounded in three places, I have wounds, two in the foot, two in the hand. I barely ran away, he says, we didn't manage to take down the train. OK, I said, and how's it going in general? He says, The blockade in the forest is over and now we are all going back to the forest. Who are the Ukrainians sitting there? They ran away from the Germans, switched to the partisan side. OK, he gives me two loaves of bread. I stepped outside, we got to the guys, distributed food to everyone, OK guys, back to the base. We got to the base, I already found there Avraham Sutzkever and Shmerke [Kacherginsky] sitting by themselves. More guys came. Nu, what will be now? Life in the forest started up again, the partisans returned slowly, slowly, and like it was, when there was no one, so now already came hundreds, but Markov – him, I didn't see. But anyway, I arrived, but now I am not a partisan, I was thrown out of the Otriad. What to do? So the guys said, That we are not accepted – never mind, but that they throw one like you out of the Otriad – this is really the end of the world. So one of them goes, there was a group there, *spetz-gruppe*, and they didn't belong to Markov's brigade, they had a special mission of their own. What was their job, what to do, I don't know. And there was one guy, nice like this, 20 years old. He was from Askevitz. So one of the guys comes over to him, and they sat there, he says, you see this partisan? He was thrown out of the Otriad. Who is he, what is he? He told what he knew about me. He's like this, these are the kind that we need. So he comes to me, says, Go talk to this

partisan. I go over to him, he asked me questions, I answered him, he said, Look, we're not staying here, we're going, but I will take you, take you with us. Nu, OK. I said, I have a sister, he says, not only you. I go over to my sister, I said to her, Look, there's such a situation, we got past the blockade, and we hope it will be OK, everyone came back. You be in the *spetz-gruppe*, and I need to go, I came to the forest to fight, not to sit in the *spetz-gruppe*

Interviewer [00:2:40]:

Not in the *spetz gruppe*

Moshe Shutan [00: 32:42]:

In the unit

Interviewer [00: 32:45]:

In the production unit

Moshe Shutan [00: 32:46]:

Production, yes. Shike, him I did not see all this time. Shike Gertman. I didn't see him all this time, I don't know where he was. Before the blockade, HQ decided to do a *rota*, a company of '*reiter*', cavalry. And Sorke got the job to be commander and to go and Take from the farmers good horses, and he went out with them.

Interviewer [00:33:41]:

Sorke Bogen?

Mosh Shutan [00:33:43]:

Alexander Bogen, yes, he went out with them to ... I couldn't walk, my legs from the swamp, from everything it was all with wounds, so I stayed on the base and he went with them. I decided I would go with this special group, so I said goodbye to everyone. One morning, the next day or two days later, in the morning we left. Where are we going? He said that we're going east to Byelorussia. This was also Byelorussia, but it was western Byelorussia, and there is Byelorussia of Vostock. So by leaving with this group, I basically finished my job as a Jewish partisan among Jews. Because all that I did, I did it to help Jews, to bring them to the forest, with arguments, without arguments, with problems, without problems, and here in this group there were no Jews. Later another one joined, from Kovna I think. I forgot his name. I think Tsavi, I can't remember well. And one morning we, I said goodbye to everyone and we left east. This was my story from the beginning of the *partisanka* until after the blockade. From now, if I'm telling it begins a personal story of what happened, I was in Byelorussia, among the Byelorussian partisans. If it interests you I can tell. If not, then we finish with the testimony.

Interviewer [00:36:17]:

No, no, it's certainly interesting.

Moshe Shutan [00:36:26]:

We left in the morning, we walked by day. I was already used through the partisans to walking by day because I knew there were also partisan areas. The commander was Captain, Captain of the unit, his rank was Captain, and there was also a commissar and the rest of the combatants. They were all equipped with weapons, there was one machine gun, we were about 15 people. There was one machine gun, sub-machine guns, and guns. And me, I had nothing, I only had the grenade. We arrived around two to a place with about four houses and the commander said we will be here a while. It was four o'clock, it was still light. The commander calls me, the commissar, Come here. What is it? Listen, we want to send a letter to Markov's HQ. Can you ride a horse? I said yes, I didn't know.... So I will give you a horse and you will ride to the base, deliver the *paket* and return. OK. When we went from the base here, so the guys sent, the machine gun passed from one to the other because it's difficult to carry a machine gun all the time. Then came my turn. They're all bigger and stronger than me, came my turn, I took the machine gun, I walked some hundreds of meters, it was difficult so I bent over, walked bent over, but I didn't say that it's difficult, I was afraid to say. So the commissar walks back and forth among the guys, so he says, You don't have strength, pass the machine gun to someone else. No, no, Mr. Comrade Commissar, It's not difficult for me. I tell you to pass it on, pass it on. Now he's telling me he's sending me back, to the base, and he will give me a horse. I said to myself, why did he choose me? He's got guys whom he knows, but I cannot refuse an order. I said OK, pick a horse for me. The farmer had a few horses, he picked out for me a little horse like this, sturdy, said, Take the horse and go. Will you know the way? I said yes. To say 100% if I knew the way – we only passed once, in places I have never been before. But I said yes. After all, I kind of knew the direction. OK. I sat on the horse and went back. On the way a partisan with a gun met me, on a tall horse, skinny like this, a *peger* about to die. *Zdrasovitzye, Zdarsovitzye*, Hello hello, where are you going? None of your business, I say. Listen, he says, maybe we switch horses? Oh, I said, not good, I am without weapons. He has a weapon, he can take my horse by force. I said, I can't. What is it, he says, What can't you do? Look, my horse is better than yours. I said, I can't because this is the horse of the commander of the patrol. If I don't bring his horse back, he will kill me and go looking for you. No, no, I was just kidding, he says, I didn't want, but you, you're not a human, he says and rides off. He rides off, I get to the base. I get to the base I see Shike [Gertman] sitting there and someone... he's getting his hair cut. I entered below, handed over the package and I need to head back

Interviewer [00:00:41:42]:

Entered to whom? Markov?

Moshe Shutan [00:41:45]:

In the HQ, Markov wasn't there. I come out, I see Shike and I saw my sister, nu, just one day had passed, not even a day, I left in the morning and came back in the evening. They asked me, how is it there with the guys? I said, I still don't know, we will see. And I wanted to ask Shike about this whole business, and what happened, why did he leave me and not say anything? Later I thought, the truth is he experienced a defeat, as you say, he did not succeed in the mission of taking the guys out of the ghetto so his heart must be aching, so what, I will sow salt on his wounds? I said, I will be silent, I won't ask him anything, just, How are you? How are you feeling? And so I said goodbye to my sister, to him, and all the other guys, and that was the last time I saw Shike because afterwards he fell. I drive back, it's already dark.

Interviewer [00:43:08]:

How are you managing with the horse, anyway? If you can't ride

Moshe Shutan [00:43:14]:

There were reins, I held the reins and sat. I will tell you, when he went in *glob* - how do you say *glob*?

Interviewer [00:4:28]:

Running.

Moshe Shutan [00:4:29]:

Not regular running.

Interviewer [00:4:1]:

Galloping?

Moshe Shutan [00:4:2]:

Galloping, then it was easy, when he runs its hard, it throws you about when he runs, but galloping then I'm sitting like on a couch, so I almost all the way, almost all the way I galloped because it was easier for me. Anyway, when I got later to this *khotor*,¹¹³ back, once I got off the horse I couldn't move. I'm driving back, and suddenly I see two roads like a fork and I didn't know where to turn, how can I know exactly, a road I don't know? So I thought I needed to turn right, I rode to the right, rode some 300 meters, I feel, this is not what I saw on my way, it's all field. So I stop the horse, went back, not to the fork but farther back, I said, I will let the horse walk on his own. And I pull the reins, the horse starts walking, by himself, without me guiding him, he went left and like this I got to the place. I got to the place, there was a guard, one of the guys, he asked me, The password? He gave me a password, I answered him. This commissar comes out, he says to me, You know, you're lucky you found us. If you'd gotten lost, we wouldn't have waited for you. That didn't seem to me an encouraging attitude. OK, the next morning they're saying we're leaving. We all gathered, we were already ready, suddenly we hear

Khotor: an isolated farm house.¹¹³

shots from the forest, all at once everyone is on their feet, no, one shot. And we step outside, look, we see from the forest, it was maybe 800 meters from us, a *sheigetz* runs. We go towards him, he comes, and he's shouting, they shot Vaska, Pietzka. What is this, they shot Pietzka? He says, I was sitting with him, and some animals by us, we were guarding them, they ate grass and suddenly we heard a shot and Pietzka fell, so the commander told us to go look for the shell because if there was a shot there must be a shell. We looked among the trees, didn't find, so he goes over to this *sheigetz* he says, Tell the truth, From where did you hear the shot? He says, From there, and this *sheigetz* lying on the ground like he's dead, a bullet entered here and exited here, but a nurse came with us so she took his pulse, took his hand, she says, He's alive. So they immediately put him on a stretcher and took him back home. But the commander is speaking with the other *sheigetz*, he says, Where did they shoot from? He says, I don't know, I heard a shot. He gave him two slaps, he says, You shot. So the *sheigetz* immediately broke down, he says, Yes. What did you shoot with? With the *Trezenka*(?). How do you have a *trezenka*? We found. Where is it? So he went to a tree, under a tree, which he found, he took out a *trezenka*, and that was the weapon with which he shot his friend. They played, and suddenly he shot and hit him. I said, Oh, I'm dealing with such commanders here, how did he catch him out. We set out and left already in the evening and this *sheigetz* who was wounded, he was up on his feet in a few hours. His luck was that the bullet passed straight through, it didn't stay. We're walking, more partisans come from the sides and more partisans, we were already several hundreds. Then the commander says we need to cross train tracks, and it's an area with guards. We waited 300 meters from the tracks, then came an order to run. We ran over the tracks and one commander stands on the tracks shouting Faster, faster. We crossed, the minute we crossed rockets and shots started, but not shots from one side, from several sides. Partisans did a distraction action and the Germans shot there, and in the meantime we here crossed. And we entered a dense forest, and this was already the east side of Byelorussia. We entered a big forest and there we already walked all night and carried on, we also walked by day. The whole way we walked, Byelorussia until the base where we arrived, we walked day and night. We just kept going and walking. The appearance of the villages in Byelorussia is different from Poland, there you had Kolkhozs, it was like this, boring. Big fields, you see a single color. After the Germans came the Kolkhoz after all didn't work together, everyone worked for themselves, but this appearance remained. Because in Poland every farmer tilled his bit of land, with this and with this, all kinds of things. And there it didn't exist. We got to the forest, to a partisan base. And after a few hours the commissar comes over to me, says, Listen, we're carrying on, you will stay here in the Kalinin Brigade and be a partisan here. So I saw that they want to get rid of me and they left me in the Kalinin Brigade. I come to the base, they told me a trench, where to enter, there you will be. I don't know anyone they're guys, Russians, Byelorussians, Ukrainians. And the Ukrainians were few. I felt a little like this, lonely, I got used to Jews, here there's no Jew. The moment I came they started asking me, Where are you from and what are you. By my speech they saw that I'm not Russian so first they thought I was Polish, I said to them no, I am not Polish, I'm Jewish. OK,

among us, they say, everyone is equal, no difference. And they start asking me, Where is the family from, what is the father, what is the mother. I said to them that I'm from a family of workers. So this was alright, so this – I already knew that I should say I am from a family of Jews, of workers. So one of them says, He's one of us, you can count on him, he's all right. A day later the commissar of the Otriad comes to me, called Kapitonov, and holds a conversation with me, but unlike the *Shkotzim* he didn't ask me who are you, what are you, who do you belong to. He talked to me about literature, and later he told me that he was a director, principal of a high school, in Russian literature. So he talked to me about literature, so I said to him like this, he will talk to me, a word here, a word there, later, from what I will say. He will already see who am I and what am I. Anyway, I got on with him in conversation, and we stayed friends was that he treats me well, and from the moment I saw that he treats me well so it was no longer, my loneliness wasn't like it was. I gained courage, I felt more free, I said, it will be OK. After a week we set out on an ambush mission, an ambush against the Germans. They gave me a gun, and in the ambush we walked some 20 kilometers. Germans came, we shot at them, but we didn't attack them because they were about 100, more than 100 people, and we were not more than twenty. It was a platoon. They started shooting at us, so we ran away, but we caused them casualties.

Interviewer [00:55:23]:

You already have a weapon?

Moshe Shutan [00:55:25]:

They gave me a gun. Nu, when we returned to base, it was merry, Oh, we showed the Germans, and like this the time passed from one operation to the other. Once we went to battle against a position of Germans, we took out the position, returned back, we would go and return to the base. I also got to know there on the base one guy who worked as a baker, he would bake bread for the partisans. So one needed flour, where did the flour come from? I stood on guard and I see five carts driving, on the first cart is a red flag, approaching the forest. I said Stop, I already had the instructions, and they waited. Partisans came, took the horses, and the farmers waited, unloaded the flour, potatoes, and they returned to them the carts with the horses and they went back, and like this there was flour to bake bread. I became friendly with this baker, what was special about this baker out of all the other partisans? They were all young, aged 20, 25-30, no more. He was 55. And I spoke with him, he told me that he knows about the situation of the Jews, that they're killing them, and he himself went to the partisans, he left a wife at home in Minsk – he was from Minsk – and two children, his two sons are in the Red Army. Like this I found another friend, apart from the commissar, and the guys treated me, I didn't, I had no cause for complaints. One day they put me on guard with two other guys, it was winter, and at the end of the forest, before a field, everything was snowy with snow, covered in snow, and there was a trench maybe ten meters from the place where there was a tree, where I stood on guard. So I have to stand guard first, from six till ten, and they were both in the trench, and then we switch. When they stood

on guard, so these *Shkotzim* took with them bags, a bag with potatoes, there was a stove there, an iron stove, they lit the stove and then started *kartoshkes*... how do you say?

Interviewer [00:59:11]:

Roasting.

Moshe Shutan [00:59:11]:

How?

Interviewer [00:59:12]:

Roasting.

Moshe Shutan [00:59:16]:

After the *kartoshkes* were ready one of them shouts to me from inside, Come here, take a *kartoshke*. I took a *kartoshke*, I ate, after five minutes he says Come, take another *kartoshke*, I came over and took another *kartoshke*. It was cold, But I had a coat like this of fur, and also Bolek – I have to stand up, it's my leg, it's numb.

Interviewer [00:59:47]:

We can stop. We're already at the end of the tape, right Dani? We will finish it. One more minute.

Moshe Shutan [01:00:00]:

So he says, Why are you taking the *kartoshke* and going to stand guard? Sit and eat. I said, It's forbidden, how can I do a thing like that? So he says, You're afraid to sit down, all the Jews, you're a coward, all Jews are cowards. Oh, the moment he says, All Jews are cowards, so I sat down immediately. I sat down, I took one *kartoshke* after another, he gave me, I was warm, it was good, it was also tasty, and I fell asleep. I fell asleep, and when I woke up, I heard shouting and somebody hitting me in the head, on the head. One hand, second hand. The gun was between my legs. I grabbed the gun and shouted, Stop, I shoot. So he immediately took the gun away from me. I saw someone tall, I didn't know who it was, I was still asleep, who took the gun from me, and I got up to him, so I saw, I came, I saw it was the brigade commissar. You fell asleep on guard duty, is this how you keep watch? It was his adjutant. His adjutant – He should be killed.¹¹⁴ So the commissar says, Get up, go to the woods. There were a few meters there, a few trees. I got up and went, I went back. Again, he took out his Mauser in my face. And I'm going, going. I thought, here, I will see light, and if it all ends here in Byelorussia, in the forest, that's it.

Interviewer [01:02:11]:

On executions in the partisan units, see Daniela Ozacky Stern, "Executions of Jewish Partisans in the Lithuanian Forests – The Case of Natan Ring," *International Journal of Military History and Historiography* 40 (2021): 219-244.¹¹⁴

We'll start next time.

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 10 – transcript

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interviewer [00:00:45]

This AC is off? Yes, the AC is off? OK.

Moshe Shutan [00:00:58]

As I stood in front of the commissar, in the last seconds I thought of something to say, and the words escaped my mouth, 'I am left the only one from my family'. He stopped, looked at me, asked me, 'How old are you?' I said 19. 'Did you see the movie *Chapaev*?' I had seen the movie *Chapaev*, but I told him no. Why? Because in the movie *Chapaev* there's a story where the guard, the sentry, stood watch and he fell asleep and because of this Chapaev – and then Chapaev is killed. They storm the camp and Chapaev is killed. He says, 'When they show Soviet movies one should watch, see them.' He said to me, 'Go back to your post, and give the adjutant the gun. Go stand guard, and you should know, if something happens again, you will not come out of it alive. In about another half hour the brigade commander is supposed to arrive, make sure you look alert.' And he drove off with the adjutant. I stood, I thought, my situation is not good, but, nu, I could not do anything, I stood and waited. I waited and I hear them coming closer. I shout, 'Stop! Stop where you are, one person – I say – one person come here and the rest stay where they are.' I saw a small man walking and approaching, and I recognized that that is the Brigade commander. He comes, taps my shoulders, 'Oh, you're a good guard.' Everyone comes closer. He said, 'Because you're guarding like this', he takes out a bag with Majorca, with newspaper, and says, 'Smoke.' I said, 'No, one shouldn't smoke while on guard.' 'If I the commander give you, you should take', I took. He took the lighter, wanted to light the cigarette. I said, 'I took, I took, but while I'm on guard duty I will not smoke.' He said, 'You're A-OK.' And drove off. They drove off, and I thought to myself, he will go to the commissar, and then he will see what kind of head-in-the clouds guys. When they relieved me from guard duty in the morning, they arrested me and put me in the trench with a guard and I was left alone. Commissar Capitonov came and told me there would be a trial. I sat the whole time, a few days went by, they gave me 100 grams of bread and 1 liter of water but I didn't think of the food, I thought what would happen. The guard who knew me, the guards were from my unit, so they didn't even talk to me, nothing. A few days went by and Commissar Capitonov, he's the unit commissar not the brigade commissar. And he says to me, 'The trial will be today and I will be there, and I'm very sorry about everything that happened and I want you to come out of it alive,' and he goes off. That same day in the evening

he comes to me and says, 'You were found not guilty,' and he told me that during the discussion, during the trial, Commissar Yesinovich, the Brigade commissar, says, 'The Germans killed his whole family and when he said that he is the only one left of his family, it's as if he told me his whole biography. I would finish what the Germans started. And that's why I left him alive.' Some people there demanded a death sentence, but the commissar was against it, and also the Brigade commander, he said I agree with the commissar. The adjutant only said, 'Where is the order, where's the discipline, we've already had an incident like this....' So he said about this, 'This is already the second incident, and in the first incident at least we banished him.' So the commissar said, 'Yes, we banished him, but he was under 18 and returned to his village, where is he going to go?' He meant me. And when he said to him, 'Where's the discipline, where's the order,' then the commissar said 'I'm Russian and not German.'

Capitonov comes to me and tells me the whole progress of the trial and says to me, 'How did you dare sleep on watch, and you committed not one but two crimes. The first crime you committed is that you sat down. If you had not sat down, you probably would not have fallen asleep.' So I told him the story I had with the gentiles (*Shkotzim*), that they laughed at me for being a Jew afraid to sit, that all Jews are cowards. He heard this and said 'Wait, we need to go into action, I will run to the commissar.'

After half an hour he comes back and says, 'The verdict was 10 days in jail.' So he comes in and says, 'I talked to Yesinovich, you're free, you're going into action with us.' I left the trench and they gave me back a gun, and we left the base. The main job we did there was ambushes, more than once we attacked German outposts and also the collaborators, Belarusians, Ukrainians. What else did I want to say? During the trial they asked Capitonov what has he got to say about this case; so he said it's a serious incident, he said this, but he said that on the other hand, 'Look, he came to us in the first place, he came straight to the headquarters and asked for two people with dynamite and to go blow up a train off the tracks. And this is a sign that he's a warrior, he didn't just come to sit in the forest.' Why am I telling you this whole incident? Our situation in Narocz [forest] was very difficult. Antisemitism there was very high. At first, they didn't have such antisemitism, but then came prisoners who were with the Germans and Ukrainians who fought at first with the Germans against the Russians and they brought the antisemitism to the forest. And besides, they were also antisemitic officers. But here in Easter Belorussia it wasn't present, and I felt good, I felt among equals, So the gentiles (*Shkotzim*) would sometimes tell a joke or something, there were also two Ukrainians who escaped from the Germans to the unit. All their jokes were about Jews, all the time they laughed, but they didn't touch me, they didn't ask me anything, I had no contact with them. Days passed and winter came. In the winter, HQ decided that we should establish ourselves in the villages in the area.

Interviewer [00:13:18]

You started to say that you went on an action.

Moshe Shutan [00:13:22]

Yes.

Interviewer [00:13:23]

What was the action?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:25]

There was an ambush.

Interviewer [00:13:27]

And what happened?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:32]

This time we did not encounter anyone, we waited all day and they didn't come, no Germans or collaborators came. But many times, they did come, and we would open fire, and since they always had more soldiers than us, and they drove machines, half-track vehicles, and their weapons were better than ours, we would shoot at them, and when we saw that they are starting to surround us from the sides, the flanks, we would retreat. But there were always victims [among the Germans]. There was an action where we attacked their outpost at night. They shot at us with machine guns. Since at night they cannot see us, they heard. So they aimed the machine guns ahead of time and thought the area dead. We crawled on our bellies and started throwing grenades and paralyzed the outpost and conquered it. This was the outpost that controlled all the area and took them out of there. I said that HQ decided we should be in the villages. We moved to being in the villages; they organized us, 3-4 partisans with the villagers, and what we did there was just guarding. Guarding during the day and also at night. And, nu, in the evening, the civilian population, there were lots of *Shiksehs* [non-Jewish women], they started having parties, playing the accordion, dancing, life changed. There's a difference between being in the forest, in the trenches, or living free in a house, seeing the lights of day. The space is greater, what you see, and the feeling is also one of more security. The officers decided with this that there will be partisan presence in the villages, in all the areas. In fact, all of White Belorussia was liberated. The Germans were just, they controlled only the big cities and some smaller ones, but the area all around the cities was controlled by the Partisans.

Interviewer [00:17:03]

You're talking about which period now?

Moshe Shutan [00:17:05]

This was '44, winter of '44. Spring was approaching. In May of '44, beginning of May – end of April they started talking about the Germans raising a blockade. For me this was something a little bit familiar already because I went through one blockade, now another blockade. But if the first one I went through, we were just thrown about, then this time I was in the unit. What the officers decided, that's what we did, I didn't have to think what to do. We were settled in the cemetery, on a hilltop, and the officers said we would meet the Germans there, and withdraw, but with a battle. One morning, around nine o'clock, each person took up position under a tombstone and we waited. Germans came out, with Polizei [Police] also. Why Polizei? Because we saw that they're walking in black coats. The Germans were in green coats and they were in black coats. They came out against us. The forest, we saw, was an open zone between the forest and the graveyard, about 800 meters, and on the left there was a small forest. When they came out, they came to about 500 meters away from us, and gave the order to fire. [We] shot at them with guns, machine guns, some of them fell, and they began to retreat. They retreated back to the forest, and there was a pause in the battle, silence. There was silence. I stood, I sat, I lay down in my position and watched, then I saw like this, if they entered the forest, on the left there is the little forest, they can flank and come to the little forest and the little forest goes behind us, and then they can surround us. I went to the commander, I told him, 'Look, the situation now is that they retreated, but we don't know what they will do. So there is such a possibility'. He looked, and said, 'You're right. We need to send into this little forest two people, and see that they don't approach on the left.' So he said, 'You will go, and take another one with you.' Why did I intervene in the course of this thing? I was afraid of one thing, deathly afraid. To fall alive into the Germans' hands. He assigned the partisan named Chushko, and we had to get past the open zone. We traversed by crawling, because they could have shot at us, and entered the little forest. We came closer, passed the forest – we had to get past it to the other side, it was maybe half a kilometer, and suddenly we hear a horse galloping. We sat on the ground past the trees and we saw a partisan on a horse. We stepped out, said – and he also stopped. 'Where are you going?' I told him, and then he said, 'You're crazy, you'll be taken captive by the Germans. Go back, I'm the last person between you and the Germans.' I said, 'We have an order, and we will fulfill it.' He looked at us and rode on. We came to the edge of this forest, and I said to Chushko: 'Look, you look to the right and I will look to the left.' OK. We carry on, it's quiet. I look, Chushko is lying some 10 meters from me. I look after a few more moments, and I don't see Chushko. I look back, and he's maybe 20 meters behind me. I said, 'What's up with you? You need to guard and you're lying behind me?' He didn't answer me, he was afraid. Suddenly we started hearing cannons and mortars in the direction of our

outpost, where the commander told us, 'You go there and stay there until I take you down.' When we started hearing the shots, then we heard the shots on the right, not from where we were, and the shots go deep, deep, on the right and soon they'll be right behind us and then I didn't know what to do, I could see that the shots are almost behind us, so I said to Chushko, 'Come on.' Eh, I look and Chushko's not there. He ran away and I was left on my own. I was on my own, the shots are almost behind me, I said, I'll go back to the cemetery outpost. So I traverse the forest again, again the open field, I get to the cemetery, I see no one. We were there for a few days, so the cook made a big pot like this, *Katzul*.

Interviewer [00:25:13]

A stew?

Moshe Shutan [00:25:14]

Where you cook a lot of food, how?

Interviewer [00:25:20]

A cauldron.

Moshe Shutan [00:25:21]

So I saw that there's nothing left, only a hole. A mortar hit there. Carriages – we had a few carriages, so they also left everything. I said, 'They went, where will I go? Where will I look for them?' Since I heard the shots on the right I said, 'They must be where the shots are. I will go there.' I went in the direction of the battle, got to the path, I'm walking along the path, there's an abyss, I see maybe 20 meters from the abyss, Commissar Yesinovich is sitting with a map, the Brigade commander and the commissar's adjutant, and three horses tied to trees next to them. I said, 'Nu, I found them.' But as I was saying, I found them, I hid. Why did I hide? If they see me, and they know that all the guys are in the battle, they can say, 'You ran away from the battle,' because they don't know the whole story. I ran away, I came closer to where the shots were, I started crawling, the bullets were whistling, I see figures among the trees, I saw that it was partisans, I came close, came to one who was in the front. I said to him – I knew him – I said, 'Where's the unit commander?' The unit commander sent me there. So he says, 'He's there, maybe 100 meters.' I crawled the 100 meters, reached the commander, he looked at me, 'Oy,' he says, 'I forgot to take you down. Where's the other one?' I said, 'I don't know, he ran away.' 'That's a lie', he says. 'You ran away and left him there alone.' I said, 'Look, why would I lie to you?' 'Go back there and bring him'. I said, 'What do you mean go back there and bring him? He's not there.' I said, 'If you insist that I go back, give me someone to witness that he's not there, since you don't

believe me.' He assigned me a guy. We went back to the cemetery. From the cemetery we needed to crawl back to the forest, so the other guy says to me, 'Listen, why should we take chances? I will say that we were there and that he was not there.' I said, 'No, you will go with me to the end.' So I walk up ahead and he walks behind me, maybe 100 meters. I started shouting so that he will hear me shouting. He says, 'You see he's not here. Let's say that he's gone.' We returned and he said to the commander, 'He already said that he's not there.' 'OK', he says, 'Lie down.' And we carried on with the battle until the order to retreat came. We retreated and arrived at a village maybe five kilometers from the place we were. There in the village we found Chushko. He ran straight to the village and that's it. They received him back, they didn't tell him anything. Now it started, since the battles, the Germans sent also The Germans sent also.... Airplanes. We started to retreat. We walk through forests, and the German bombers, they bombed us, and once it was absolutely terrible. They shot at us suddenly, they shot from machine guns and threw bombs so there was an order to enter the forest. We were on the way, between the trees, so many escaped as deep as possible. I ran maybe five meters from the road and took shelter under a tree. I look, and I don't like this tree, so I moved to another tree, and I hear that they're shouting to me. But no, I don't get it, I can't catch the words. It doesn't enter my head. Later I understood, it was in German. Then it entered my head and I understood what he was shouting at me [00:32:08, says a sentence in German, 00:32:09] and I looked, and maybe ten meters from me some guy is standing, also under the tree, he's not moving. After the bombardment stopped, I walked up to him, 'Who are you? What are you?' Turns out that four Germans deserted the German army and joined the partisans and he was one of them. This guy comes up to me, we had there maybe 80 killed and we were about 500 men, there were 80 killed and many wounded. One guy comes up to me and says, 'Mishka, have a look, they killed Karamanchok. I don't remember if I told you about Karamanchok, but when I was with him in the forest, then I ... we became good friends. I was young, he was 55. I loved his stories, his character. He baked bread in camp. So after the watch I would go to him, and he would share with me fresh, warm bread, and tell all kinds of stories. Among the stories he told me, he said, 'Look, I have a feeling I'm not going to make it through this war.' 'You're talking nonsense,' I say. 'Why would you have thoughts like that?' 'This is how I feel.' And he told me a story about a man who cannot escape his fate. And now that they told me, 'Here, go look, Karamanchok died,' my heart ached and I saw how strange, a man's road and life.

We carried on walking, we didn't even bury them. They told us that we're not far from the river Brasino. There were marshes there, and passage was difficult; those who had been travelling with horses from the start, left the horses and we walked on foot. We're walking, and suddenly we see opposite us also walking a big unit of partisans. So I hear their commander ask our commander, 'Where are you walking?' So he says to him, 'We're running away from the Germans. And where are you walking?' And he says, 'We're also running away from the Germans.' The strange thing here was that each carried on his own way. We reached Brasino, a big river, and it was difficult to cross it; but they found a spot with many logs, not tied to one another but one next to the other.

They were very slippery, and one had to be careful not to slide on them, and it happened that when we crossed the river on those logs then this guy slipped between two logs and went down, and he couldn't get out, because the trees joined and he stayed there. When we crossed the forest, German airplanes would come every time. So HQ saw that it was a difficult situation so they said, and we heard shots on the other side so they told us to go back. Go back, cross back across the river. Airplanes came, dropped bombs, and went, disappeared in the sky, then there was an order to cross the river quickly, we crossed. To reach the river there was a zone of terrible marshes, it's 200 meters on either side of the river, we barely got through it. When we returned to the other side of the forest –

Interviewer [00:37:56]

Of the river

Moshe Shutan [00:37:58]

Of the river, the commander tells us, 'Listen, the situation is unbearable and very difficult, we have to split up into small groups, split into small groups and each group exits the blockade on their own.' I stayed with the squad commander and five other partisans, there were seven of us. So they said, 'Let's go back.' We went back, met citizens, citizens who also had heard that there's a blockade and escaped from the Germans to the forest because they would burn them alive in their villages, these cases happened, so they were already afraid and escaped to the forest, whole families with children, with women. We met them and they're walking, not in our direction. In the meantime, the commander got sick, the squad commander was called Pietzka.

Interviewer [00:39:31]

What happened to him?

Moshe Shutan [00:39:33]

He got sick, he got a high fever and said he doesn't have the strength to walk. So among the citizens he found an uncle with his family. Nu, I said, 'What can one do, if the guy is sick? How can we help him? So he will be with the family and we partisans will go.' So I was left with the five partisans. There was a Belorussian among them, two Russians, one Ukrainian and one Pole. On the way we met, suddenly one guy walks up, says to us, 'I just now escaped from the Germans, they caught me and I escaped, I managed to escape.' And he tells us that they're coming closer so they shoot, and three lines come up, first line takes captives, second line of Germans, depends how they're

feeling, either they kill those they capture or they take them captive, and their third line kills. So he said, I was caught by the first line and they led them, so he ran away between the trees. We passed the night there, he was with us. In the morning, we heard gunshots, paf, paf, paf, Not at a rapid pace but here a shot, there a shot, but on all sides. So he says, 'Here they are, they're coming.' As soon as I heard the shots, he said 'Here they are' and he ran, in a different direction. We stayed, we stayed, what to do. So all five said like this, 'We... will surrender to the Germans.' So for me this was a blow. I said, 'I do not surrender to the Germans.' 'Don't be afraid,' they tell me, 'we won't tell that you're a Jew, they won't do anything to us.' They threw down, the Germans, also pamphlets, so in the pamphlets it was written that whomever surrenders is kept captive, so they just send him to work in Germany. And for me this was all just stories. I told him. So they say, 'We won't say 'partisans', we'll throw away the guns,' and that's it. So I sit, the gun I don't want to throw away. So they say, 'If you don't throw the gun away you betray us as partisans, so go away from us. Go wherever you like, but leave us.' So I left them and walked off maybe 200 meters, I sat down, I was on my own in an unknown situation, in the marshes, they're shooting all around, I hear it. I said, 'If this is to be my end, then I will die with everyone together. But not, not surrender to the Germans alive, that I won't do.' I buried the gun, I had a grenade. I said 'I'll blow myself up in the worst case and then we're done.' So they didn't see I had a grenade in my pocket, so they said, 'You came back, don't be afraid, it will be OK.' We heard shots again, and we started walking in another direction. We started walking again and we met up with Pietzka again, with his family, with more civilians, so he looks at me and says, 'Where's your gun?' So I told him. 'And where are they?' I said, 'Here they are over there.' So he says, 'It's a bad business, you didn't do right.' And he had a gun, he was sick, he had a gun. Suddenly we heard shots next to us, maybe 100 meters, so everyone started running away, then these five partisans started running in the opposite direction from the shots. So the child of Pietzka's relative, a kid about 10, 11, started running after the partisans. So his dad is shouting, 'Where are you running to?' So he shouts to him, 'I want to go with the partisans, be with the partisans.' I also shouted to him, 'Don't go with them.' They ran off, In the mess there, in the turmoil, so they ran off. We were left standing, so Pietzka asks his uncle, where shall we go? He stood like this, he was fifty, he said, 'We will walk like this, not opposite to the shooting but parallel to the shooting.' We walked with them, since Pietzka had a hard time walking I took his gun, I said 'I will hold your gun.' OK, he agreed. After a few minutes, the direction they ran to, we heard shots and shouts and then quiet. And we kept walking. And these five partisans with the relative's son, they were killed there. We walked for an hour or two and suddenly shots all round and shouts, so everyone get scared and the uncle, Pietzka's uncle, he says 'We need to scatter and look for shelter under trees or in the marshes,' and he ran and I was left with Pietzka and Pietzka is barely walking. So I dragged him under a tree, a big tree. And there was a fallen tree there, so they couldn't see well, it hid us well. When we heard the shots and shouts I said to Pietzka, 'Let's get in the marsh, we will hide up to our mouths.' So he says OK. He's barely moving, so I push him in this marsh, in the water, as he enters up to his knees he starts shouting 'Get me out!' and

his face goes completely pale, really white. I took him out, and say to him, 'Pietzka, it's only for a few minutes, I don't know how long, maybe five minutes, ten minutes, they will pass and we're done.' He says, 'I can't.' So I said to him, 'So I will go in on my own.' As soon as I push myself into the mud, it was mud and water, I went in as far as my belt, I felt a stream of cold from my feet straight to my heart, and I felt my heart stop. I got out of there quickly. Later I understood why he couldn't be there, it was the beginning of the water and the water in the marshes were still like frozen. So he says, 'What shall we do?' So I say, 'here, under this tree that fell and that's it,' we lay under the tree and wait. It was already evening. Around noon rain started falling and this rain, these drips were constant, then it got stronger. And while I'm talking, when we were under the tree, it was already raining heavily. Suddenly I hear talk. Talk, and I can't see, it was difficult for me to see. I opened up the branch a little bit, and 20 meters from us some Germans were gathered and they're talking. They look here, they look there, they talk, what do I know what they talk about, finally they skedaddle. The shots died down and that's how the day ended. At night we were awfully cold, I lay next to him, by Pietzka, we warmed each other. In the morning we got up, the sun came out, we got out from under the tree, we warmed up a little bit. And we said, 'If they went past we'll return to the usual.' All right. We start walking. I carried him, he could barely walk. We walk, and suddenly we hear shouts of a Russian woman, 'My son, my son, where are you?' She lost her mind, from all the situation that she had been through, she lost her mind. She comes next to us, we said to her, 'Why are you shouting "My son"?' She says, 'I left my son here yesterday, he's five years old, and I can't find the place and I'm losing my mind.' We said, 'Where will you look for him? Come with us.' 'No, I must find him.' And she ran onwards shouting, 'my son, my son, my son.' We went, we passed maybe a kilometer. Suddenly I see a kid under a tree, with his head towards the earth. I thought he was killed. I come closer to him, I turned his head, he opens his eyes, I see he's alive. 'What are you doing here?' He says to me, 'Mama left me here, and said that I shouldn't move from here, she will come pick me up.' I said, 'Come with us.' 'No, no, I won't go,' he says. A five-year-old child. And he didn't go. I couldn't carry him because I had Pietzka, so he said, 'We can't do anything, let's go.' And we left the child. If she had come with us, she would have met him. I don't know what happened to them. We were already close, we were maybe a kilometer, more than a kilometer from the base where we were before, with the civilians, before we started running. Pietzka sat down and said, 'I can't walk anymore.' 'What happened? Just a little bit...' 'No, I can't, kill me.' I thought, 'What shall I do? If I sit here with him in the marshes it's... it's not... It's no good, it's not a solution.' I said, 'You know what, I will go to the outpost, and there, if I find people, I will ask them that someone comes with me and takes you.' He said, 'Good, go.' I went. I came to the outpost and I saw his uncle, I come to the uncle, he's sitting by a campfire with more people and they're saying that the blockade may be past. I told him that Pietzka is here, not far away, and that we need to go fetch him, then he says to me 'I'm not going.' I looked, I thought, 'What is this, what does it mean he's not going, to leave a sick man alone?' So he says, 'Why? How can you behave like this?' His feet were in rags, so he took off the foot rags and all his toes were without skin, flesh. I was

frightened at this sight. 'Now you know why I'm not going?' He says, 'I can't walk.' So I came back on my own, I ran into Pietzka, he sat and then he regained his strength, and slowly, slowly we would walk, 100 meters, then another 100 meters, and so we reached the base. There he lay under a tree, he didn't want to eat, he didn't want water, he didn't want anything. He lay there, he was completely pale, white, we sat there. The night passed, the night passed, and in the morning he says 'Water,' he wants water. I gave him a little water on the lips, because the truth is there wasn't water; I – when I wanted to drink I took off my hat and put it in the mash and water entered the hat so that it's without earth. So what entered the hat is what I drank. And what I drank was also with mud. They cooked also some greens they found, herbs like this from the forest, and ate it and gave me to eat also, because bread, food there was none. They gave us before we scattered, before the blockade began, they gave each of us five kg flour, but in the marshes, we carried it through the marshes so it all became one lump of water, it was hard, you couldn't even eat this flour. So we ate herb soup, what they did, in these waters. In the morning he asked for water, I gave him some on his lips, I spread a little water, a little to drink, and around noon he regained his strength. That night he went through the crisis, he had typhoid fever. He had typhoid fever. We lay there maybe five days. And he regained his strength and said, 'Let's go back to the partisan base.' We went. One night we went past, we had to go through a dirt track, and we hear carriages, machines, talking. When we came up, we looked down on the road and I saw Germans retreating, many, thousands. We waited until they went past and then we went and we reached the base, there the first one I met was the HQ commander, of my brigade. 'You're alive,' he says. He says, 'You see' – looking at me – 'Where's your gun?' I told him the story. He pats me on the shoulders, says, 'Never mind, the main thing is that you're alive, we'll give you another gun,' and they gave me another gun. They already started partisan actions behind the lines of the Germans, those who were blockading. Everyone told how I met up with the guys, everyone told his story, how he got past the blockade, they said that even a whole brigade went past without, with no shooting. Some people wanted the blockade to pass, to break the blockade, so at night there were five hundred partisans with automatic weapons, with machine guns, going out to battle calling *Urra*. But the Germans before nightfall, set up their machine guns with mortars that almost killed everyone, and they didn't succeed. In one such attack one guy, Pokovnik Radionov, was killed, he from the start fought, he went over to the Germans, fought with them. Then with his unit he went in '43 back over to the partisans. They didn't do anything to him

Interviewer [01:00:00]

The tape is finished.

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Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 11 – Transcript

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Moshe Shutan [00:00:25]

It's already ten hours, it will end up being ten and a half, it will end up fourteen, eleven hours, enough?

[00:00:36]

No, no, not yet.

Moshe Shutan [00:00:42]

He's gone to get me tea.

[00:00:46]

No, wait a minute, wait, wait.

Moshe Shutan [00:01:03]

We were on the base and some of the partisans were sent into actions and I was there. Pietzka meanwhile recuperated a little, and our feeling after the blockade was very rough, because we lost a lot of people; there were many injured. But the war goes on and you can do nothing except fulfill the job that has been given you. After a few days, this was on the 15th of May, one partisan comes and says to me, Mishka, do you know? There's a Red Army convoy, in our unit's HQ. We go over there, and then the Red Army Captain comes out with two more soldiers. They looked at us, we looked at them, as if the Messiah had come. And we were there in the tents, we said, there, the Red Army is soon going to enter after the patrol, and we'll be done with the partisan business. In the twilight, three half-track vehicles entered the base, and the commander spoke a little with our commanders and then they headed back out. We were outside, looking at them, we asked, we exchanged words. Then the commander says to me, The HQ commander asks me, Moshe, Mishka, do you know the way to Pleshchenitsy? I said, Yes. Then climb aboard the half-tracks and you show them the way. OK, I climb aboard one of the half-tracks where the commander of the half-tracks was, and an hour later we were on our way. I led them through the forest paths, it was very difficult to pass, they drove slowly, slowly, almost as if you were walking fast, not faster than that. We drove all night. We reached a A road thingy A fork. It's a fork. So the commander wants to take a right. I said no, we have to go straight. He stops everyone, says, why straight, here I have the map, and shows on the map that we need to go right. I said, No, you will enter a cul-de-sac. We should go straight, then this road slowly turns right. He heard

me. We carried on, and just before dawn, with the first dew, when the light starts, we reached the edge of the forest. Before us was a field, and a kilometer from the field was the road leading to Pleshchenitsy. And we see on the road lots of carriages with Germans with machines, and they're walking slowly, they were thousands there and they were retreating. The commander gave an order to move forwards, and the three half-tracks spread out and started driving rapidly towards the road while shooting, they had a small cannon and machine guns. In my half-track there were five soldiers – four soldiers, the commander, and myself as the sixth. I look at what my eyes see, here, for the first time I see in front of me the real German Army, not those who fought against the partisans, but really an army. They started shooting at us with machine guns, but we advanced so quickly that they saw it's their end and then started to run, they threw everything down and started running. When I looked at that, for me it was... the world changed completely, overturned. I, who was a Jewish youth in the Ghetto and saw all that the Germans did to the Jews. And here I see the wheel turning and they're running away, soldiers with weapons. So I said, so, in combat they're not such heroes. Against Jews who had nothing they were heroes, and here on the battlefield it's not so much like... as it is. So I didn't shoot and they all shot, and suddenly the commander pokes me, Partisan, why are you not shooting? So I stepped out of my dream – because for me it was a dream – and started shooting also. We climbed onto the road, they scattered all the Germans. And then I remembered at the beginning of the war, when two Germans ran after a hundred Russians. One hundred Russians running away from two Germans. And here I saw thousands, thousands of Germans running away from three half-tracks. We climbed onto the road, and he said to drive to the town Pleshchenitsy, this was the district where our brigade was. He said that we need to be ready for battle because they didn't tell us if they are defending Pleshchenitsy, the town, or not. In the end, when we entered the outskirts of the town it was quiet. He said forward, we entered, we met civilians and they said that the Germans have all run away. He said to me, you finished your mission, you can go back to your unit to the partisans. We said goodbye to each other and separated, and I went back to the base. I reached the base the next day, but on the way I already met units of the Red Army, there was a unit driving with cannons, trucks with mortars and cannons. And the soldiers on top sat down to eat. They sat down to eat, the commander tells them, we're just going to rest half an hour and we advance. So the soldiers sat, look, we've advanced so many kilometers, we're already tired, we need to rest a few hours. So he says to them, Listen, we've got our army ahead of us, face to face with the Germans. Maybe they need artillery assistance, and we will sit here? Let's advance, he says, ten more kilometers. Then one soldier tells me that he's been like this already for dozens of kilometers, he's dragging us along like this, ten times since yesterday he's said... and suddenly there's an attack by German airplanes. I lay by the side of the road, all of the soldiers lay by the side of the road, and one mortar hit the car, next to the car, and it went up in flames. So the commander gave an order to the soldiers to take down all the boxes with the mortars. I looked, the machine is on fire, the mortars could all blow up. First of all they released the cannon, they released it from the car and set it aside, then they started removing boxes, and suddenly they

started blowing up, so they ran away. They ran, lay down on the road, and the car was burnt and everything blew up, we sat down. In war, not everything goes smoothly. Even when you advance there are victims. I met a unit walking on foot, suddenly a full machine drives by with soldiers, with ammunition and soldiers. So the pedestrians – they were a unit of maybe 50 guys – so one of them goes up to the truck driver and says, Where are you going? He says, We're advancing to the front. What are you carrying? Supplies. You get down, he says, and we will drive. I look at how this works, one gives an order to the other, one intervenes with the other. So this guy says, We're going into battle, and you're not. So we need to be not tired. And they got down, and then they sat down and drove. So when I talked to this guy I said, Where are you advancing. [He asked] Where are you from? I tell him, from around Vilna [Vilnius]. Oh, Vilna, he says, we're going there, this is where we're going, we need to be there by the 5th of July. Later I found out that on the 5th of July they encircled Vilna, but I believe that they took Vilna on July 13th. When I came back to the base, they told me that we have to go to the city of Minsk because Minsk is already liberated and that's where all the partisans are gathering. It took us a few days, we arrived next to Minsk and rested by the city in the forest, in a grove by the city. The cook said that he needs to prepare food, and the commander of the platoon comes to me and says, Fetch two pails of water. OK, I took the two pails, I went, after five minutes I feel my head spinning, I can't walk. So I barely came back, I came back, he says, You got the water so quickly? I said, I didn't fetch it. What happened? I don't feel well. There was a nurse, she took my temperature, I had 40 [Celsius]. She says, To the hospital. So two partisans accompany me to the city of Minsk, where there was already a Red Army hospital, and the doctor diagnosed typhoid fever, I got the typhoid from Pietzka. After I was in hospital – we were more than a month, about a month I was in hospital and about 18 days after the illness they left me so as not to contaminate others, so that we can prevent giving it to others. They passed me on to the Red Army. This army unit was rear-guard and we focused on the city of Minsk. Actually, if I spoke about the partisan business, so by the time I got to the Red Army – so this is my whole story about the partisans, how I went through it from beginning to end.

I want to note one more thing, because it appears to me important. When we were still in the forest, in 1944, there was a connection with the 'Big Earth', that's how they called it in "Leshe Zimla", the partisans, the other side of the hinterland, of the front, they called it the Big Earth. So airplanes would come with weapons, with newspapers, and they would take back the wounded, one could say there was already normal communication. So among other things, the commanders, Commissar Capitonov, when we would gather in the forest by a bonfire or whatever, as soon as they brought newspapers, he would go, Guys, we will now read what's in the paper, see the news. So we would sit down, 40-50 partisans, and himself in the middle, and he would pick up the newspaper. The first thing – this was Pravda newspaper, the first thing he would open the first page and Stalin's Daily Order is written there. He would go over it, he would start looking through the newspaper, until he reaches a page, he says, Now we will read Stalin, not a chapter, an essay, not an report, a news-story. Now Ilya

Ehrenburg's story. I heard Ilya Ehrenburg,¹¹⁵ even when we were in the Ghetto, we heard, whenever a German newspaper fell into our hands, the Völkischer Beobachter, they would mention Ilya Ehrenburg. Why? Because if we're talking about spiritual weapons, he was the most devastating weapon. And after the commissar would read us his report, it created in us exalted spirits, everyone listened quietly and everyone saw why we need to fight against the Germans and the fascists. I later thought that it forged the ranks of the partisans, I don't know what went on in other units, but where I was. Then I saw an exaltation and a willingness for self-sacrifice. So I saw that if Stalin was the commander of the forces of the Red Army in the fight against the Germans, then I saw in Ilya Ehrenburg, he was its soul. He was the soul of the struggle of the Russian people, of the Soviets, against the Germans. Because no journalist, not even the best, reached his stature, and for me it was comforting that he was Jewish and he wrote, in all his reports he mentioned Jews. He also said, he wrote that since the war of the Germans against the Jews is the most cruel, then we Jews need to be in the first line in fighting them. When I finished the partisan business and was free, I started to think about friends, acquaintances, who's alive, looking for one another. I didn't have that opportunity, because I was in the army, I had no contact. Later I wrote a letter to my town, and once when I was in the unit, they tell me, you have a guest, and a sister of mine came. She came to visit me. So I knew that she had stayed alive. She told me all that they had gone through in Narocz. They had no blockade since the first one. It was a very moving meeting. She and I survived, the only ones of the entire family, and then I met a friend in Minsk, I was with him in the partisans when I left with him from Vilna Ghetto, Patshenikov, Avrasha Patshenik. I remembered all my friends that I went through the period with them, like Tevka Bromberg, Berka Yochai, they each have their own story. And this is actually how I want to end the story of what I went through, from the start of the war until the Red Army entered the partisan area and freed those regions. That's it.

Interviewer [00:24:21]

I want to ask you a question. You said earlier, during the blockade

Moshe Shutan [00:24:26]

Yes, I please. No matter, ask, ask.

Interviewer [00:24:31]

Ilya Ehrenberg (1891-1967) was a prominent Soviet Jewish journalist and writer who became one of¹¹⁵ the most influential war correspondents of World War II, known for fierce anti-Nazi propaganda articles that helped galvanize Soviet resistance. He later co-edited "The Black Book" documenting Nazi crimes against Jews in the Soviet Union.

No, carry on, I will remember the question.

Moshe Shutan [00:24:33]

No, no, I, about my conversation with, with Bogen, what my teacher said about the Germans, I will talk about that in the last recording, not now. I need to prepare for that.

Interviewer [00:24:58]

OK, so I want to ask you a question. You said that during the blockade you saw, you met a mother looking for her son, and about a kilometer later you met the son, and you carried on walking. Actually, why did you not do anything to bring them together?

Moshe Shutan [00:25:25]

It's like you're in a jungle, it's like looking in a pile in a carriage of hay, it was impossible. Look, we're now reading things where hundreds of policemen are looking for someone missing in a built area. In an unbuilt area, not swamps and such, and sometimes they're looking for three days even! And there, what option did we have? Pietzka was barely moving, he himself was barely walking and I was dragging him along. To leave him – it wasn't in my head that I would leave him. It's a very sad case, and it's what can happen in a war. Say if today I would go through something like that, I would have dragged him by force, but then I didn't do it. I think about it not, more than once. A man doesn't always do what he should do. There are moments where his thought is with himself, he's with what's closest, maybe a bit further. Sometimes in these situation you don't see. Today I see it more sharply, I understand it more and more, that's why I told this sad story. It's like the story I told of the two brothers, when we left from Świąteczny Ghetto to the forest and they asked us to go out and I told them, No, because the decision was that we take no one, and a few weeks later they were killed, they were killed in Ponary while running away, they ran away but they were shot and killed. It's the same sad story. In life it doesn't always work the way it should. I don't know, maybe you need a special impetus for it, but the situation is so, the situations are so tense that sometimes it is difficult to think all the way to the end, then you see the product. There are sometimes, for instance, things I went through and what I did, I did. But decades later I understood what I did. There were subconscious actions, how do you say, sub-conscious? Yes. Because we actually did not have time to sit, to think, I don't know how in the HQ the officers were, but we were nearly all the time tense, and if there were changes of a shift from sitting in the base and going into action, we didn't set the time we didn't set the action, the moment they put us in they said, Nu, now we leave, tomorrow we leave. So each person – I don't know, I won't talk of each person. So you, naturally I would enter a little bit stressed. I wasn't afraid, but the tension was there. The tension before action. And in situations of stress it's hard to think, you need

special nerves for that. Usually I wasn't in a debate in these situations with others, they didn't ask my opinion, I wasn't an officer, I wasn't a commander, I was a simple partisan soldier. Only in the period where there was Vilna Ghetto and we left for the partisans, we acted independently, so we thought, how and what. But yes, to say that we did everything all the way to the end – today I would do it – even if in the same way, many things I would do differently.

Interviewer [00:31:29]

Like what?

Moshe Shutan [00:31:30]

Saving the Jews from the ghetto. I shouldn't have listened, if the FPO refused to go to the forest, I should have organized with more people, we will bring them into the business to expand these actions, I only did what I myself could do. There were results, but it was possible to do a lot more. It was not a normal situation and time, it was cruel, We did indeed fight against the Germans but we Jews lost the war. Because the Jewish people paid in many victims during the Second World War and we call it Holocaust. For us it was not a victory. I hope the world changes and becomes better. That's it.

Interviewer [00:34:12]

When you were liberated, when you met the Red Army and there was liberty suddenly, what did you think? You described it all factually, but....

Moshe Shutan [00:34:29]

If there were... If there were people, not as far as I'm concerned, as far as I'm concerned the Germans lost the war by beginning it; but if there were people who had doubts, but when you saw the fall of the German army, how they retreated, then the Russian offensive was from Vitebsk and they got to Warsaw, that's a distance of more than 600 kilometers, so you could say that this general doubt no longer existed, because everyone saw that it's the end of the German, the end of their army, that they lost the war. It's true, at the same period the Americans with the English and French had the second front, we saw that Germany lost and it gave us a sense of relief, that in any case the victory – it maybe wasn't for everyone, I said that we Jews lost the war, but those who remained at any rate, they could breath free, because this was what they dreamed it would be; those that remained, it gave them encouragement and hope for a new life.

Interviewer [00:36:50]

When the moment of liberation came, did you have any plans going through your head?

Moshe Shutan [00:37:07]

With the liberation, with the arrival of the German – Russian army, I thought that I would continue the fighting. It so happened that I was in a rear-guard unit. But here's the thing: When I was in the army, they sent us once to Bialystok. Bialystok belonged to Poland, and I heard already that Jews were leaving the places, that [they were leaving] from this zone where they went through so much on their way to Eretz Israel, that a lot of Jews escaped the army and by hook and by crook they went to Germany and from there looked for ways to get to Israel. There were some also who left for the US, for other countries, but the majority came to the conclusion that for the Jews there is only one place in the world and that is Israel. So when I came then to Bialystok, I walked in the city, I met with Jews, I went to synagogue to see Jews.

Interviewer [00:38:51]

When was this?

Moshe Shutan [00:38:53]

It was in '45. The war was already over and I met with Jews there. We talked, and they said to me like this, Listen, you're a soldier? What do you need the Red Army for? Why should you serve? You're a Jew? Throw away your uniform, we'll burn them, we'll give you civilian clothes and you will go from Poland, you'll go further, you can go where you want but don't stay in the Red Army because [then] you have no opportunity to go to Israel, you have no opportunity to go elsewhere, but they usually talked about Israel. The suggestion was, how do you say, tempting. But I decided I would not be a deserter from an army that had such a big part in the victory over Germany, I would not betray it. I did not accept the proposal to desert, I stayed to serve, I served until the liberation, until they liberated me. There's a story that I, as someone who was born in Poland, I could leave Russia and go to Poland and from there the way onwards was free. I was indeed in the Polish Embassy in Moscow, I served in Moscow a year and a half. I was at the Polish Embassy and they told me even though I'm a soldier, I can go according to the agreement they have with the Russians. And they told me they would send to my unit the documents. I waited, after two weeks they said you will receive the documents. I waited more than two weeks, I didn't get them. I didn't get the documents. Suddenly.... During this time I was in training, and during training they told me and three others to present ourselves at the unit, at the base in Moscow. I got there, I got to the base, I see hundreds of soldiers. Where are you going? To the Far East. All three guys who travelled with me, called, we were four who came, so they told them that they also are going to the Far East, So I thought for sure this is because I presented a request to travel

to Poland, so they're sending me to the Far East so that I will forget all this story. I had once a meeting with the second-in-command of the NKVD in Moscow. The unit where I was serving, it was an NKVD unit. It was a chemical-engineering unit. And he once called me, after I presented the request, he must have found out, apparently the Poles sent from the Embassy sent the papers and it got stuck on his desk. So he called me to come. So when I came to him he says, Listen, What do you need Poland for, we'll send you to study. I said how can I study as a soldier? He said, What do you care, we'll give you this time. Why did he choose me to study? I can only say that I would sit there for whole nights and read books; everyone would go to sleep and I would read books until 2, 3 in the morning. In the forest, one had to sleep from 11 till 6. So at 11 I would enter the library, take books, and read until the morning. And the duty officer didn't leave me. He would open the door, how come there's a light in the library, see me, and he would do like this with the hand and leave me. Anyway, I got up like everyone else at six and did all the exercises and all the workouts, everything. So maybe someone told him that I'm like this, so he wanted to send me to study. I said.... I went to study a few weeks, I learned in a night high school, it didn't work with my head. My head was full of everything we went through, and the stuff we went through didn't give me any peace, and I thought only one thing, that the Jewish people, like all people have a state so the Jewish people deserve a state. And I talked to him, I said, What do you think? That I want to go to Poland? I have nothing I need from the Poles, if I go, I go to Palestine. He looks at me, doesn't say anything to me. So when I came to the unit, to the base, and I see they're sending everyone to the Far East, I went to him and said, You see, it's because I want to go that they're sending me to the Far East. He says, wait, wait, I will look into it. So then he asks, he picks up a phone. I say, Are you calling the unit? But I left it without permission. I will be arrested. He says, Don't worry, don't worry, it will be OK, and he calls. So they look for me in the list of those going to the Far East, then he says to me, Why do you say you're going to the Far East? You're not on the list, you're not going. I said, We're four guys who got called up from training, and I'm among them, they're all going and I'm not? He says, You see that you're not. So why was I called up? He says, I called you up. And he starts up again, that I should stay, that I should not leave the USSR, that the USSR did a lot for the Jews, and Poland has nothing for me, and Palestine also has nothing for me. He says, We will take care of you, you'll study, be among people. I refused. So he says to me, in the end, you know, what with all the procedure of the documents, we can't release you. I said, Why? So he says to me, because the law that applies to the army does not apply to the NKVD army. It's a completely different law, we receive different orders. So he says to me, So I said to him, This can't be. So he says, If I tell you, you can believe me. I don't have to tell you, but you can believe me. Anyway he says, I will help you be liberated from the army. Were you ever sick? I said No. What, never? I said, I was once, fever, I had typhoid, then I had dysentery after the partisan business. OK, all right, I will send you to a medical committee and we will see. And he calls, and in walks a Major. Doctor, he says to this Major, examine his health status and we will see what his status is and then we will decide what to do with him, and you – he says – go back to your unit, don't be afraid,

nothing will happen to you. I went back, I went back and after a few days I meet Capitonova, the doctor of the unit. And she says to me, What? What ties do you have with Major Landebrov? The doctor, his name was, he was Major Landebrov. I said, I have no ties. According to what he said to me, She says, he wants to release you from the army. And they did release me. And this Palkovnik, the NKVD second-in-command in Moscow, he told me you're now released and you can go wherever you want, and I set out with the goal of getting to Israel.

Interviewer [00:50:50]

Tell me you didn't have After liberation, yes, you didn't have the wish to take revenge on the German?

Moshe Shutan [00:51:27]

No. If there were people who were guilty, in the killing of the Germans, I saw their defeat, I saw in it the victory and the revenge and it certainly satisfied me, for me it was satisfying. I don't know what I think, because to this day some people talk about how they should be punished. I don't say that a criminal shouldn't be punished, but there's a saying in Russian [speaks in Russian] After the brawl you don't wave your hands. If it was necessary, right, if there was a need to take revenge, it was the fighting against them. This in my eyes is the sublime revenge, and those who fought did their part. I wrote the book, and you must have read the book *Ghetto and Woods*,¹¹⁶ and you read there about Berl Yohai who went into action, if you remember, and he found a two Jews, a married couple with a kid. He told them that a time would come that the Germans would live like you do here, like you are here, like.... Like mice [in English] Like mice, and they will hide and not say their names, and who they are, and what they are, and they will tell lies to their kids and they will live a lie. A person who has to change his name, who has to hide, who hides this cruel past. I don't see in him a man, but a mouse, like some of the Jews were when they were hiding. And these people, if they should be put on trial or not, a man should be put on trial, but these – there's nothing to judge. It won't bring us back the victims. And I told you that for me, revenge was the biggest, fighting and victory over Germany, because millions dreamt of the victory over Germany all the years of this cruel war. And they got it. And for me it's enough. If we're talking about years of Jews, of humanity, I don't see the Germans today as a danger to the Jews. Our biggest enemy today are the Arab states, Palestinians and not Germans. If there are now phenomena that are reminiscent of the days before Hitler came to power, I don't believe that Hitler can rise in Germany again, I don't see it realistically, Fascism- maybe, but not... Hitler with the German fascism, like it was. I see it as a singular thing that happened in history, if there is today even cruelty in the world, and

Moshe Shutan, *Ghetto and Woods* (Tel Aviv: Committee for the Commemoration of Jewish Fighting ¹¹⁶ in World War II, 1985).

terrible cruelty is... people are the same people. For instance, they talked of the revolution in Russia. So I asked myself, they did the revolution, and everyone was for communism, everyone was for socialism. But later I asked myself, before the Russian revolution, the character of the Russian people was different, and after the revolution, the next day, is it already a different character? But the lesson of the Second World War was learned by the French, by the English, by the Armoricans – they gave a lot of victims. I don't believe, just like we say that we won't forget the Holocaust, I don't believe they will forget the victims they gave. So I don't believe that what was could come back, in the same form, I don't believe. One horrific thing is that for instance there was the Gulf War and the Iraqis sent out rockets against us, so it is true that in the army they say it was a "scattering", even though it wasn't. But the whole world was silent, and no one said that a man like Saddam Hussein, if he sends rockets against the civilian population, against women and youth and children, a man like that should be put on trial and be declared a war criminal, they didn't do it, and it's very dismaying. I was in the US, in California, in Los Angeles. I went with a friend of my daughter, a lawyer, so he says to me, Moshe, let's go into the Wiesenthal Institute, of Shimon Wiesenthal.¹¹⁷ You asked me about revenge. Shimon Wiesenthal to this day deals with the issue of the Germans who sinned, if we can say it like that, with these murderers. And he wants to put them on trial. I don't think he does it for revenge but for justice. To do justice. So I spoke to the lawyer I was with, so he said to me, he asked my opinion. I said to him, revenge is necessary, He says, so I say revenge, yes. So he says, But they must be put on trial if there is to be justice. I said to him, the world is not conducted by justice, but by interests. And if we today, we stand in a trial against Demianiuk, he's Ukrainian, we know how the Ukrainians behaved...

Moshe Shutan – Testimony – tape 12 – Transcript

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Interviewer [00:01:10]:

Go ahead, please.

Moshe Shutan [00:01:17]:

In the previous recording I talked about the blockade, and how I was with my unit commander [00:01:25] Pietzka [00:01:26], we were only the two of us, and I told how we hid behind a fallen tree. I saw the Germans gather about 20 meters from us, and one thing was clear to me, that I would not fall into their hands alive. I had a grenade, I

The Wiesenthal Institute, named after Nazi hunter Simon Wiesenthal, was dedicated to tracking down ¹¹⁷ Nazi war criminals and pursuing justice for Holocaust crimes.

pulled out the pin and waited. So he looks and says, What? So you would kill me too? I said, So back off. So he says, Nu, whatever. Luckily, they talked, and it was raining heavily, and they left the place and so we stayed all night. The next day we got back, we walked towards the base from which we left, and I told how on the way we met a woman who was looking for her kid. She didn't walk with us, and later we met the kid and he didn't want to go with us, I stayed with him and I went with Pietzka, I barely carried him, and I told how I came to the base, and there was his uncle, the citizens who were in the forest, and I asked him to come [00:03:05] help me bring Pietzka [00:03:07] because he couldn't carry on, he stayed maybe 1.5 kilometers from the base. So he didn't want to go, and I asked him why, so he showed me his legs and his toes were without skin, all red, you could see only flesh. I went back and brought him. After I went, I also sat by the fire to rest, and I took off my shoes with the rags in which they were wrapped. When I walked, it burned between my toes, and now that I took off my shoes with the rags I saw that I also had no skin on the toes. To tell the truth, we were in filth. Two weeks we didn't eat anything. We only drank a little water and that was mud water. And how it healed afterwards with nothing – I find that hard to grasp, doctors should think about it, how it passed with no infection, nothing.

Now I will talk about the conversation with Bogen. I mentioned Alexander Bogen. When I was still in the ghetto and we talked about the situation, it was obvious that I, he, we also know

Interviewer [00:05:13]:

Which ghetto are you talking about?

Moshe Shutan [00:05:14]:

Vilna Ghetto. So it was obvious that the war would end in our favor, but since the war carried on and the persecutions against the Jews were cruel, He said that it's good if - that every Jew who leaves the ghetto and gets to the forest, that's good. And if we're talking about fighting, he said that one partisan does more for victory against the Germans than all the 20 thousand who sit inside the ghetto. Then later in the forest I had a conversation with him after all the....it wasn't You couldn't say persecution, but all the humiliation, all the cruel behavior that was against the Jews who came from Vilna. And I sat with him and talked and we saw the behavior of the Russian commanders, so he said to me, You know, they are showing us the way to Palestine. And I told of a case that I saw and it was, how would you say, [00:06:42] *barzeikt*(?). It affected me [00:06:47], that I would change my whole opinion, and the meaning was that the Jews need their own state, because – that Zionism was correct. Now I will speak, that was more or less the conversation with Bogen. Now in the forest where we were, some FPO Vilna people came, and among them I met one called Moyshe Brauze. He asked me, I asked him. He was a member of FPO, and he came with his wife to the

forest. And apart from being a member of FPO, he also served in the Jewish police in the ghetto with the rank of a Sergeant Major. We talked of Gens, we talked of Desler – he knew I was from Święciany and that all the Jews of Święciany from the ghetto, that they took them, that the Jewish police took them on Gens's order, it was obvious that the order was from the Germans to transfer the Jews to Kovna. So he told me, Look, he says, Gens promised the Święciany people that he would go with them to Kovna because they didn't believe him. So me and five other policemen with Gens, we came to the train station in order to travel to Kovna. Then Weiss comes – Gestapo, a German officer, Weiss¹¹⁸ – and he says, You're not going. And Gens saw that they're taking the Jews to the train tracks, where all the railroad cars are, and that's the road to Ponar. So he says to Weiss, You cheated me, so he laughs at him. So Gens takes out a pistol and says, If you don't free, if you don't follow the order according to what you said, I kill you, I shoot you. So Weiss says, If you kill me, you will not only exterminate these people here, but also exterminate the 20 thousand Jews living in your ghetto. Gens was in distress, he said, he stood little, silent, and then said to Weiss, At least, those that you said are going to Vilna, at least these ones, let go, if not I kill you. And Weiss agreed.

Interviewer [00:10:37]:

Who can testify to that?

Moshe Shutan [00:10:40]:

Moyshe Brauze. And they released these people and they got to Vilna Ghetto, about 2000 people. Moyshe Brauze told me this, and he said that he himself was there with him, with the group of policemen. After they released the people and Gens lowered the pistol, Weiss gave an order to arrest him, and they arrested everyone, including Gens and the rest.

Interviewer [00:11:21]:

Of the Jewish Police?

Moshe Shutan [00:11:23]

Yes, and they took them to Lokishki, which was a jail in Vilna, a well-known jail,¹¹⁹ and they put them in a cell, no beds, no nothing. The floor was cement. All night, he

This is the notorious Nazi commander Martin Weiss, on whom see Christina Ullrich, "Der erste ¹¹⁸ deutsche Prozess gegen Einsatzgruppentäter. Die Besonderheit des Falls Martin Weiss," in Martin Cüppers, Jürgen Matthäus, and Andrej Angrick (eds.), *Naziverbrechen. Täter, Taten & Bewältigungsversuche* (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 2013), 303-318. Lukiškės Prison.¹¹⁹

says, we were arrested there, and Gens cried like a little boy. In the morning they released us and sent us back to the ghetto. Me, after this incident, after years that I told this story, people don't want to believe. Anyway, I didn't invent the name Moyshe Brauze, people know him. And they know he was like this, he was killed with Glasman in the blockade, in Glasman's group with his wife. After he was killed, Dov Levin once said, Professor Dov Levin¹²⁰ once said, if it's a witness who is not alive and you can't ask him, then it's a problem he said. I don't know, today I'm alive and tomorrow not, so what I passed on, when I was alive it is true, and after death, it's no longer true?

Interviewer [00:13:08]:

Do you know by any chance who else did Aryeh [should be Moyshe] Brauze tell this?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:14]:

I don't know. I don't know. I I saw him there for a short period.

Interviewer [00:13:19]

He told you this personally?

Moshe Shutan [00:13:20]:

Personally, yes. Personally, personally. We sat, we talked. With me, usually, not just Moyshe Brauze talked, I also spoke with Glasman, I talked, and I talked to Mirka Ganionski, if you heard, a young woman who was in the the FPO. Years later I read Dworzecky. Dworzecky, in his book Vilna

Interviewer [00:14:01]:

Jerusalem of Lithuania

Moshe Shutan [00:14:04]:

Jerusalem... no... destruction, the destruction of Vilna.¹²¹ Not exactly. "*Vilna In Camp un umakom*" in Yiddish. So he wrote there that they brought the *Shalonim* to the police station, the they arrested Gens and Gens was in detention all night. I didn't know Dworzecky, I didn't know of this story, but he had it too. They asked me, Who told you

Dov Levin's testimony is preserved at the Fortunoff Archive, HVT-1807.¹²⁰
Mark Dworzecky, *Jerusalem of Lithuania in Revolt and in the Holocaust*.¹²¹

that he was there and participated with everyone? So I said in my heart, So, there may be more like this, there may be a policeman who was left alive, but if you give me one person who will come and say, I was a policeman in the ghetto, then I will agree to it. I was a partisan, I hid with Gentiles, I was in the camps, but for someone to say, I was a policeman – not one has the courage to say this hard truth. I won't say terrible truth, but a hard one. And there were people like that. There were people who were policeman and knew and did not know. I see it as my duty to tell this incident, because it's said of Gens that he helped the Germans murder Jews, and some Jews claim that he helped the Germans murder family members, acquaintances. If there is a trial, then we need both sides. I'm not saying that those who claim that because of him, their acquaintances died, I don't say that they're wrong, because everyone see things from their point of view, but even if it's so, and I agree with it, but if there are things that he did for the good, then that too should be passed on. And that's why I saw it as important, to tell this story. I wrote a book, *Ghetto and Woods*, and in this book I write about this incident. I spoke once with Antek Zukerman,¹²² so he said, How can this be, it hasn't happened in all of conquered Europe that one Jew raises his pistol against a German. If you look into Gens's character, I think you could come to the conclusion that he had that courage. He could have run away from the ghetto easier than other Jews could have. He walked without a Jewish star, he had the help of the police, of Lithuanian officers, they say that even when Kittel called him, Not Kittel, Neugebauer, he called him to come to him and that would be his end – they say that this Weiss, that he threatened him, said to him, Don't go, and he went. And if he went, then I, according to all my estimation of the situation in the ghetto, especially the Wittenberg incident, then I see the fact that he, although he delivered Wittenberg to the Germans, it doesn't matter that later they released him, but the very fact that he delivered, that he said This is Wittenberg, with that he signed his own death warrant. Why? Why? Because if he had come to the forest, the Jews would kill him. And that raises the question, why would the Jews kill him? Because there was an incident in Rudnitzka Poshtza (Rudniki Forest), where they killed four guys from Vilna Ghetto, they were policemen in the ghetto.¹²³ The Lithuanians and the Russian partisans didn't know who was a policeman and who was not a policeman. So it appears that someone from the Jews, some went and told on them and then killed them. Obviously, these ones, if Gens was in their hands, first and foremost they would do it. And I think if the move he did - and he went and Weiss told him this would be your end – then maybe he chose instead of dying like the Jewish traitor, better to die as a Jew at the hands of the German, because he could always have run away. He wasn't in jail, he could have gotten help to hide, but that's what he chose. He didn't leave the

Antek Zuckerman (Yitzhak Zuckerman, 1915-1981) was a prominent leader of the Warsaw Ghetto Uprising and deputy commander of the Jewish Fighting Organization (ŻOB), who later became one of the founders of Kibbutz Lohamei HaGeta'ot and a key figure in preserving the memory of Jewish resistance during the Holocaust.

On this incident, see Ozacki Stern, "Executions of Jewish Partisans in the Lithuanian Forests – The Case of Natan Ring."¹²³

ship, he was with it to the end. This is actually the story, the episode with Gens and what happened at the trains station.

Interviewer [00:21:09]:

This thing he told you, Brauze, did you also tell people there? After Brauze told you the story?

Mosh Shutan [00:21:18]:

No, no, I didn't tell. There were other problems, there were always problem. But to sit down with someone, to talk about Vilna Ghetto, I talked to Glasman, I talked to Brauze, I talked to Mirka Ginionsky. Why Mirka Ginionsky? In the FPO there was, how shall I tell you, a platoon, like they say, Shin Bet (internal police). And Glasman was the commander of this platoon. Against traitors, against people received, to see if they are people you can count on. And Mirka Ginionsky worked in the platoon. She said to me, for instance, I talked to Desler, and he says he knows you, and he praised you, she says. This, I didn't talk, only when I came to Israel when I heard, everything was black before. In the beginning, all the policemen were black, all the Judenrat guys were in not a good state, that they said they were traitors; but slowly, with time, they started to find out each one separately how he was, what he was, so the attitude towards them changed a little. Usually there were policemen who helped; who were in the police and helped me. Like, in Kailis, they helped me enter Kailis, they told me things that I write about in the book. Also about Gens, by chance, about Gens – they asked him for people for Minsk and he had, he gave; they told me about the conflict he had with Yosef Glasman, they told me about [00:23:40] Tsefki Bialek [00:23:41] where I write about the boy who was beaten by the German and then Gens took his *nageika*, the stick, and he carried on. All these things I heard from a policeman.

Interviewer [00:24:04]:

The meeting with Glasman – did you ever talk about the group's exit?

Moshe Shutan [00:24:09]:

About what?

Interviewer [00:24:10]:

About the exit of Glasman's group from Vilna to the forest, did you speak to him about that also?

Moshe Shutan [00:24:16]:

No, no. What I spoke with him, they were suspicious of me. Since he was in the platoon of the.... They suspected me of being guilty of what happened in Lavorišké, where there was the ambush and they lost dozens of people, and Sonya Madeisker talked to me, I told about this. I told them, But you.... Nu, you didn't hide, but you didn't want to say that the group is leaving, so I didn't know. So Glasman says to me, you know I told him the story, all of it, how they didn't tell me that I talked to Gens about partisans, so he says to me, You know what, so you go to Jurgis. Jurgis was the commissar of the Lithuanian Brigade. And tell him, tell him your story. That's called, that someone told him about him a different story, and who told him, that's clear. This is story that was with Gens, the rest of the things that happened. I spoke about it, that Jews did, Jews, that they were policemen. I had the same case in the forests of Narocz. A group from the ghetto came, and among them was the general secretary of the criminal police, Margolis, that, while they examined me and beat me, he was there, and he even said to me, Look, young man, it's better that you say what they're asking you, and if not, it will be very bad. The guys knew what happened with me in the Jewish police and that he came to the forest. So some of them come, Moyshe, do you know? Here's Margolis, now you can take revenge. I looked at them – the partisan had a special unit for partisan security, not like the NKVD, but they would call them, in Russian, "*Osovi Ozdye*", that they looked for people who were not safe, who were traitors. If I'd gone to them and told them, Here, this guy served in the Jewish police and he helped in the investigation against me and they beat me up, then for them, to finish someone off, it was, it wouldn't be a problem at all. So I said, I looked like this, Jews from the ghetto, even my acquaintances, my friends, come to me and say to me, hand in a Jew so that they will kill him. There were many Ukrainians who came to the forest and maybe collaborated with Germans, who murdered lots of Jews, and they received them and they knew who they were, and not one person killed them, and they said, With their blood, they will cleanse themselves of the bad things they did. So we as Jews in this case would be worse than the Russians. I told them, No, you will not go. They said to me, If you don't go, we will go. I said to them, You will not go, and they didn't go. In the end, he also died, Margolis, with Glasman's group in the blockade.

Interviewer [00:29:17]:

But you could... did you talk to him? Something happened to him with the partisans, I mean, this is still a person who demands some kind of an explanation, how did you behave like this? Or why did you behave like this? Why did you behave like this?

Moshe Shutan [00:29:32]:

Towards Margolis? I didn't want to talk about it. He saw me once. Put his head down. I didn't say anything to him, he didn't say anything to me. Not by my hands, I said. That's one of the stories about cases that were in the partisans, also about Jews.

Interviewer [00:30:04]:

Do you think that there should be the same justice, the same law, for antisemites who murdered Jews and Jews who collaborated and...

Moshe Shutan [00:30:22]:

Look, if we're talking about Jews, then this, it's a very sad affair. There are some among them who were very cruel, there's nothing else to say, they didn't behave nice, especially the police. I say like this, if – say – if the Judenrat exists, and the Jewish police is part of the Judenrat, but I see a difference between the Judenrat and the police. Ask me why. The man sitting inside the Judenrat, as a judenratnik there are situation where he needs to think how to behave, so he's a man who thinks. If there's a man who thinks, he's got something of humanity, but in the police there those who didn't think anything, they gave an order and they executed it without thinking anything and with cruelty in addition. I don't say about everyone, but there were those.

Interviewer [00:31:41]:

To some extent Gens was there in that, Gens was head of the police in the ghetto for a long time.

Moshe Shutan [00:31:49]:

He was head of the police, but let's say there was the incident with Oshmiana, he sent Dessler with the police, he wasn't there. When they had to move the Jews from Świąciany, so he came to us and explained. I say like this, any thinking person - he's got a spark of a man. One who does not think, he only receives orders, and executes them, and with cruelty. And if there are some like that who are caught after the war, they caught them personally, if there is someone whom he, personally, did something to him, and he told about him and they arrested him and judged him, that is correct. I told you that the court didn't [00:33:04] *Effenmeschenitz* [00:33:05] doesn't deal with revenge but with justice. This is justice, to accuse and convict a murderer is justice. That's how I see things. But if there are cases where we don't know, or that you know, and a long time has passed, then I said, I talked to you, that the victory, I see the victory over Germany as the pinnacle of revenge. Because the Germans, they were willing to have another five million Germans die, if only they win. It wasn't important to them, victory was important to them, and they lost. Eichmann's trial was right after the war, everything was still fresh, in the memory, in the pain of people, but time lessens this

feeling, and if we have, if we've got a Demianiuk - so I told you I spoke to a lawyer, Leonardo, from the US, from Los Angeles, who told me we're at Wiesenthal's institute, Shimon Wiesenthal. So I told him, I wouldn't deal with it now. So he says to me, Where's *justice*, Where's justice? So I said to him, because the world does not proceed according to justice, but according to interests. That's my approach, personally.

Interviewer [00:35:09]:

Moshe about.... You also met Wittenberg. How... what character did Wittenberg have? Who was he?

Moshe Shutan [00:35::18]

According to how I saw him, he was a closed person. Maybe with friends he was open, but to me he was closed, spoke very little, asked a lot. A man who thinks, who talks, he didn't talk in a flow, but he thought of every word he said. To say if he was more sure of himself, an independent man, so I said that as soon as Gens gave him in, so for him it wasn't a surprise. Because it was known, Gens goes with the Germans, executes the German orders, the FPO are against the Germans, and they are enemies. I don't know if that's the word exactly, if enemies is appropriate here, because they were both Jews, but according to the situation, how they acted in the situation, so Wittenberg - it wasn't a surprise that Gens told him, here's Wittenberg. Because he considered Gens all the time, not just him, the entire HQ of the FPO, the majority, the friends of, the majority, I can't say everyone, I don't know, but the majority thought that he was, they saw him as a traitor. I see in it that And he wanted to hide, he wanted to, he didn't want to go to the Germans. Wittenberg, he dressed up as a woman, but as soon as his friends, that he was already in the hands of his friends and they had to talk about what to do, practically, according to the regulations of the FPO, then the situation came for them, even if they didn't know that this can happen, that Jews will come and say because of one man we need to die, and they told him that he has to give himself up to the Germans. And Gens told me, Do you know why he went? He said, like [00:38:08] a minister he [00:38:08] went. Because he believed that he has friends.

Interviewer [00:38:13]:

We, the issue is that

Moshe Shutan [00:38:15]

Already... yes, there was....

Interviewer [00:38:16]

Yes, we recorded this, correct.

Moshe Shutan [00:38:17]

OK, I will carry on. This is an argument that requires clarifications, testimonies.

[00:38:46]:

No we, among all the decrees that came to the Jews, there were from the Nazis, from the Germans, especially from the Germans, because the Jews did not lack enemies. There were also among the Poles, also among the Lithuanians, the Ukrainians, I don't know how they were in the Arab countries, but where I was. So my teacher, Devorah Fisher, that we learned in school, one time they sent her to Germany in the '20s as part of a delegation to visit the German schools. And after she came back from there, she would always tell us about this visit, and when I was in school, that was already in the '30s. So what did she tell about the Germans? She says we came to Germany and then we came to one school. We enter the school yard, quiet, total quiet. We thought, she says, that it's the lesson time. To our surprise we enter a hallway, and we saw that all the children are outside and there's no lesson, and they're talking among themselves quietly, playing quietly. What order, she says, what discipline, how cultured they are, she says, we should learn from the German children how to behave. And she always praised them. These children killed her. In the '40s they were already army men.

Interviewer [00:41:11]:

Moshe, let me wipe the corner of your mouth.

Moshe Shutan [00:41:23]:

Now, what did I learn from the Holocaust? I went through enough, I saw enough. When we studied history in school, we learned about the Vandals, the barbarians, and since it was evident to anyone who studied history, that this is a wild thing, wild people were the barbarians, inhuman. So if the whole world knows about it, then certainly it will not happen again. That's what we thought. But we saw that not everyone learns from history, some do learn, but not everyone. There's something cruel about people who don't want – it's hard to say this – when you analyze people's situations, people do say that there are murderers, bandits, but that usually there are inhuman – this we don't talk about. There is an issue with unpredictable [people]. So it is known, this is an unpredictable person, for instance about Hitler, they also said that he, he was unpredictable. But the problem with saying, not with those who are unpredictable, these

we know, but the so-called normal people. And that's the problem that was, it exists and it continues. I learned from the Holocaust, among other things, that I am very wary and afraid of three types of people. The first, someone with influence, wise, who has an answer to every question. I am afraid of these people. The second sort is the crowd who enters an ecstasy after the speech of some leader with dictatorial tendencies; I am also afraid of these people. And I am afraid of those who don't think, there are people who don't think. And this – I spoke before about them, that they asked the Germans how did you do it, so they said, We were little clerks and we only followed orders. So if orders, then in the end the order comes that Hitler is guilty of everything; one man is guilty of everything. Is it possible that one man could have done all the horrors they did? Without these people, without those who do not think, these careerists who looked for positions of power, for favors, without these people, they're not necessarily bad, but without these types, the evil people like Hitler would have been equal to nothing. He couldn't have done anything. And they are also dangerous. Maybe not inside their consciousness, but that's the way it is. That's what I learned from the Holocaust. Because I saw people in different and strange situations that in a usual time, in a time of peace, it doesn't happen.

[00:46:46]:

Now I will speak of what is most painful for me from the Holocaust. Obviously, I lost my family, relatives; acquaintances, friends, all the victims that were, Jews and non-Jews, but in the sea of these victims, I see a lone sailboat above the water, and the name of the sailboat, of this sailboat is David Luzhek. Who was David Luzhek? David Luzhek was a 13.5 year old boy. You could say it, I don't want to say genius, because it's not accepted to say 'genius' about children of this age. He has the head of a genius, but you don't say he's already a genius. But David Luzhek knew more – not just more than the friends and students who studied with him, he knew more than the teachers who taught him. In Soviet Russia, there were 10 classes before university. He entered the fifth class, from fifth he went to the seventh, from the seventh he was meant to go to the ninth. In terms of knowledge, he knew geology, geography, astronomy, algebra, physics, chemistry, literature. In all disciplines he had an open mind. I remember I had to learn a poem and I was lazy, I wanted to be better, to go walking, so I went with him on a walk. I knew I would walk and learn the poem. Because he, any poem I needed, he knew by heart. He read it once and it was enough. He read Goethe in German, Faust. And quoted whole pages, by heart. I talked to him once and he says to me like this, Moshe, did you prepare the physics lesson? I told him, No. So he answers me like this: For you to know the physics lesson, you have to read it once; someone else has to read it ten times. But you should know, that if you don't read it that one time, and he will read it only once, if you don't read at all and he reads it once, he will know more than you. I asked him chemistry, how does he know chemistry so well, he knew all the elements, all their signs. He knew their specific gravity, how many electrons are in every atom of all the elements. So I asked him, David, how do you know all this? When did you have time to get all this in your head? So he says to me, look, I was in the

village, I lived. My father was a pharmacist, and we had a pharmacy, and I would go with the children to play. So they would shout at me, *Zhid*, they beat me up. So I was afraid, and for lack of choice I would go in the house. And there were notebooks of the father, who studied in university, since he was a chemist he studied chemistry, so I would sit with that - he says - and read it.

Interviewer [00:51:55]:

Where was he from?

Mosh Shutan [00:51:57]:

Doglishek, it's not far from Święciany.

Interviewer [00:52:01]:

Where did you meet him?

Mosh Shutan [00:52:03]:

In Święciany, during the Soviets he came to Święciany to study in high school.

Interviewer [00:52:55]:

What happened to him in the end?

Moshe Shutan [00:52:37]

Yes, he knew eight languages. He read Faust in German, he read Sankiewicz in Polish, he read the Russian authors in Russian. He knew Lithuanian, Yiddish, Hebrew, Ukrainian – he quoted Shevchenko in Ukrainian, Yanko Koplov in Bellorussian, and if you think there are languages close to one another, but to know a language well, that is close to another, to speak correctly- that is more difficult than two languages that are not all similar to each other. And he got along with everyone. Since he was so strong in... physics, algebra, so I told him, What do you think, what will you study.

Interviewer [00:53:56]:

What are you?

Mosh Shutan [00:52:57]:

What will you study? Will you be an engineer, will you be a scientist. And he says to me, without thinking much, I will be a professor of literature. Because man, he says, is the most complex creature in the universe. He chose not to study people through history, he didn't study, he didn't go study people through psychology, he chose literature, through literature. When I think about him, it's hard to forget a child like that, he was also a good friend to me. Sometimes I think, why did I remain and he didn't do anything in order to be saved; there can be an argument about that. Only one thing is clear, that he was a rare pearl among the Jewish people and all of humanity. And if the *shkotzim* took his childhood in the village, then came the Germans and took his life. If there is matter, then he was entirely spirit, and that's the cruelty of periods like that, that not, you can't differentiate between men, but look who were the victims among the victims, what people they were. And this was for us the *velosst*, a great loss. Now I want to end, I want to speak, to thank my friends, thanks to them I wasn't alone in the struggle. In the little that we did, you always thought that you have a friend who thinks like you, works like you, helps you, lends a hand. I want to mention those who fell. Like David Yochai, Yoskeh Rodnitzky, Shaykeh Gertman, Skholka Wolfson, Lyebkeh Gurevich, Shaykeh Levin, and the list goes on. I want I appreciate those who remained alive, and among them one of the heroes, the true heroes in fighting against the Germans, and that's Boris Yochai. He participated with a group in taking down German trains, he participated in 18 actions like that, and many times he was also the commander of those units. Among them were Itzkeh Rodnitzk, Froymeh Zulesky, Tavkeh Bromberg, who are alive, some live in Israel, some in the US. And thanks to them, I could hang in there and do the little I did, and in that I thank them and wish those who are alive a long life and that we stay friends like we were then. That's it.

Interviewer [00:59:58]:

When did you come to Israel?

Moshe Shutan [00:59:59]:

Excuse me?

Interviewer [01:00:00]

When did you come to Israel?

Mosh Shutan [01:00:03]:

In January '49, via Cyprus. I sat two years in a camp in Cyprus, the English caught us and brought us there.¹²⁴ From Russia I left in December 1946 via Poland, Czechoslovakia, France, Cyprus, and Israel.

Interviewer [01:00:41]:

Did you join the army?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:43]:

Excuse me?

Interviewer [01:00:44]:

Did you join the army?

Moshe Shutan [01:00:46]:

From the boat they took me straight into the army. I was a year here in the army, but it was already after the ceasefire. There was no war. They said in the army that one should go to settle, I was five years in a village... because of personal and social reasons I left the village and moved to the city.

Interviewer [01:01:20]:

Was the adjustment to Isarel difficult? Was it difficult to adjust to Israel?

Moshe Shutan [01:01:26]:

My wife tells me, you live like you just emerged from the forest. I think that is enough to answer your question. I went to work in building most of my time in Isarel, not most, I also worked other jobs, but most of my jobs I worked in building as a floor layer, countertop installer, five years I worked in the nursing school by Ichilov. I retired, and now I still continue to work in building, and I hope for a good future.

The British detention camps in Cyprus (1946-1949) held approximately 52,000 Jewish Holocaust ¹²⁴ survivors and displaced persons who were intercepted while attempting to illegally reach Mandatory Palestine. They served as internment facilities that became a symbol of the struggle for Jewish statehood and the plight of Holocaust survivors seeking refuge.